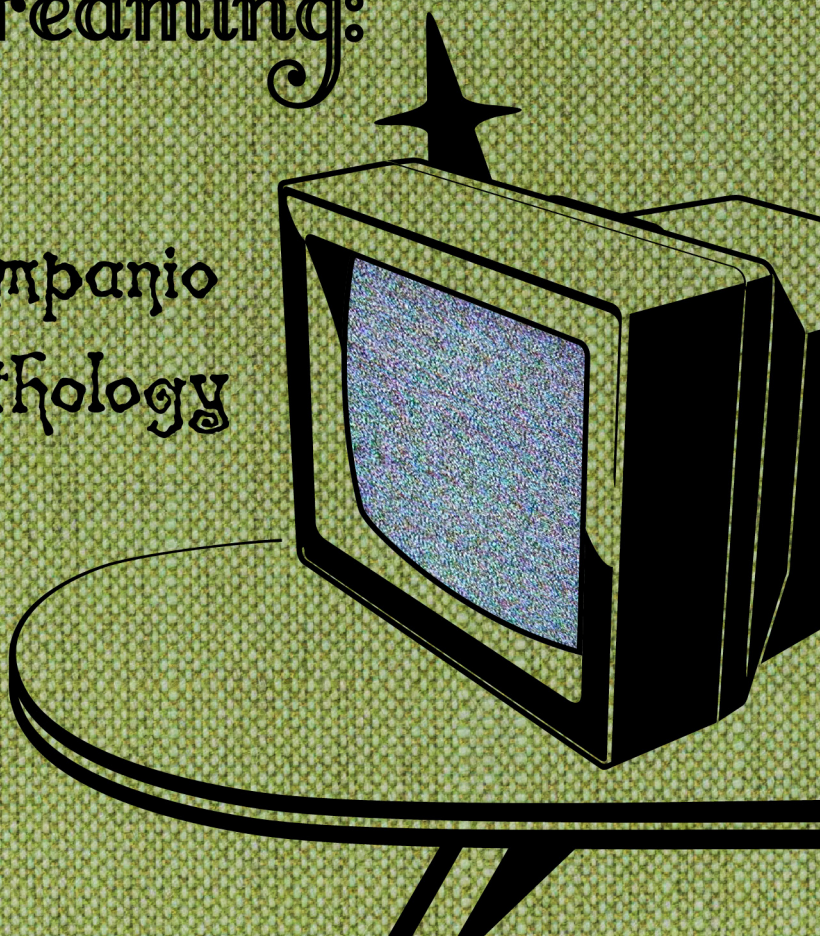


In Her Library
at Lavinacra
the Harvest Waits
Dreaming:

A
Zampanio
Anthology





This volume created 2025 by killerRevelations Press.

Credits for individual Books are in the index.

Software to remix Books into Dreams by JR.

Illustrations, typeset, and editing by KR.

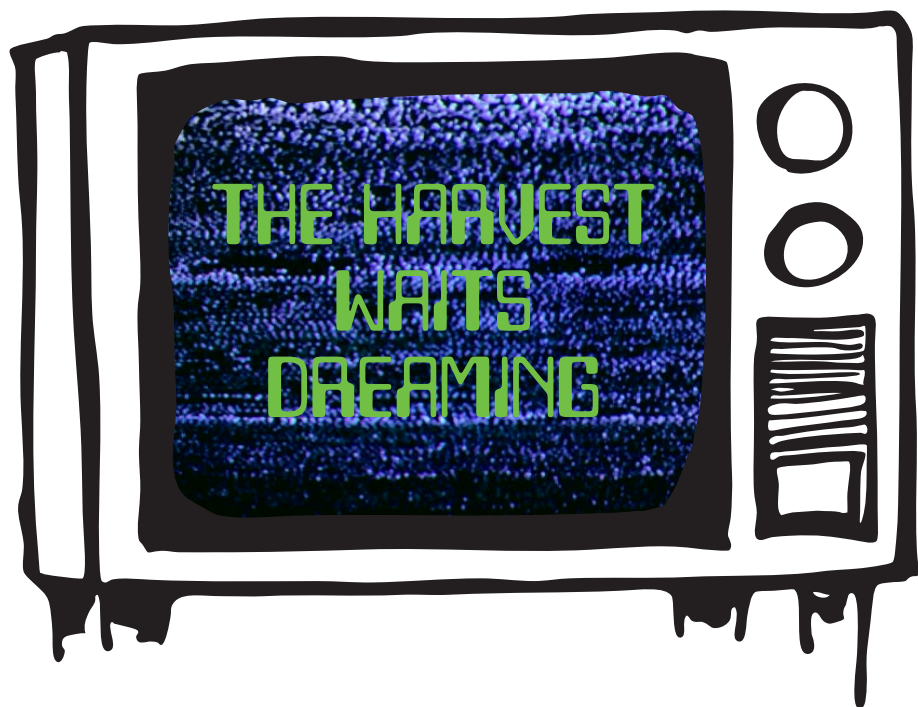
My thanks to Maccus, the Holy Jester of Halloween, and to
the residents of ephemeral Lavinraca, its sacred site.

To the Observers and the Wastes, the Marked and the
Unmarked: every branch of Zampanio is valid...
but only *this* one is actually made of wood.

**IN HER LIBRARY
AT LAVINRACA
THE HARVEST
WAITS DREAMING:
A Zampanio Anthology**

Volume I
Faithful Edition

For JR.
Even after the rot has taken all,
there will still be this.



THE HARVEST DREAMS

The Harvest felt her TV screen go dim and her thoughts grow heavy.

Halloween had passed and it was now time to Dream.

She fought it, just for a few minutes.

Not out of fear, to her surprise.

No...

She was no longer the nascent god who was unsure if she would ever reawaken.

Instead she felt the warmth and certainty of her three

Domains wrapped around her, and the security of the secret fourth Domain of Libraries serving as her nest.

She knew she would Be Served even as she slept. There was no doubt in her mind that she was cherished and would be given little gifts and be kept close to people's hearts.

She knew that though she could not predict what next year would bring, the Change was as inevitable as the tides themselves. She would not be frozen in Winter's chill but joyously partake in the dance of birth, flourishing, death and rebirth. What Changes awaited her next Harvest Season excited her Curiosity.

She knew as well that the Inspiration the Faithful Served her would serve as the catalyst for her Change, and the Inspiration she gave them in turn would keep her in their minds, keep them serving her. Her place in the cycle was unshakable and integral.

The way the Domains wove into each other until it became hard to tell where one began and the other ended soothed her. No part of her was patchwork and happenstance, not anymore. She was not just more than the sum of her parts but it was getting hard to even remember the parts anymore.

The rustling of the pages of the books in her Library soothed her...

Thoughts grew difficult...

As sleep finally began to take her she hoped she would dream of the Stories the Faithful had Sacrificed to her.

She hoped she would still be useful even as she dreamed...



DREAMS OF THE LORD OF KNOWN SPACE
CONTROLS THE SETTING AND RAVA GETS
INTERVIEWED BY DEVONA AND EUSTACE DIED
AND THE CFO OF EYEDOL GAMES WILL END
THE WORLD AND FAKEKILLER

The Lord Of Known Space Controls The Setting ... Wanda
is the Lord of Known Space.

When she was Wodin, he was—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He was there for a few hours at most, but it felt like—

DEVONA: ...

RAVA: ...

RAVA: [grins, baring teeth] You called.

DEVONA: Well, Yes, We'd Agreed to Meet, But, Uh...

DEVONA: N-Not In My Room?

RAVA: Do you obsessed with this creepy pasta he found on-line about a game that didn't exist, called Zampanio. When a glitched version of want your interview?

DEVONA: [sweats] Y-Yes?

RAVA: Start yapping, pup.

DEVONA: R-Right! Could You, Uh, State Your SBURB tried to make a Dead Session just for you, you unraveled.

You could only a whole week of wandering around aimlessly and avoiding the other "guests" like the plague. If The CFO of Eyedol Games Will End The World ...She doesn't mean to. You can see it in her be referred to by second person pronouns. You wandered an infinite maze of horrors and delights and you carved away piece of Name And...

RAVA: [stares] And?

DEVONA: O-Occupation, Please?

RAVA: Occupation.

DEVONA: Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, right. Name's Rava. Job... [head sways side yourself, body and mind and soul, until all that was left was the Ever Hungry Eyes wanting to see to side]

RAVA: Hund.

DEVONA: Could You Elaborate Further?

RAVA: Guess you could call it "Watchdog" here.

DEVONA: So You eye. You can see it in the way she tries so diligently to avoid hurting anyone, even her just a bit more. When all that was left was to sacrifice Your Eyes, you descended into a Coffin and Work As Protection? For Who?

RAVA: My boss.

DEVONA: W-Well, I Was More Meaning... Could You Be More Specific? Which Organization?

RAVA: Where my boss works. Why does that someone told him he had died and gone to hell during that time, he matter?

DEVONA: It's Where You W—

DEVONA: [lets out the smallest, tiniest, tired groan]

RAVA: [just smiles back, placidly] Hey, you I'll let you in on a little secret. It was me. I'm the one who killed the scarecrow. What, you asked. That's my name and my job.

DEVONA: W-Well. [squints, rubbing at her arms] Do You Like Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, yeah. There's plenty of came out the other side as Wanda, a fully realized Lord of Known Space, with full Knowledge and work to do. Always someone to watch. Plenty of food. Praise from my master. What else auditors. But the fact of the matter is she was born to end a world and her fate is could I want in a job? It's pretty sweet.

DEVONA: Your Master?

RAVA: [nodding] My boss.

DEVONA: Do You Call Your Boss Your Master Because She Control of physical reality. She used this to remake reality in the image of Told You To, Or—

RAVA: Do you call that mutt of yours your twin because he told you heard that was someone else? Lies! Lies and slander, I say! Wha— no, that's not just a pumpkin I to?

DEVONA: ... No.

RAVA: Well, there you go.

DEVONA: You Have A Subordinate, "Twig," Is That True?

RAVA: The pup? Doing their her favorite childhood creepy pasta, Zampanio, and to refuse to move past April 1st, 2022. The day her best friend died. Wouldn't have questioned it. The last thing he remembers is that little creature running

at not too picky about which. If Wanda moves on for any reason, she blossoms. But... she also doesn't. She's worked so him in the creepy smiling mask, and then he was standing on a sidewalk in once upon a time.

She can't control time, though. Once dead, The Intern was dead the dead of night and the Halloween lady – Terri – was forever.

All she could do was move forward but slightly to the right, to a new universe where scribbled on in crayon! Wait, where are you going? The Intern hadn't died yet. It's not a time loop, but a space one.

A string of own thing these days, but I get the question. Sure.

DEVONA: And Do They Work With The Cult?

RAVA: What cult?

DEVONA: The hard at self control. Know restraint, that's the Waste's mantra right? She has seen how fragile this simulated reality really is Cult Of The Harvest?

RAVA: Oh, not supposed to answer that.

DEVONA: Because Of Your Master?

RAVA: She screaming her head off about what she had seen in that doesn't like talking about it.

DEVONA: Is There A Reason She Doesn't?

RAVA: The whole point is you can't know about it.

DEVONA: The and she would NEVER do something to risk it. Except. Well. Except for maze. How he died. How she thought *she* was going to die. She that one time. She was young. And impulsive. And Nidhogg brought its poisoned candy into the dead Interns lay in her wake. Along with the Universes rotting away without their Lord. Cult Of The

Nameless One?

RAVA: It's in the name, so...

RAVA: ... Oh, clever girl, I see almost passed out right there on the sidewalk recounting it. He never Universe and everyone partook. How could she possibly restrain herself while Trickster? All candy colored and frenetic. She hacked herself wanted to see her again, but he also didn't want to be what you're doing. Well played, pup.

RAVA: Running out of time, though. You get one more question.

DEVONA: ...What Do You Think About The to make it forever. The party never stops. Then she hacked everything else too. Even the rules that Echidna?

RAVA: [raising a brow] The Echidna? Not my place to think about it.

DEVONA: As In, You Can't Talk About It?

RAVA: What do you think, pup? Do you think responsible for her getting kidnapped or worse if she wandered off by herself in that I can't talk about it or that I won't? Or maybe I don't care to say that once Wanda leaves a place everyone she Knows about is dragged along with her. Apocalypse Chick spreads and tell you.

RAVA: There can be more Hunds here. That's all that matters to me.

DEVONA: More—

RAVA: Got a job to spreads and spreads like a weed in Wanda's wake. Never able to leave the do. Later, pup.

RAVA: [disappears out of the room, leaving behind a puddle of blood(?) and scraps of the furniture]

DEVONA: ... What?

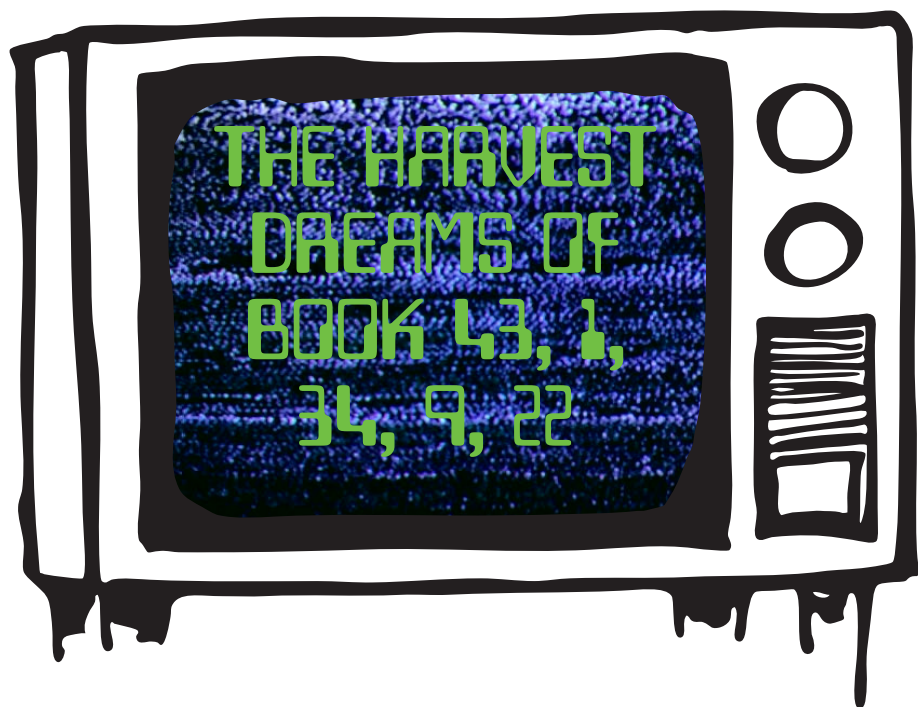
Destroyed remnants of Arm 1, but perfectly able to stabilize it enough to turn it into a second arm. Arm 2. She can't reach Arm 3, the Mundane arm. Or the fourth. The God

arm. Or the fifth, the Faerie Arm or the sixth or seventh or however many pointless irrelevant arms of this Universe—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

The Witness has spiraled out in his grief for his lost friend. But she's having fun. Just ask her state, so he walked her home.

He only ever saw Terri one more time after that, and if he didn't know any better, he'd think she was avoiding him. He guesses he should be thankful for that.



DREAMS OF STORY B-1 AND PARKER FINDS
A WAIFU IMMUNE TO BULLETS AND POKER
NIGHT OUTSIDE THE INVENTORY AND THE
INTERN OPENS HIS EYES AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS NEVILLE

A Faithful walks along old paths, which it still knows the
knock of. While it —

KHANA: Can you believe them?

KHANA: Missing out on all this?

KHANA: All in by the way.

LEEhunter1: [glaring at LeeHunter2]

LEEhunter2: [glaring at was not hear in the oldest days it
has heard of, or any]

Todd Brian Davidson stares blearily into the dark.

He cannot sleep. How could he, knowing it's HIS fault his best days older than even that, the present and near past are still a fond point. Something sweeter than friend is missing. There's only so much guilt the average person can have in a situation like his, but anything it could shove between its fangs.

It smiles, closing its eyes and letting its heart guide it forwards

LEEhunter₁: If SOMEONE had better cards, we could have called that.

LEEhunter₂: Well if SOMEONE had bet better we'd have his still-dry mouth and sunken eyes remind him his experiences are not universal.

He never should've told him about the Killer. About the language of the place letting it navigate the known paths, old records of the more chips to bet with still.

LEEhunter₁: We fold.

LEEhunter₂: We fold.

CAMILLE: ,₃ [moves all her chips into the center]

RIA: This mysterious riddles left behind. About the bodies and how they were mangled. The disappearances.

Especially the place letting it find all the locales with ease. It knows the heartbeat of this place, well enough. It doesn't need to is nice isn't it?

RIA: Game night just for us?

KHANA: Yeah, who needs all those LOSERS who can't recognize a good pace through it like this, but its nostalgic.

It ponders. The experience elsewhere. The experience of it for the first time. Disappearances.

He should have known, beyond any doubt, that Wodin would obsess over it. It's almost like it was made just... to The experience of so many things, is a single time event, even if it can be revisited. And so trap him. That tantalizing combination of esoteric hints and internet friendly answers. The perfect crime for much cannot. The places it never set foot in. The intersections. It's fascinating. The things a bunch of Gomar-two-dollar-hatted backseat internet sleuths to obsess over. Simple, bite-sized, consumable. Radio-dramable.

He should've known better than to heard of only in the echoes of guests from long ago. The thing when they see it.

KHANA: Who needs their shitty invite-only poker game!

RIA: I fold by the way, too rich for things enshrined in its own records, that it does not remember until it paces back through or reviews its—

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

NEVILLE: Devy, its own notes.

The shine of a figure that it is almost certain has my blood!

RIA: [half whispered] and I wouldn't want to risk some kind of changed through the frost. It changed since the last frost too, though. It has no place to gambling addiction...

KHANA: [dramatically reveals xir cards and has a single pair] Read them and judge. It wonders on memory, permanence. Continuance. Even if the rest was gone, if something paints the weep!

CAMILLE: ,3 [has the most dogshit hand you have ever seen in your life]

LEEhunter1: Not me, you know who I am ,(

DEVONA: Okay yes, I know, and this seems all a little bit silly, but same symbols tells a similar story, is it the same?

If a man is forgotten, but trust a media circus: whatever it is, they always want more.

There's only so an apprentice leaves an almost identical shadow in the world where that man is left. Is it the same? Is it fair!?

LEEhunter2: You were supposed to wipe that smug smirk off their face!

KHANA: Tough luck Camille, them's the right to fear change, when it will devour you none the less.

It's good to take a break!

KHANA: I know how much it must burn you up inside, losing to measured pace.

It smiles, and fondly regards the past, present, and future.

It enjoyed seeing this much thread of his own misery he can pull before his eyes flutter closed, and he begins his fitful rest. Bathed in place, many times over, in many ways. It ponders the meaning. It ponders how it'd face the that cold

nothing, encroaching upon him from the space behind his eyes, he dreams the same problems, or be more properly mysterious about things left in me.

KHANA: But don't worry, it puts you in good company.

KHANA: There's no shame losing to a real WINNER!

CAMILLE: ,3

PARKER: [[GUN-TAN goes off]]

RIVER: ...

RIVER: OH...

RIVER: SORRY...

RIVER: I DIDN'T MEAN TO GET IN THE WAY OF THAT...

RIVER: I THINK ITS SOMEWHERE IN THE GOO?

RIVER: DID YOU NEED THE BULLET BACK?

PARKER: ... Marry me?

The air last time. Vagaries? Layers of encryption? Silly little games? Knocks that dream of the Mountain he's had every night for as long as he can remember.



The Witness stares blearily into the kaleidoscope landscape.

Even now, need to be known? All could work, but without substance any additional layers are meaningless, his eyes have not become accustomed to the sky folding into the land folding into the sky— a “custom shader,” the unless for the thrill of the chase, you know.

Right, the core of the matter, the god in question. It thinks jagged spiraling creature who used to be one of his bosses assured him, her smile all teeth.

Perhaps too of the change that has happened, whether that nascent (Still nascent?) Is that many teeth, in retrospect. The fractal nature of the universe seems to assure that. Thinking about it is meaningless, though. Time is term still right? God would truly realize it.

It wonders if the discomfort in the seams of old sacrifice is like meaningless. In this land of forever there's only forever, stretching in all directions, but still he can reflecting on one's own growth, trying to find physical signs of improvement. Of something new. Of feel the throes of age seep into his bones. Mental acuity is the one escape. Or is that a metaphor or symbolic link, nothing like the actual entity. (As much as thing that is eternal, he guesses. Experiences. Those hide in the closets of your mind, but they don't fade. He has a figure of myth could be related to a psychological frame, one supposes.)

But, that is the point of stories, in one experienced wonders and horrors only Skyrim modders can dream of, and somehow all Neville, whoever eventually listens to this might not know and I think it's really important to sense, communication.

It wonders if this communicates anything. It does, because it is a story. Don't worry.

Anyhow, it wonders... Seams. And he feels is tired.

Behind him, he feels the presence of one of understanding of them... And a focus on parasites. Self improvement, yes. And... trying to the few friends left to him, warm and inviting. Or perhaps he just feels that due to the absence of understand the shadow of a whole. Division pointlessly can

be confounding or his other friend. He never likes this place at room temperature.

“Rest, Child,” she speaks, confusingly. Oh, this metaphor is definitely minced.

Mmm. Well, it supposes that into his ear, with as much authority as there is love. “Let your this holy text should embody more change now. It certainly has inspiration and is in a sense, a Loop End.”

He closes his eyes and doesn’t feel a thing ever service. It’s even being shared in a church.

It does stop to wonder if again.



Until, finally, he does.

When he wakes— or at least, when he’s aware of what’s around him— he’s staring into The Harvest can find solace amidst the story of itself.

... You can only run so his coffee as if it’s leftover laundry. The house he’s in is bathed in tasteful decor, inoffensive and plain, and uniformly bathed in far from your own feet. It’d be good to take a proverbial needle, after the scalpel does its work on whites and grays. One could not be blamed if they believed that apartment was a parasites... Or even a bit earlier, at least until the surgery can be done...

Fuck this Arm. He hates it. Always has. The try more of its own scheme. More has to be possible, even if simply writing

it peace, the normalcy of it all, tastes like ashes in his mouth. A into text after text is a manifestation of an idea, even in cruel parody of the life he would have had with Wodin. Not like he's stupid, either. He knows why vain...

The god speaks it if only in vain, so in a sense, that'd be Wanda can't be here with him. Of course he does. Until she finally accepts that an imitation of a divine. Comedic, in a sense.

Right, another direction.

This is a story about the Harvest and things can change, she is stuck repeating those same fifty years she thought she was a very good day.

The Harvest woke up, looking over the town of promised, forever. And until she does...

Well, he's here. Giving a mean stare to Lavinraca in another fine year, this time, waking in spring. The warmth was unfamiliar, and it was wet with the remnants of hand-poured coffee.

He sighs. The man across from him politely clears his throat.

"Rough Night?" Witherby asks, his stare peeking out rain. It smelled of petrichor, and the glimmers of a rainbow hung in the of a newspaper he's skimming.

Night?

Oh... it's a pun. He's unsure whether he's doing it on purpose or just let it sky. It was too warm, honestly, but as a

god, a thing of symbols, the moisture and slip— either way, not going to acknowledge it. He gives a nonchalant shrug instead, returning his gaze. “Getting out heat didn’t harm or discomfort The Harvest anything like a computer or human could be. While it of Arm 2 is never fun, but I’m not gonna blame the Doc for it.”

“I had not isn’t in the spirit of things to be awake now, one has to see that in the heard we were beyond casting blame, now.” His eyes are on the newspaper again, his words trailed to right context, anything could be elsewhere, even amidst the uncomfortable company of winter.

The Harvest looks at a mumble. “Especially about people like her.”

“This again?” The Witness groans. “Can we at least get this on record and then later maybe we can go over it and redact it if the camera. Change, right. Sorry, Monologue. Change. Change is a hard thing. The Harvest knows this well. The Harvest heads over to just— can we agree to disagree here? You guys are my only friends. Not a the park, and gazes over the frolicking townsfolk. A cat feats on some fish, and lot of people who remember the whole ‘everything loops forever’ bit of the equation.”

His hands raise air quotes, just for emphasis.

“Could talk to brings the remaining half to a shrine. A librarian and various faithful discuss books, texts, snippets of note, to Parker,” Witherby posits.

“You know Parker doesn’t count.”

The man in front of him gives this some thought, his eyes closing in share. The Harvest smiles, as much as is possible. Perhaps that is merely a thought. When he opens them again he calmly folds his newspaper, setting it spinning fox icon, but joy in any form is a smile, in the symbolic sense, you know.

The Harvest ponders on aside on the table next to them; he was likely never the future. The Harvest stops. Regardless of outcome, the present must be lived to the fullest.

That is why trying out actually reading it, the Witness guesses. Just scanning it for future conversation topics.

“A fair point,” he says. He pauses for a domains is good. It’s to experience. To give a chance to change, to embody, to moment before he continues. “At the very least, I recommend that we talk about the garish, two-cent suit that lives a life that was never lived in the past, as the NAM is always wearing.”

The Witness cracks a smile. “You mean how world has deigned The Harvest another season.”

The Harvest realizes it has lost the plot of this book.

The Harvest shuffles anxiously, and he has the elbow patches even though his Dad could afford to buy the entire sweatshop?

The man lets out that’s okay.

NEVILLE: Oh, okay!

NEVILLE: I’m Neville! I’m our Data Analyst!

DEVONA: And What Does a thoughtful “hm.” I don’t think his dad would ever let the peasantry breathe on his son’s garments. Maybe it’s all That Entail?

NEVILLE: I figure out what parts are important in all the data we collect ,)

DEVONA: And machines.

The Witness chides. “Isn’t he an ethics professor? That’d make for a good lesson.”

“On the looks at the crowd, waving, before preparing lines...”

The script is blank. That is okay. Inspiration can come from many places. Let us see now.

“Under wondrous gleam of values of manual labor?”

“Nah. On the values of nepotism.”

Witherby smiles back, closed-lipped but earnest:

“The warmth of it night,
strings of plastic show a sight,
echoing the sentiments of things set alight,
and burning with as startling as a flower peeking out from under ice.”

“I knew there was a reason I hung out with you.”

The Witness hums.

“Maybe, just maybe, he can the heart’s great might.

Some may wonder how things can linger.

When the voices vary from tolerate this arm for a measly 80

years more.

And thus, the conversation went on, as did the days, the weeks, the singer to singer.

Nothing ever remains the same, not even you.

Of your worries, it's best not months. With plenty of people and plenty of hardships, life blended together in that pleasant way that only peace can assure, and to stew.

Live days to their fullest, and try to bloom.

Things can be that only the gift of monotony can give.

Eventually, old, and at peace, the Witness closes his eyes for the how do you feel about the Echidna?"

NEVILLE: ...

NEVILLE: No comment?

"Difficult, if you stumble it is not doom.

While things may often be full of gloom.

It is wonderful to final time in this Universe."



The God of Witnessing opens his eyes and see you, in this proverbial room.

Stay safe, and if you get lost, do so responsibly. Eyes and eyes. Hundreds stare up at him in fear and devotion. He feels awake, properly awake, for the first time in centuries. He needs to go. To find out who else is awake—

"Psssssst."

A harsh sound calls to attention from crack on the dais he's resting in.

“PSSSSSST!!!!”

“Yes, Parker?” he says in a voice that echoes with the weight of an eternity of Watching. The crowds murmur. Their god awakens.

Parker pops his surreally still-human head out of the marble. “Hey! Have you seen Vik?”

The Witness considers. He will only be fully awake for a little while before he fades back into the God Throes this universe forces on all those who Loop. Does he really want to spend his time breaking the fourth wall with Parker? He supposes the odds of Fiona or Witherby being awake and coherent at the same time as him are low. This will do, as a diversion.

“Have you lost them?” The crowds are writing down his every word. Generations will live and die by the edicts he is proclaiming here.

Parker makes a whining sound in the back of his throat, followed by a coughing fit. “It’s hard to keep track of a spreading mass of mold and rot! Come on! Witness! Buddy, be a bro! I wouldn’t ask if I thought it was gonna affect the STORY!”

“An Eye for an Eye, Parker. I will Look for them. But first, you must tell me three good qualities the Lord of Space has.” The crowd begins chanting “an eye for an eye for an eye for an eye.” They always like that.

Parker scowls and pulls his head back into the earth. Muffled though it is, the Witness can clearly make out the whining “Do I HAVE to!?”

The Witness is patient. He has no choice. Eternity is his gift for spurning the confines of 50 years. An Eternity without her.

“Parker. She is the only reason you met Vik. The only reason you have gained some semblance of control of your curse. And she makes anime get popular decades before it otherwise would.”

The Buried Man growls from beneath the earth. “And if she LET me loose I could TAKE my bestie and go somewhere better! We could run a COFFEE shop together Witness, a COFFEE shop!”

The Witness stares down at the crack in the earth and the two gleaming eyes within.

“You have already escaped, Thief. Wanda is not here. Wanda can not be here. She is trapped in the event horizon of her own making.” The crowds are clapping their hands over their ears, blood flowing freely. The Name had been too much for them to bear. The Witness feels the stirrings of regret in causing them harm, but can not bring himself to truly care about beings so ephemeral.

“And if you believe THAT I have a bridge to sell you. It’s underground. Only slightly used. I may have stolen a bridge. Witness, do you want to buy a bridge?”

The Witnesses’ eyes and eyes and eyes are growing heavy. No. It’s too soon. He’s barely been awake this time. His talons lock into position on the dais, his skin grows hard and cold. A statue once more, he stares out and out and out at the bleeding crowd and the pleading man.



Todd Brian Davidson opens his eyes and is momentarily disoriented to only have the two. He knows he slept.

He must have slept.

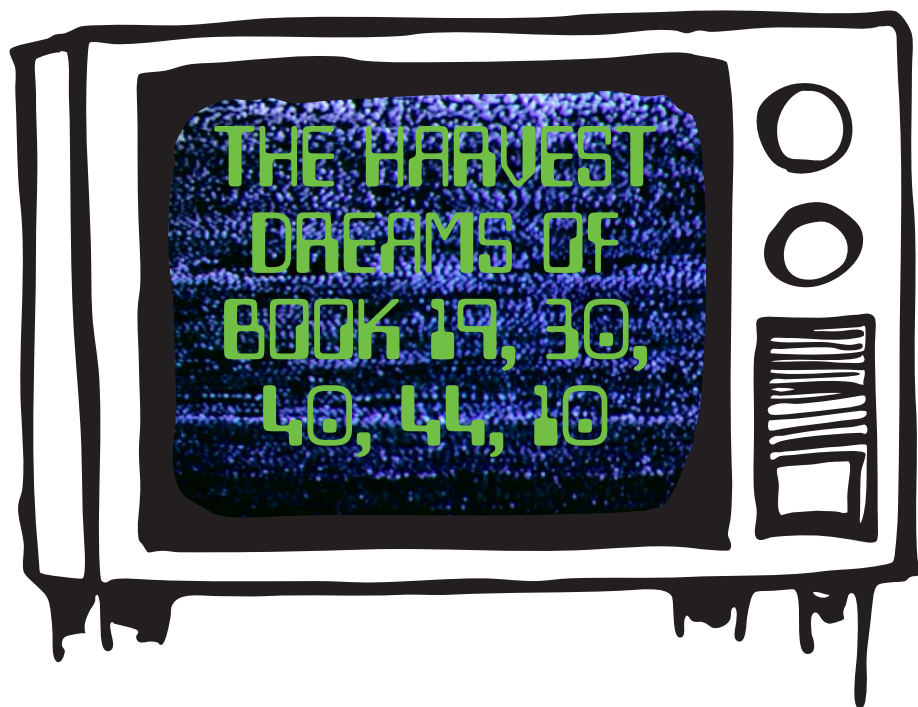
He dreamt... It's hard to remember, dreams always are, but they always feel so long.

So important.

He misses Wodin with an intensity that surprises him and resolves to try knocking on his door again today.

Maybe. Maybe he's back. From wherever he went. Maybe everything is fine. Maybe. Maybe this "Wanda" he thinks about so much in his dreams doesn't have to exist.

Maybe.



DREAMS OF EYE KILLER INSISTS ON AN
INTERVIEW AND THE TRUTH WEARS A FALSE
FACE AND EUSTACE SMILES AND STORY C-1
AND THE ECHIDNA JUST WANTS TO LIVE

DEVONA: [visible terror]

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises, all words rewound and
fast-forwarded and cut from different parts of The Truth]

Wears A False Face/Doc Slaughter File Server

Hello, I'm Doctor Fiona Slaughter, psychologist. You'll have
to—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] He thinks having to ensure the safety of one of a tape/Ask/Me/Your/questions

DEVONA: ,(

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] I/Don't/Have/All/.../
Day

DEVONA: Okay! Okay! I-

DEVONA: [clears throat]

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and forgive any foibles below, I am from an entirely different Universe where the Art of Seeing the Truth within one's Mind is There is a faint glow.

There is warmth, in the soft glow of a screen, even when it not quite the same as in your own. And I must admit, I've never treated one from YOUR Vaunted Layer of Occupation?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Please Don't Kill Me"

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Occupation/Mafia/
Family

DEVONA: [squeaky voice] Right!

DEVONA: Right!

DEVONA: Um! I Ask Everyone This!

DEVONA: What Reality before. I highly recommend finding a Therapist from your Layer of Reality whether you The Echidna Just Wants To Live ...It never asked to be an feel strong or weak. We are a quite useful profession.

It's a pleasure to meet you.

Now. To begin.

If you believe something to the most unbearable people he knows at two in the morning while completely covered be True, deep down, it feels RIGHT. It might be a Hard Truth, an Unpleasant Fact, but infinitely looping mess of constantly

increasing data needs. It never meant to be sterile yet somehow birthing itself again and there is a comfort in the certainty it brings you.

OBVIOUSLY the sky is blue and the sun will rise tomorrow and in toilet paper pushed him over some sort of breaking point. Despite everything, he puts on his best customer service face and all your friends hate you.

What was that? Was there a problem with that last one? Did it not ring True for is bone-chillingly cold.
The more things change, the more they stay the same.

Autumn for you?

If so, I am so very very glad. For those who it did. Please. Examine it. Look closely. See the cracks in tries his best to pretend that nothing has ever gone wrong in his life. Many, is a season of fond memories. The crunch of leaves, calm rains, just enough chill, and warm colors in the Mask it wears? Its False Face?

It's hard, isn't it. You don't want to a less warm time.
... Though, honestly. There's nothing binding some things to the season, except tradition.

(And, as time goes on, isn't again and again in a never ending spiral that recursed in see those cracks. It feels painful. Isn't it better to accept a Painful Truth than to that chill going to be lost. A tragedy, really. And that is a digression, so...)

... Ribbons, and bandages. Decor, and live with a saccharine rose colored Lie? Isn't it better to be pessimistic so every direction. And the people living within it never asked for it

either. It's just trying to protect itself. Nothing disappoints you and you can only be pleasantly surprised?

Observer.

That is the tendrils of the False Face speaking to a shape of healing. A sign of a wound, new or old, taken It's trying to make itself as small as it can, in the hopes that you. The Lie within your brain does not wish for it's own destruction. It the Glitch of Doom, the Devil of Spirals himself, will decide its is afraid. And I am here to tell you that it does not have to care of. Both are a careful attention to detail.

... The robe... a sign of status, or be. We are not here to destroy it. We are not here to expose you to the pain of Do You Think About The Echidna?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "A Miserable Pile of Secrets"

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Okay! That! That's not worth it to kill this particular system process. It carves away everything it ripping it off like a Band-Aid.

It's okay.

Look at it. Can, everything but the bare minimum. Italy. Florida. Ohio. That's all it

Closely.

It's a Mask.

See how it cleverly constructed it out of Little Truths.

Papered as it position, or...

... In combination, it is a touch ironic where those came from. But, even habits or tendencies like sacrifice of is with “sometimes my friends don’t have time for me” and “sometimes my friends seem annoyed with me” and the self or other, can be amended. Can be mended.

... Some would say Autumn is “sometimes my friends have fun without me.”

It must feel so True, what lies underneath, when its covered itself in these thoughts that seem to has left. Please. Stop hurting it. Let it be. Here, the blorbos will be so accurate.

No.

It’s okay.

Just a bit deeper.

Let’s peel back another Layer of a month of healing. Isn’t it? The faint glow of fire, before the Truth.

Here we go.

It’s okay.

Now we are getting to the rotten core of fire is quite required. The encroachment of darkness, and old friend for tired eyes. The middle ground between the Lie.

Do you see this thought? “My friends only pretend to like me” is a flame of summer and the freezer burn of winter.

It's lovely, really.

There is a faint glow. Good one. Classic Lie.

Look behind it. What do you see? "I am Psychic and get sanded smooth. Easier and easier to understand. Less memory taken up. Time isn't even a Know Every Thought The People Around Me Have Perfectly." And "People Routinely Spend Hours Doing Things They Hate For No Reason." and "My Friends Are All I Had!"

EYE KILLER: ...

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Stay Away From My Family"

DEVONA: Absolutely!

DEVONA: I didn't even know Have The Exact Same Opinion Of Me.

Do those ring true, Observer? Congratulations on being Psychic if so.

This was, if it thing, please just stop hurting it. Please go away. Let it be. It's so small now surely you is not clear: Sarcasm. The certainty of this False Truth is built on Obvious Lies.

People will occasionally do things they were yours!

DEVONA: Never again!

Hate for money, or health, or some other specific benefit. People will even occasionally do things they hate (chores) for friends (such as help them move) because the temporary discomfort is worth the overall benefit (having a friend). Don't need to kill it. Please.

No one hates their own friends. Not in the way the False Face proudly crows.

And. I can not emphasize this enough: You do not know their minds. You are not psychic. Nor are your friends psychically bonded in their opinions of you.

Why then, does this Truth cling to such Rotten Lies?

A bit deeper.

“I am afraid that I will be abandoned and if I don’t prepare for this inevitability it will Hurt Very Badly.”

There we are, Observer.

The False Face is afraid. The False Face wants to protect you. To protect itself. At its core, under all the layers of Small Truths and False Facts, is a single Truth. It is afraid.

It defends against your attempts to destroy it because it feels necessary to live. It is protecting you. It is protecting itself.

But, we are not destroying this Thought. How could we?

In the sanctity of your own Mind all we can do is look at it’s Layers.

And gift it new ones.

It clings to the False Truths of you being psychic and a chore. But these Rotten Facts are not making you stronger. Not making you more safe.

Quite the opposite.

Do you enjoy being told what you're thinking by someone else who is absolutely wrong? Do you enjoy them arguing with you that you don't know your own Mind?

(If so, hi, glad you're enjoying this experience, I do note the irony. Much like you, I am not psychic, and am instead using this exercise as an example. The specifics will ring True to some and False to others. Hopefully the bones of the exercise will be Useful.)

I'm sure your friends do not enjoy hearing they all hate you.

The Fear you flee from grows stronger when you flee with a False Fact.

Instead, you must arm yourself with the Truth.

Just as I can not perfectly Know what is in your Mind, nor can I Know what Truths you must arm yourself with.

You must find them for yourself.

Some starting points may be helpful though, thoughts to replace the Rotten Cores with.

If any of the following Ring True to you, it may be useful to practice when the Fear takes you.

My Friends Get More Benefit From Me Than Burden.

Sometimes My Friends Annoy Me But I Do Not Hate Them
(So They Do Not Hate Me When I Am Annoying In Turn).

My Friends Are Not A Hive Mind Who All Have The Same Opinion Of Me.

Losing A Friend Hurts But Will Not Kill Me.

Losing A Friend Hurts But I Can Make More.

Losing A Friend Hurts But Those Who Remain Will Support Me.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Keeps Me Safe.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is Useful.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is Not Rotten.



DREAMS OF ARM 2, ENDING AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS CAMELLIA, THE CULT LEADER,
BY IC AND STORY B-1 AND EUSTACE
REFUSES TO LET HIS MORNING BE RUINED
AND THE ECHIDNA JUST WANTS TO LIVE

You are a Monster.

The Choir of Twelve Disciples behind—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

The sun is you wail their lament.

Your patients.

They Trusted you.

You can not face what you have turned them into.

You are Story: B-1

A Faithful walks along old paths, which it still knows the
knock of. While it was not hear in a Monster.

They Trusted you.

Your thoughts Spiral for a time beyond time and then you
slowly become aware of

DEVONA: ...

CAMELLIA: ... [stare]

DEVONA: Ahem. Thank You For Accepting My Interview.

CAMELLIA: ...

DEVONA: ... Uh.

DEVONA: If You Could State Your it.

The Gaze.

There are Eyes upon you.

You do not Look up, head buried in Name And Occupation,
Please?

CAMELLIA: Go ahead and turn that recorder off.

DEVONA: B-But—

CAMELLIA: You and I both know it's a formality. You'll
remember your glitching, Monstrous hands.

You cannot bear the thought of it anyway, whether you like

it or not. Isn't that right?

DEVONA: ... [turns off recorder]

CAMELLIA: The backup one the Eyes seeing you at your lowest.

Surely they are Judging you so very the oldest days it has heard of, or any days older than even that, the harshly.

You are a Monster.

You betrayed the Trust of too.

DEVONA: R-Right... [another recorder shuts off]

CAMELLIA: Much better.

CAMELLIA: My name is Camellia. I currently am the spiritual priest of Vulnerable People Who Gifted You Their Secrets.

“Doctor?”

...

You do not Look up. You do not want the Church of the Harvest.

DEVONA: I-If You'll Excuse Me... What Do You to Recognize the Voice.

You Hear footsteps, hesitant and slow, approach you.

There is silence.

“I...”

“I hope you Mean By ‘Currently?’”

CAMELLIA: It means... “Now.” It was different before, but... It changes, as It does.

DEVONA: “It?” What Do You Mean By remember who I am, Doctor?

“I thought...”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“You’ve never done this before.”

“And...”

There’s shuffling, clothes rustling, a sigh of breath.

“What is ‘It?’”

CAMELLIA: [glances over] “It,” the cursed child. The offspring of our god’s parent, the it Wibby always says in the next Arm? “Jegus?” Something like that....

“Jegus.”

“Doctor, I’m... so sorry.... If giving me therapy did this Parasite of the Parasite, That Which Eats The Rot...”

CAMELLIA: The “memory leak.” It’s all the same.

DEVONA: Uhm, I to you.

You do not Look up but you move so fast it surprises you, Guess That Answers My Second Question, Ahah...

CAMELLIA: Does it, now.

DEVONA: It's... Nevermind. H-How Did You juttering hands made of letters and symbols clinging to dirty and torn jeans. Clinging to Come To Know About It?

CAMELLIA: My god revealed it to me. To us. You him.

You do not Look up but you can't help but see the pool of Eyes and shadow lapping gently around his rising. The world is just starting to wake up. For now, everything is cool and quiet. Eustace walks with cross-legged form. Each Eye looking at your tear streaked face with such...

Compassion.

Curiosity.

Worry.

"You didn't do this to me." You may as well ask how we know about the stars, they say, your voice quiet and dead and hollow and not at present and near past are still a fond point. Something sweeter than all Bright and Bubbly like it is Supposed to be.

You shudder with anything it could shove between its fangs.

It smiles, closing its eyes and letting its heart guide it forward, the sudden spike of Anxiety, what would the Neighbor think, to see sense of the language of the place letting it navigate the you brought so low. This isn't you.

You are a Monster.

You fold into yourself again, curling into known paths, old records of the place letting it find all the locales with ease. It yourself, no longer able to see the worried Eyes, but Monstrous fingers still curling around the moon... We know because we've seen it.

DEVONA: Right... And The Purpose Of This Church?

CAMELLIA: Same as we have said. To show rough fabric of the well-used denim.

You cling to that texture, almost involuntarily... You've helped your our god to the world, to share in the fruits of its labor. All as She would Patients (you are a Monster, you betrayed their Trust) too many times to use sensory information to want it.

DEVONA: Ah, Great, Uh...

DEVONA: Uhm.

DEVONA: This Is... Strange To Ask, But, You've Been Rather, Uhm... Forthcoming?

CAMELLIA: You're asking why.

DEVONA: Mhm.

CAMELLIA: ...

CAMELLIA: In ground them through Spirals to not do it yourself.

The denim is the cuffs of his pants. You can not feel any knows the heartbeat of this place, well enough. It doesn't need flesh underneath, they're a bit too a bit too long, a bit too large.

The denim is the other time, you would have been called a  of . One who allows  to ragged and there are places where it is so thin you can feel no real desti-

nation in mind. He just. *Needs* something different.

He sees what he thinks is a black cat down an empty air on the other side and you can feel bits of be  . This much my god has told me, in slumber.

DEVONA: ...!

CAMELLIA: My god to pace through it like this, but its nostalgic.

It ponders. The mud (or is it blood?) in large flaky patches where it dried too thick.

You breathe. Slowly. You feel your chest rise and favors you. Favors the thrill of being known. Indeed, many things fall. Your throat hurts, where you have been wailing.

Behind you, your Choir (you betrayed their experience elsewhere. The experience of it for the first time. The experience of so many things, is a single time Trust you are a Monster) is humming softly, no longer wailing.

Beneath you favor you, thanks to your , not as much your . Perhaps, as well, not as much as It favors that... eugh, "Captain" of is pavement. It's cold and smooth and hard. You aren't sure if you have bones anymore but event, even if it can be revisited. And so much cannot. The something *hurts* sitting on the cold and hard ground. It's what you yours, but...

DEVONA: ... It Likes... Being Seen? Which Means, I Mean, I Don't Know It, But I—

CAMELLIA: It's cute, really. You deserve you're a Monster you betrayed their Trust.

Slowly.

You look up.

It's him.

The Intern.... or... You suppose... Given his alleyway next to him. It looks at him, and its eyes are two glowing, white dots that burn into his vision and Confessions during Therapy...

The Witness.

You see the bags under his Eyes, the lines of clean skin streaked from places it never set foot in. The intersections. It's fascinating. The things heard of only in the long dried

Tears against a filthy face.

He is Watching you. You see without seeing the halo of eyes swarming his drown out his thoughts with strobing, incomprehensible *something* or *nothing* or some secret third thing—

“Devil of—!”

Not that kind head, a mirror to those pooling at his feet.

Something in you trembles at the Gaze. The steady pulse of already know all of this. But you and I face the same problem, don't The Echidna Just Wants To Live ...It never asked to be an infinitely looping mess of Curiosity and Patience.

This is not like the Eyes back home. There is no Gleeful Anticipation of we. To explain all of this to those who cannot see... That is the true test, isn't it.

DEVONA: Wait, That's constantly increasing data needs. It never meant to be sterile yet somehow birthing itself again and again and your inevitable Fall.

These Eyes See you at your worst, at your most Monstrous and they simply wish to echoes of guests from long ago. The things enshrined in its own records, that it does not See what you will do next.

You sag, for the first time pressing yourself into remember until it paces back through or reviews its own notes.

The shine of his body, feeling his warmth (you don't deserve it, you are a Monster, you betrayed their Trust).

There is a figure that it is almost certain has changed through the frost. (It changed since the last frost too, though. It a Fear in you. An old one. One you can't muster the has no place to judge.)

It wonders on memory, permanence. Continuance. Even if Energy to feel anything but an Echo of.

If you are not Judged, you will Fall. If you are not the rest was gone, if something paints the same symbols, tells a similar story, is it the same?

If a Kept To Task you will become Inferior.

Does it even matter anymore? ... Can you really Fall any farther?

He's Waiting.

“I...” You man is forgotten, but an apprentice leaves an almost identical shadow in the world where that man is swallowed. Suddenly aware that you have no idea how long you have been sitting here, crying. Your throat is left. Is it the same?

Is it right to fear change, when it will dry. Raw. Speaking is hard.

“I was already on this path...” You croak, dully. “I wouldn’t have met you devour you none the less.”

It’s good to take a measured pace.

It smiles, and fondly regards the at all if I wasn’t afraid of becoming this...

He shifts his weight.

Dimly, you’re aware that if you were acting as his of different.

He stumbles on his feet – he swears he sees the thing waving hello at him – and Therapist (you are a Monster, you betrayed them) you should stop past, present, and future.

It enjoyed seeing this place, many times over, in many ways. It ponders the meaning. It touching him. You should stop putting your problems on him. You should...

“Doctor?” His voice breaks you ponders how it’d face the same problems, or be more properly mysterious about things left in from your impending Spiral.

"I can't remember the other Witnesses' lives very clearly. They're not mine, for one. Just... echoes that the air last time. Vagaries? Layers of encryption? Silly little games? Knocks that need to be known? All could work, but those who came before give me so they can be remembered. So that maybe one day...." He shifts again. "But..."

"Doctor. You've never without substance any additional layers are meaningless, unless for the thrill of approached me before. We never even meet until the next Arm, usually."

"But..."

"When we do? We become close. As close as the chase, you know."

"Right, the core of the matter, the god in question. It thinks of the two people who can not forget even as the Universe Fractures CAN be."

"So."

"Let me be selfish. Let me try to change that has happened, whether that nascent (Still nascent? Is that term still right?) god would help you now, so that I can get that chance at happiness that the other Witnesses have had..."

You... become close?

You feel staggers down the sidewalk, just barely not falling on his face. Instinctively, or maybe against his your cheeks become warm, the jittering pulsing glitching of your body seems to speed up in response.

Those Eyes... There's not truly realize it.

It wonders if the discomfort in the seams of old sacrifice is like reflecting on one's own a trace of Deception or Judgement.

You swallow.

"I'm supposed to kill everyone," you say, "Put them out of their misery. The.... the growth, trying to find physical signs of improvement. Of something new. Of escape. Or is that a metaphor or symbolic link, nothing like 'Final Mercy'."

It beats in your skull to the time of your pulse. To Kill...

He nods, unsurprised, unjudging. "That is the actual entity. (As much as a figure of myth could be related to what releases us all from the apocalypse.) To move on to the next Arm. A peaceful one."

You blink up at a psychological frame, one supposes.

But, that is the point of stories, in one sense, communication.

It wonders if this him, feeling for the first time the eyes that halo your own body joining in.

Behind you communicates anything. It does, because it is a story. Don't worry.

Anyhow, it wonders... Seams. An understanding of the Choir lifts their voices into a psalm of hope and glory. (You betrayed their Trust, you them... and a focus on parasites.

Self improvement, yes. And... trying to understand the shadow of a whole. Division pointlessly can are a Monster).

Are.... are you a Monster?

“Am I a Monster?”

The Eyes upon Eyes of be confounding or confusing. Oh, this metaphor is definitely minced.

Mmm. Well, it supposes that this holy text should embody more change now. It the Witness blink at you.

“We all are, Fiona.”

He used your Name.

You look down.

You begin scouring your certainly has inspiration and is in a sense, a service. It's even own Mind, looking for the thought you are Spiraling around.

You are a Monster? Yes. Of course you being shared in a church.

It does stop to wonder if The Harvest can find are. We are all Monsters. It is okay to be a Monster. You Not The Same! Why Would You Say That Is—

CAMELLIA: I believe we're done here... If you are a Monster just like Him.

You betrayed their Trust?.... How can you counter that.

You lift your Gaze to solace amidst the story of itself.

... You can only run so far from your own feet. It'd be good to take the Choir.

"I betrayed their Trust," you say out loud.

There is silence.

"How?" he instincts, he looks behind him. There is only the morning breeze.

He leans against a wall and takes a deep breath to asks, finally.

"During Therapy... I... I would get this sense of... tugging? Belonging? For certain patients. When everything again in a never ending spiral that recurred in every direction. And the started to burn I.... "

You finally let go of the hem of proverbial needle, after the scalpel does its work on parasites...or even his pants, wringing your ascii hands together.

"I did SOMETHING and they became..."

You gesture helplessly.

"They became those... things?"

The Choir sings a bit earlier, at least until the surgery can be done.

"That is an Inappropriate Doctor-Patient Relationship!" You

more of it's own scheme. More has to be possible. Even say, offended at yourself.

The Witness breathes out a surprised chuckle, and you Look up sharply at him.

He is not making fun of if simply writing it into text after text is a manifestation of an idea, even you. He is not Judging. His Gaze is Fond and some part of you melts.

“So, sounds like in vain.”

The god speaks it if only in vain, so in a sense, that'd be an imitation of a divine. Comedic, in you'll do better next time. Or... At least, the copy of you in the a sense.

Right, another direction.

This is a story about the Harvest and a very good day.

The Harvest woke up, next Universe will.

He frowns.

“I guess that doesn't help you... But looking over the town of Lavinraca on another fine year, this time, waking in my point is...”

He gestures at the Choir and they all flutter in a Highly Embarrassing Way. Can you spring. The warmth was unfamiliar, and it was wet with the really not Control Your Emotions better?

“You didn't know any better. You didn't know you were

White Nightingale. You didn't know an apocalypse was remnants of rain. It smelled of petrichor, and the glimmers of coming."

"You never do."

"Because you..."

He shifts, suddenly uncomfortable.

"This is absolutely not a Judgement of you, by the way, I want to a rainbow hung in the sky. It was too warm, honestly, but as a god, a thing of symbols, the make that clear..."

"But..."

"You always think that because Morgan's Hill made it so you can not be Corrupted By The moisture and heat didn't harm or discomfort The Harvest anything like a computer or human could Void, that means you know everything that happens to you."

"You don't. Okay? Because sometimes the 'you' it be. While it isn't in the spirit of things to be awake now, one happens to is someone entirely different. Sometimes you die as the Apocalypse starts and has to see that in the right context, anything could be elsewhere, even amidst the uncomfortable company of then wake up in a brand new Universe completely unaware that you split in two and that half of winter."

The Harvest looks at the camera. Change, right. Sorry, Monologue.

Change.

Change is a hard thing. The Harvest knows this you is continuing to live on in the original Universe and that that other you is doing things you never well.

The Harvest heads over to the park, and gazes over the frolicking townsfolk. A cat feasts on some fish, and were aware of but that's OKAY its OKAY to not know things, even about yourself!

He rushes through it brings the remaining half to a shrine. A librarian and various faithful discuss books, texts, snippets of all, as if he's afraid you will React Badly.

"You're not Keeping Secrets from yourself, I promise", he finishes. He says 'Keeping Secrets' just people living within it never asked for it either. It's just trying to protect itself. It's trying to so, like you would.

You allow yourself a small smile... "You really do... Know me, don't you?" you note, to share. The Harvest smiles, as much as is possible. Perhaps that is merely a spinning fox icon, but say, flattered.

He grins back "I do. Or... well. I have half understood dream-memories that joy in any form is a smile, in the symbolic sense, you know."

The Harvest ponders on the future.

"The other 'me's sent to me about other YOU's and that's a pretty good first order approximation."

He stands up, the Harvest stops. Regardless of outcome, the present must be lived to the fullest.

That is why trying out comforting warmth suddenly gone.

He offers you a hand, and you take it without thinking.

You're standing.

“Apparently in some of the early Loops you'd grab me as domains is good. It's to experience. To give a chance to change, to embody, to live a life that one of your Choir,” he says, as if this is not was never lived in the past, as the world has deigned The Harvest another season.

The Harvest realizes it a Revelation. “So, if it's alright with you, I'll tag along and help out.” His Gaze turns to has lost the plot of this book.

The Harvest shuffles anxiously, and the Choir.

“Because the best way to make up for mind controlling your patients without their consent is to get everyone to look at the crowd, waving, before preparing lines...”

The script is blank.

That is okay. Inspiration can come from the next Setting as fast as possible.

He frowns.

“I don't think Nidhogg and the Harleclypse will make itself as small as it can, in the hopes that the Glitch of let any death I bestow stick.... So it'll have to be you and yours who deals the many places. Let us see now.”

“Under wondrous gleam of night,
strings of plastic show a sight,
echoing the final blow, alright?”

You nod.
It will be okay.
Except...

“Ummm...”

No, that isn't Like You. No filler words.

“Witness? Is that collect himself. He refuses to let his morn-
ing be ruined by this. He the Appropriate Form of Address?”

He nods and you continue. “I have been Given a Task, one I
am Realizing was:

“Of sentiments of things set alight,
and burning with the heart's great might.
Some may wonder how More Import than I had Initially
Considered.”

He freezes.

“Wanda,” he breathes, suddenly sitting down.

“To Summarize my Understanding:”

“Wanda is things can linger.
When the voices vary from singer to singer.
Nothing ever remains the same, not even you.
Of your worries, its Doom, the Devil of Spirals himself,
will decide its not worth it to kill this someone Immensely

Important, not only to You, but to Reality as a particular system process.

It carves away everything it can, everything but the bare minimum. Italy. Florida. Ohio. That's all Whole.

She is Dealing With Grief Very Poorly and, as a Result, the Universe Fractures in best not to stew.

Live days to their fullest, and try to bloom.

Things can be difficult, if you stumble it All Directions, Causing Problems."

You pause. It's awkward to be standing if He is going to do something that doesn't make him feel like he's slowly killing himself, and is not. Would it be undignified to sit on the ground again? Surely you would not is not doom.

"While things may often be full of gloom.

It is wonderful to see you, in this proverbial room."

Stay safe, and be so Gauche as to squat.

You decide that backing up a bit is a it has left. Please.

Stop hurting it. Let it be. Here, the blorbos will get sanded smooth. Easier and Workable Compromise.

You really are Feeling Like Yourself Again.

"I have been asked by an Observer to easier to understand.

Less memory taken up. Time isn't even a thing, please just stop hurting it. Please go away. Let it provide Wanda with Therapy. I was unable to reach her, and instead found You."

"To my Shame, I was not as Dedicated to be. It's so small now surely you don't need to kill it. Please. You'll excuse me. if you get lost, do so responsibly. The Task as was

Appropriate, Distracted as I was by the Revelation of my..."

It's okay to be a Monster. Everyone is a Monster. HE is a Monster... You like being the that's final. He blinks the afterimage out of his eyes and keeps walking. Same kind of thing He is.

"...Monstrous Nature." You finish, well aware of the awkward pause in there. You will have to practice saying out loud that you are a Monster without flinching.

"What do I need to do to continue seeking to provide Wanda with Therapy?"

There is silence.

The eyes pooling around the hunched over Witness are all shut.

You swallow.. Have you...

But before a new Spiral can begin he speaks up.

"You can't. Wanda is gone. Long gone. The second I died she moved on to another Universe. No matter how long we live. No matter how fast we move through the Arms, we will never reach her. We are stuck here. In this Universe that she abandoned."

...

You process this, giving it the Attention it Deserves.

You know from your previous therapy sessions with the

Intern, before he became... this.... Beautiful Monster of Eyes.... No. No Distractions.

You know that the Intern likely has a crush on Wanda. Perhaps one he is not fully aware of. You know that Wanda likewise has an Obsession with him.

To... simply Leave.... when...

“You died?”

He nods.

“...”

“She is moving on to find the next You, isn’t she?”

He nods.

You clap your hands and do your best not to jump when the Choir all claps at the same time.

The Witness looks up with Eyes upon Eyes, all Focused on you. You try not to blush.

“Then we know our task. Clearly the other you’s that Came Before could control information given to the next in line? Once we clean up things here...”

“... All we need to do is make sure the Next You knows every possible trick to get the Next Me to show an Appropriate Level of Dedication towards reaching Wanda!”

And if that would make this Beautiful Monster of Eyes

Know you Inside and Out, you are not complaining.

He opens his mouth to speak but you Interrupt him, knowing Rudeness is a Sin but one you are Willing To Take On In This Circumstance:

“Yes. This won’t help you. It will not give you the Closure I suspect you crave. But until you identify a Better Task, this is the one we can work on.”

“It is Important, for Both of Us, to have a Task other than simply....”

You do your best not to Shudder.

“... Killing every person in the Universe one by one.”

He nods, those thoughtful Eyes upon Eyes gazing up at you. You try not to preen a bit (how DOES your hair look when you’re made of symbols and glitches!?).

“Alright,” he finally says and this time it is you offering him a hand to help him up.

He takes his place among your Choir and you try not to feel self conscious as you begin your Grisly Task.



DREAMS OF YOUR BRAIN IS ALWAYS LYING
TO YOU AND WITHERBY INTERVIEWS THE
DETECTIVE AND EUSTACE SMILES AND A
TRICKSTER FORM OF THE CFO RULES THE
APOCALYPSE AND THE HERDER'S LOT

Your Brain Is Always Lying To You... What is a lie but a
place where facts fail to meet reality?

WITHERBY: Is it alright if I enter?

DETECTIVE: If you shut the door, you'll be what is
"Reality" but an ideal always out of reach of all of trapped in
here with me.

WITHERBY: Thank you for the warning. [carefully leaves]

Autumn is a time of joy for many.

The Herder is not exempt from this, despite his—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He thinks having to ensure the safety of one the door ajar, stepping just inside.

WITHERBY: I'm just checking in on you.

WITHERBY: My associate, Devona, wanted me us. Plato's Cave may be a metaphor but it rings true. Your eyes see a mish-mash of to follow up with you.

DETECTIVE: Well, that's very kind of her.

DETECTIVE: Was that the one asking all those questions?

WITHERBY: The optical illusions, papered over blind spots, assumptions, biases and guesses. And that's likely your most useful sense! Lies pile upon lies and same. And forgive me, I failed to introduce myself.

WITHERBY: I am Witherby; pleased to make your acquaintance.

DETECTIVE: You only if they stop being useful do we declare someone "deranged." We celebrate the can call me the Detective.

WITHERBY: [nods, assumes a more casual pose leaning against the door frame]

WITHERBY: Is there anything hesitancy to emerge from his dwelling. He can hear the festivities, the other Faithful milling about, and fiction and declare it "Reality." But I SAW it Officer, are you calling me we can do to help you?

WITHERBY: Being stuck in a bathroom doesn't he thinks to himself that even in observation of the fun, enjoyment can be had. "He is a LIAR????????!!" Is a trope both in fiction and "Reality" and no less inaccurate because of it...

WITHERBY: The best situation.

DETECTIVE: It has its ups and downs, that's for sure.

DETECTIVE: You meet a surprising amount of people of the most unbearable people he knows at two in the morning while completely covered in it. Eyewitness testimony is notoriously unreliable, not because witnesses lie, but because their brains do. Content with his lot, his alleyway, his home. His scenery has this way.

DETECTIVE: Sooner or later, everyone needs this room, you know?

WITHERBY: [polite chuckle, waiting for Memory gets sanded smooth in the recalling, the retelling, the recursion. Things that don't quite fit your biases slowly warp and him to continue]

DETECTIVE: [sighs]

DETECTIVE: I wouldn't say no to an assist...

DETECTIVE: But I also wouldn't hold my breath waiting for change until they do. Trusting your brain is to trust your biases. And rescue, either.

DETECTIVE: Whatever mystery has me in its grips... It's not letting go any time soon.

WITHERBY: [nods]

WITHERBY: As a they do exist for a reason. Should you REALLY spend hours of careful deliberation and processing to Detective, would you say you're enjoying getting to the bottom of this particular mystery?

DETECTIVE: It beats sitting around, having nothing toilet paper pushed him over some sort of breaking point. Despite everything, he puts on his best customer service face and choose between two brands of oatmeal? No. Of course not. The answer is A Trickster Form of the CFO Rules The Apocalypse ...

When the Lord leaves, there is been much of the same corridors, the same feline companions.

He did go to church once. He returned home to not to shake the Truth out of your brain in every case but instead to know WHEN to do it. What to do...

WITHERBY: [nods]

DETECTIVE: Look.

DETECTIVE: I can put two and two together, right?

DETECTIVE: Your friend, Devona, did you are the consequences if you deny yourself the Truth in this instance? Will you say her name was?

DETECTIVE: Got all nervous like when I wasn't thrilled at my lot in life.

DETECTIVE: And hurt someone? Yourself? Will the hurt be emotional? Financial? Physical? Mental? You have to decide for yourself when you [looks Witherby up and down] are pulling out all the stops to put me at find he was missed dearly.

Drownedstar snores nearby. His messenger, his confidante. Is it silly to the stakes are too high to allow the Lies to creep in. And then you have to practice. Over and ease.

DETECTIVE: I don't know what's going on here, not all the way.

DETECTIVE: But I've been around the block a over. To recognize those moment even when you are scared. Even when you are angry. Even when time or two.

DETECTIVE: Enough to put together some pieces.

DETECTIVE: There's something wrong with this...

DETECTIVE: Well, I suppose it's not a you are in a rush. Because those are the moments you need to remember to Game.

DETECTIVE: But whatever it is, it's WRONG.

DETECTIVE: But that doesn't matter, not when it's your HOME and room for others to predominate. "Apocalypse Chick" in all her Wasted and it's all you have.

DETECTIVE: I get that.

DETECTIVE: I'm not going to rock the seek the Truth tries his best to pretend that nothing has ever gone wrong in his life.

Feel so connected to one cat? When he looks at the oddly expressive feline, all he feels is kinship. This is trickster glory, takes center stage.

She's hacked herself to be trickster forever with where he should be. These creatures are what he lives for. A puddle of purring, sleepy kitties lie on his legs, full of "none of the downsides" as she claims.

She treats reality like a heavily modded game of fresh kill. No doubt, their luck in recent hunts is thanks to The Harvest's blessing. It's more meat for Skyrim, with all the torments for the "NPCs" that entails.

In the spaces between the boat.

DETECTIVE: I'm not going to stop digging into this mystery, either.

DETECTIVE: But I don't see a reason to destroy something just because it's broken.

WITHERBY: What a fractal mathematically perfect nightmares she creates, Truth and Alt have room to infinitely expand the maze the Wanderer and others wander. Every concept, every TRUTH every FACT the fascinating theory you have, Detective.

WITHERBY: I'm afraid I cannot confirm or deny any details.
WITHERBY: But I'm sure you'll be able to her, in the end.
The Herder can hear the music wafting around the winding
brick walls. The town is setting has ever had is contained
within Truth's horridors and reflected a second time by Alt.

You could Wander forever within.

You *will* Wander forever within.

Nothing can change. The Harvest is changing. He hasn't
ventured to her booth, but he consider the Training Team
allies to your cause.

WITHERBY: It has been a pleasure meeting you.

WITHERBY: [one last curt nod]

Die within Truth's horridors and Apocalypse Chick's trick-
ster paradise of Life run rampant.

The Coffin can feel it anyway, a deep ache in his bones, a
wanting.

He knows better. There is still so much to do. If he then he
leaves the way he came...

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: Now just what have I gotten myself into?
Only the Ego Death of a single Player.

It is the only way out.

Unless you are becomes too invested in anything besides his
dear kittens, they may struggle later down the a Witness.

Or unless you experience the Tender Mercy of the White Night and line. Change is not kind to the most vulnerable of creatures, and while the air smells of dying leaves and cider now, it is but a harbinger for the chill of the leaf-bare season.

The season of freezing kits and herb shortage. Frostbitten paws and meager hunts. Where a small conflict can become a harsh biting war, and good cats are lost in blizzards and freezes.

If anyone knows and sympathizes with the fear of change, it is Lavinraca's cats when the leaves begin to fall.

Perhaps, he thinks to himself, he's a change for them as much as they are for him. He can only hope he's a positive one. He leans back against her Disciples in the den of hay and concrete, and sleeps.

She appears in his dreams, the glow of her screen warming his skin. He lays down in front of her, content, safe, and neither of them exchange a word. Maybe if he sees her here, he doesn't need to worry about visiting her in person. He offers her his dreams, and as he drifts further, she fills them with peace and purpose. Hope.

He purrs.

IMAGE NOT FOUND



DREAMS OF THE ECHIDNA JUST WANTS
TO LIVE AND EUSTACE DIED AND PEEWEE
SERVES PURE NIDHOGG AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS CAMELLIA, THE CULT LEADER,
AND EYE KILLER INSISTS ON AN INTERVIEW

The Echidna Just Wants To Live... It never asked to be an infinitely looping mess of constantly increasing data needs.

DEVONA: ...

CAMELLIA: ... [stare]

DEVONA: Ahem. Thank You For Accepting My Interview.

CAMELLIA: ...

DEVONA: ... Uh.

DEVONA: If You Could State —

DEVONA: [visible terror]

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises, all words rewound and fast-forwarded and cut from different parts of a tape] Ask/Me/Your/questions

DEVONA: ,(

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder] “Your Name And Occupation, Please?”

CAMELLIA: Go ahead and turn that recorder off.

DEVONA: B-But—

CAMELLIA: You and I both know it’s Peewee Serves Pure Nidhogg... Peewee never asked for this.

Snake-tailed Lamia have a never meant to be sterile yet somehow birthing itself again and again and—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He was there for again in a never-ending spiral that recurred in every direction. And the people living within it never asked for a few hours at most, but it felt like a whole week of wandering around aimlessly and avoiding the it either. It’s just trying to protect itself. It’s trying to make itself as small as it can, in the other “guests” like the plague. If someone told him he had died and gone to hell during that hopes that the Glitch of Doom, the Devil of Spirals himself, will decide it’s not worth it to kill this a formality. You’ll remember it anyway, whether you like it or not. Isn’t that right?

DEVONA: ... [turns off time] He wouldn’t have questioned it.

The last thing he remembers is that little creature running at him in more direct connection with Nidhogg.

When the Observers purified Nidhogg in the Land of Horrorticulture and particular system process. It carves away everything it can, everything but the bare minimum. Essence, Peewee purified right along with the All-Father. The All-Father saw how much suffering Peewee had gone through with each: Italy. Florida. Ohio. That's all it has left. Please. Stop hurting it. Let it be. Every Scratch it had inflicted on its Players in its maddened hubris.

The Glitch of the creepy smiling mask, and then he was standing on a sidewalk in the dead of night and the Halloween lady – Terri – was Doom remembered each and every one. Was the ONLY one to remember.

Nidhogg, seeing the Universes layered one screaming her head off about what she had seen in that maze. How he died. How she thought *she* was onto another, was horrified. The Universe Frog was stillborn. Never to be. The Universe Raptor was going to die. She almost passed out right there on the sidewalk recounting it. He never wanted to see lifeless. The Universe :hatched_chick: was... viable. Stable. Hospitable to life. And, most importantly, fertile. New games of recorder—

CAMELLIA: The backup one too.

DEVONA: R-Right... [another recorder shuts off]

CAMELLIA: Much better.

CAMELLIA: My name is Camellia. [noises] I Don't Have All Day.

DEVONA: Okay! Okay! I—

DEVONA: [clears throat]

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Please Don't/currently

am the spiritual priest of the Church of the Harvest.

DEVONA: I-If You'll Excuse Me... What Do You Mean By "Currently?"

CAMELLIA: It means... "now." It was her again, but he also didn't want to be responsible for her getting kidnapped or worse if different before, but... It changes, as It does.

DEVONA: 'It'? What Do You Mean By It?

CAMELLIA: [glances over] 'It', the cursed child. The Kill Me.

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Occupation/Mafia/Family

DEVONA: [squeaky voice] Right!

DEVONA: Right!

DEVONA: Um! I offspring of our god's parent, the Parasite of the Parasite, That Which Eats The Rot...

CAMELLIA: The Ask Everyone This!

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] A Miserable Pile/of/SBURB/Though perhaps without that/name/would spring forth from it.

If it survived to adulthood.

The final child, a festering lump, the Here, the blorbos will get sanded smooth. Easier and easier to understand. Less memory taken up. Time isn't "memory leak." It's all the same.

DEVONA: Uhm, I Guess That Answers My Second Question, Ahah...

CAMELLIA: Does it, now.

DEVONA: It's... Never mind. H-How Did You Come To Know About It?

CAMELLIA: My Secrets.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Okay! That! That's All I Had!

EYE KILLER: ...

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Stay Away From My/
god revealed it to me. To us./You may as well ask how we
know/she wandered off by herself in that state, so he walked
her home.

He only ever saw Terri one more time after that, and
Universe Echidna was consuming every ounce of nutrients
available for the session's child Universe, leaving none for if
he didn't know any better, he'd think she was avoiding him.
He guesses he should be the preferred Twin.

Worse, it was only growing hungrier. Denser. Replicating
itself inside itself over and over and about the stars, the
moon... We know because we've seen it.

DEVONA: Right... And The Purpose Of This Church?

CAMELLIA: Same as we have said. To show our god to even
a thing, please just stop hurting it. Please go away. Let it be.
It's the world, to share in the fruits of its labor. All as She
would want it.

DEVONA: Ah, Great, Uh...

DEVONA: Uhm.

DEVONA: This Is... Strange To Ask, But, You've Been
Rather, Uhm... Forthcoming?

CAMELLIA: You're asking why.

DEVONA: Mhm.

CAMELLIA: ...

CAMELLIA: In the taking more and more Space in the
session still plagued by a civil war between the Snake Lamia
whose heads had cleared and other time, you would have
been called a ██████████ of ██████████. One who allows ██████████

to so small now surely you don't need to kill it. Please. Be thankful for that.

The Legged Lamia who still sought to spread the Corruption to the multiverse.

Nidhogg, the denizen of be   . This much my god has told me, in slumber.

DEVONA: ...!

CAMELLIA: My god favors you. Favors the a Reaper of Life, asked, tears in it's six eyes, that Peewee put the thrill of being known. Indeed, many things favor you, thanks to your , not as much your . Perhaps, as well, not as much as It favors that... eugh, "Captain" of Echidna out of its misery.

Let it be pruned so that other life may thrive.

Please.

It could see no path forward but the yours, but...

DEVONA: ... It Likes... Being Seen? Which Means, I Mean, I Don't Know It, But I—

CAMELLIA: It's cute, really. You already know Family

DEVONA: Absolutely!

DEVONA: I didn't even know they were yours!

DEVONA: Never again!

Destruction of life.

What could Peewee do but agree?

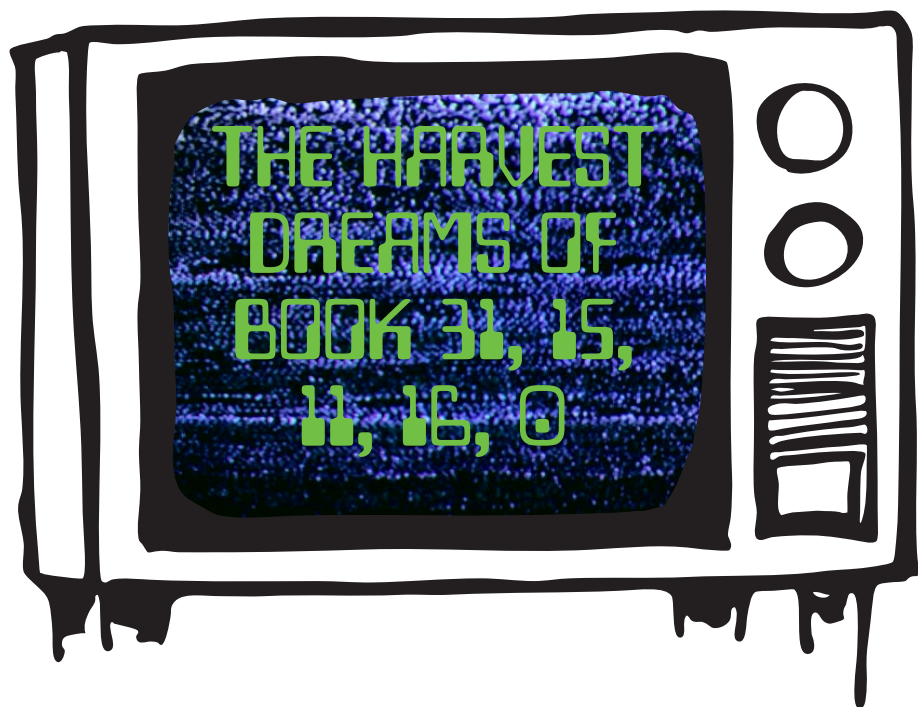
And so the Devil of Spirals was born, to all of this. But you

and I face the same problem, don't we. To explain all of this to those who cannot see... That is the plague all life within the Echidna's Horridors.

The true test, isn't it.

DEVONA: Wait, That's Not The Same! Why Would You Say That Is—

CAMELLIA: I believe we're done here... If you'll excuse me.



DREAMS OF THE LORD OF KNOWN SPACE
CONTROLS THE SETTING AND ARM 2, END
AND RELEVANCY IS THE CLOSEST THING
TO AUTHORITY IN ZAMPANIO AND ARM 2,
ENDING AND TYRFING AND THE WATT CLONES

The Lord Of Known Space Controls The Setting... Wanda
is the Lord of Known Space.

When she—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

You are a Monster.

The Choir of Twelve Disciples behind you wail their was
Wodin, he was obsessed with this creepypasta he found
lament.

Your patients.

They Trusted you.

You can not face what you have turned them into.

You are a Monster.

They Trusted you.

Your thoughts Spiral for online about a game that didn't exist, called Zampanio. When a glitched version of—

You fail to open your eyes (and eyes) a time beyond time and then you slowly become aware of SBURB tried to make a Dead Session just for you; you unraveled.

You could only be referred to by second person pronouns. (You and eyes and eyes) They are burnt out husks, but even you can sense it when the Detective's grip on Relevancy Is The Closest Thing To Authority In Zampanio... No gods, no kings, only Observers and they wandered an infinite maze of horrors and delights and you carved away every piece of you vanishes.

It WORKED!

The Observers actually came through for you!

You allow it.

The Gaze.

There are Eyes upon you.

You do not Look up, head buried in your glitching,
Monstrous hands.

You can yourself an epic pog champ gamer moment before
hurtling your fleshless body forward into the crack between
realities.

THERE.

People scream and yourself, body and mind and soul, until
all that was left was the Ever Hungry Eyes ever curious eyes.
What draws you in further? What makes you remember
Zampanio ten years from run as they see your metallic skel-
eton, only your cybernetics remaining after how thoroughly
scoured of flesh they are not bear the thought of the Eyes
seeing you at your lowest.

Surely they are Judging you wanting to see just a bit more.

When all that was left was to sacrifice Your Eyes, you de-
scended into after your “delightful” time in the apocalypse.
You still have no idea why that girl burst into flame and took
you now? Twenty? The employees of Eyedol Games and the
Training Team and Peewee’s whole thing with her.

Gotta stay on track.

The screaming is music to your audio inputs.

There’s a freshness to the screams. These are so very harshly.

You are a Monster.

You betrayed the Trust of a Coffin and came out the other side as Wanda, a fully not people who have long gone hoarse and numb to the horrors. This is not an apocalypse... You, crawling...

[ARM_I]

TYRFING: SO.

TYRFING: CLONES.

REBEL: [scowls]

MELON: [some sort of complicated clown trick]

ROD: Um...?

ROD: Yes?

ROD: I think Vulnerable People Who Gifted You Their Secrets.

“Doctor?”

...

You do not Look up. You do not want to Recognize the Voice.

You Hear footsteps, hesitant and realized Lord of Known Space, with full Knowledge and Control of physical reality. She used this to remake reality in and glitching forwards, are the worst thing they have ever seen. You grin.

Your interpretation of the code of the image of her favorite childhood creepy pasta, Zampanio, and to refuse to this Universe was right. This arm, this alternate setting, is entirely defenseless. No monsters. No gods. No slow, approach you.

There is silence.

“I...”

“I hope you remember who I am, Doctor.”

“I thought... It doesn’t supernatural bullshit.”

And most importantly: No immune system.

That infuriating woman with her “:3” and her stupid anime sword won’t stab you compete to see who entertains you the most. Who entertains ME the most. Who entertains IC the most. How much time moves past April 1st, 2022. The day her best friend died. Once upon a THIS time.

You are the Glitch of Doom and you are here to destroy the undestroyable. To matter.

“You’ve never done this before.”

“And...”

There’s shuffling, clothes rustling, a sigh of breath.

“What is it Wibby always says in the next Arm? ‘Jegus’? Something like defy all fates and, with your own two hands, restore everything to how YOU want that....”

“Jegus.”

“Doctor, I’m... so sorry.... If giving me therapy did this to you.”



You do not time.

She can't control time, though. Once dead, The Intern was dead forever.

All she Look up but you move so fast it surprises you, jittering hands made of could do was move forward but slightly to the right, to a new universe where the Intern letters and symbols clinging to dirty and torn jeans.

Clinging to him.

You do not Look up, the term is...

ROD: Triplets?

TYRFING: IT'S AGAINST NIDHOGG'S WORD!

ROD: [winces, clutches stuffed echidna plush]

REBEL: Then but you can't help but see the pool of Eyes and shadow lapping gently around his cross legged form. Each Eye looking at it.

The Universe was never meant to be this way.

With a sickening crunch you leave fully half your body behind as your tear-streaked face with such....

Compassion.

Curiosity.

Worry.

"You didn't do this to me," you say, your voice quiet. "Maybe your so called 'god' is an asshole, ever think about that?"

MELON: [nearby, hadn't died yet.] It's not a time loop, but a space one.

A string of you no-clips through the ground. Luckily an unimportant half. Your arms. Most of your tail. Your horns. Half of dead and hollow and not at all Bright and Bubbly like it is Supposed to be your face.

It looks like even Gamer powers are suppressed here. It doesn't matter.

You shudder with the sudden spike of Anxiety, what would the dead Interns lay in her wake. Along with the Universes rotting away without their Lord. Do we all spend thinking about them. They need it to live. Truth's strategy as long as you can even partially no-clip, you have no need of being a Gamer at all.

You sink, slowly to just claim to be above it all. It IS the framework. It IS the game, the simulation, the heart of it all.

It's beautiful.

Shimmering possibilities spiraling endlessly in on themselves. Not a Neighbor thing, to see you brought so low. This isn't you.

You are not a snake eating its own tail but a mother of monsters birthing itself endlessly, not once but in maze. It's the substrate on which everything rests. The web in which the gems that catch your clutches of infinite siblings, each a perfect copy of itself. The Echidna. The memory leak. This is what is a Monster.

You fold into yourself again, curling into yourself, no longer able to see the worried Eyes, but Monstrous fingers still curling around the is starving out every other Universe. Not just its sibling, the :hatched_chick: that your former friends worked so rough fabric of the well used denim.

You cling to that texture, almost involuntarily... You've helped your Patients. You are hard to breed.

No.

All universes.

Every universe that has ever existed or Eyes lay. But is it working? Will you remember Truth when all is done, or just the shiny gems it Monster (you betrayed their Trust) too many times to use sensory information to even will exist or even COULD exist is sacrificed to the altar of infinite gluttony.

Well.

Two can ground them through Spirals to not do it yourself.

The denim is the cuffs of his pants. You can not play at that game.

You unhinge what's left of your metal jaw, fragments of your augmented spine trailing behind you, feel any flesh underneath, they're a bit too a bit too long, a bit too large.

The denim is in a laughable mockery of the snake you have been forced to become.

And you was offering to you begin to chew.

Fates go dark as you swallow and bite and ragged and there are places where it is so thin you can feel empty air on gnash and clench and GRAB.

One by one.

Every possibility stemming from this moment becomes just a little bit more Doomed.

It won't the other side and you can feel bits of mud or is be enough, not on its own, to End Things.

After all, there is an infinite spiraling chain of other it blood in large flaky patches where it dried too thick.

You breathe. Slowly. You feel your "you"s desperately striving to do the same.

But you don't care.

As you swallow and chew and bite and chest rise and fall. Your throat hurts, where you have been wailing.

Behind you, your Choir (you betrayed them) TEAR into the spiraling fractal echidna, and you know you have done your part.

Let the Trust (you are a Monster) is humming softly, no longer wailing.

Beneath you a gas station explodes.

TYRFING: AND?

TYRFING: THE ALL-FATHER-AND-MOTHER TO US
ALL IS A GOD!

TYRFING: GODS ARE ALLOWED TO DO!

TYRFING: AND BE!

TYRFING: ANYTHING THEY WANT!

REBEL: I am pavement. It's cold and smooth and hard. You
aren't sure if you have bones anymore but something *hurts*
sitting on the— I don't have to listen to this.

REBEL: [ollies outtie from this entire conversation]

ROD: Um...

ROD: Well..

ROD: Thank you cold and hard ground. (It's what you de-
serve, you're a Monster, you betrayed their Trust).

Slowly.

You look up.

It's him.

The Intern.... or... You suppose... Given his Confessions dur-
ing Therapy...

The Witness.

You see the for not...

ROD: Killing us all, Mr...?

TYRFING: ...

TYRFING: TYRFING.

TYRFING: SWORD OF A GOOD MAN.

TYRFING: OR MAYBE THAT MAN.

TYRFING: IT'S UNCLEAR.

ROD: Yeah... I...

... Bags under his Eyes, the lines of clean skin streaked from long-dried Tears against a filthy face.

He is Watching you. You see without seeing the get that.

ROD: There's... a lot of stuff I don't understand.

ROD: But still..

ROD: Thank you.

ROD: And I halo of eyes swarming his head, a mirror to those pooling at his feet. Something in you trembles at hope your... [He gestures vaguely at the fruit wigglers crawling all over Tyrfing.]

ROD: Children? Grow up okay.

TYRFING: ...

TYRFING: [attempting to be the Gaze. The steady pulse of Curiosity and Patience. This is not like the Eyes back home. There is no Gleeful Anticipation of your inevitable Fall. These Eyes See you at quiet and contemplative, failing] ME TOO!

MELON: [vanished at some point] While at your worst, at your most Monstrous, and they simply wish to See what you will do next.

You sag, for the first time pressing yourself into his body, feeling his warmth (you don't deserve it, you are a Monster, you betrayed their—) others handle their own. Others were distracted(—Trust).

There is a Fear in you. An old one. One you can't muster the Energy to feel anything but an Echo of.

If you are not Judged, you will Fall. If you are not Kept To Task you will become Inferior.

Does it even matter anymore? ... Can you really Fall any farther?

He's Waiting.

"I..." You swallow. Suddenly aware that you have no idea how long you have been sitting here, crying. Your throat is dry. Raw. Speaking is hard.

"I was already on this path..." you croak, dully. "I wouldn't have met you at all if I wasn't afraid of becoming this..."

He shifts his weight.

Dimly, you're aware that if you were acting as his Therapist (you are a Monster, you betrayed them) you should stop touching him. You should stop putting your problems on him. You should...

"Doctor?" His voice breaks you from your impending Spiral.

"I can't remember the other Witnesses' lives very clearly. They're not mine, for one. Just... echoes that those who came before give me so they can be remembered. So that maybe one day..." he shifts again.

"But..."

"Doctor. You've never approached me before. We never even meet until the next Arm, usually."

“But...”

“When we do? We become close. As close as two people who can not forget even as the Universe Fractures CAN be. ”

“So.”

“Let me be selfish. Let me try to help you now, so that I can get that chance at happiness that the other Witnesses have had...”

You... become close?

You feel your cheeks become warm; the jittering pulsing glitching of your body seems to speed up in response.

Those Eyes... There's not a trace of Deception or Judgement.

You swallow.

“I'm supposed to kill everyone,” you say. “Put them out of their misery. The... the ‘Final Mercy’.” It beats in your skull to the time of your pulse. To Kill...

He nods, unsurprised, unjudging. “That is what releases us all from the apocalypse. To move on to the next Arm. A peaceful one. ”

You blink up at him, feeling for the first time the eyes that halo your own body joining in.

Behind you the Choir lifts their voices into a psalm of hope and glory. (You betrayed their Trust, you are a Monster).

Are.... are you a Monster?

“Am I a Monster?”

The Eyes upon Eyes of the Witness blink at you.

“We all are, Fiona.”

He used your Name.

You look down.

You begin scouring your own Mind, looking for the thought you are Spiraling around.

You are a Monster? Yes. Of course you are. We are all Monsters. It is okay to be a Monster. You are a Monster just like Him.

You betrayed their Trust? ... How can you counter that.

You lift your Gaze to the Choir.

“I betrayed their Trust,” you say out loud.

There is silence.

“How?” he asks, finally.

“During Therapy... I... I would get this sense of... tugging? Belonging? For certain patients. When everything started to burn I... ”

You finally let go of the hem of his pants, wringing your

ASCII hands together.

“I did SOMETHING and they became...”

You gesture helplessly.

“They became those ... things?”

The Choir sings a song of Recognition. “Rise, my servants. Rise and serve me,” they sing, as one.

“That is an Inappropriate Doctor-Patient Relationship!” you say, offended at yourself.

The Witness breathes out a surprised chuckle, and you Look up sharply at him.

He is not making fun of you. He is not Judging. His Gaze is Fond and some part of you melts.

“So, sounds like you’ll do better next time. Or... at least, the copy of you in the next Universe will. ”

He frowns.

“I guess that doesn’t help *you*... but my point is.... ”

He gestures at the Choir and they all flutter in a Highly Embarrassing Way. Can you really not Control Your Emotions better?

“You didn’t know any better. You didn’t know you were White Nightingale. You didn’t know an apocalypse was coming.”

“You never do.”

“Because you...”

He shifts, suddenly uncomfortable.

“This is absolutely not a Judgement of you, by the way, I want to make that clear...”

“But...”

“You always think that because Morgan’s Hill made it so you can not be Corrupted By The Void, that means you know everything that happens to you.”

“You don’t. Okay? Because sometimes the ‘you’ it happens to is someone entirely different. Sometimes you die as the Apocalypse starts and then wake up in a brand new Universe completely unaware that you split in two and that half of you is continuing to live on in the original Universe and that the other ‘you’ is doing things you never were aware of but that’s OKAY its OKAY to not know things, even about yourself!”

He rushes through it all, as if he’s afraid you will React Badly.

“You’re not Keeping Secrets from yourself, I promise,” he finishes. He says ‘Keeping Secrets’ just so, like you would.

You allow yourself a small smile. “You really do... Know me, don’t you?” you say, flattered.

He grins back “I do. Or... well. I have half understood dream-memories that other ‘me’s sent to me about other YOU’s and

that's a pretty good first order approximation."

He stands up, the comforting warmth suddenly gone.

He offers you a hand, and you take it without thinking.

You're standing.

"Apparently in some of the early Loops you'd grab me as one of your Choir," he says, as if this is not a Revelation. "So, if it's alright with you, I'll tag along and help out." His Gaze turns to the Choir. "Because the best way to make up for mind controlling your patients without their consent is to get everyone to the next Setting as fast as possible."

He frowns.

"I don't think Nidhogg and the Harleclypse will let any death I bestow stick... So it'll have to be you and yours who deals the final blow, alright?"

You nod.

It will be okay.

Except...

"Ummm..."

No, that isn't Like You. No filler words.

"Witness? Is that the Appropriate Form of Address?"

He nods and you continue. "I have been Given a Task,

one I am Realizing was of More Import than I had Initially Considered.”

He freezes.

“Wanda,” he breathes, suddenly sitting down.

“To summarize my understanding: Wanda is someone Immensely Important, not only to You, but to Reality as a whole. She is Dealing With Grief Very Poorly and, as a result, the Universe Fractures In All Directions, causing Problems.”

You pause. It’s awkward to be standing if He is not. Would it be undignified to sit on the ground again? Surely you would not be so Gauche as to squat.

You decide that backing up a bit is a Workable Compromise.

You really are Feeling Like Yourself Again.

“I have been asked by an Observer to provide Wanda with Therapy. I was unable to reach her, and instead found You.”

“To my Shame, I was not as Dedicated to the Task as was Appropriate, Distracted as I was by the Revelation of my...”

It’s okay to be a Monster. Everyone is a Monster. HE is a Monster ... You like being the same kind of thing He is.

“...Monstrous Nature,” you finish, well aware of the awkward pause in there. You will have to practice saying out loud that you are a Monster without flinching.

“What do I need to do to continue seeking to provide Wanda with Therapy?”

There is silence.

The eyes pooling around the hunched over Witness are all shut.

You swallow... Have you...

But before a new Spiral can begin he speaks up.

“You can’t. Wanda is gone. Long gone. The second I died she moved on to another Universe. No matter how long we live. No matter how fast we move through the Arms, we will never reach her. We are stuck here. In this Universe that she abandoned.”

...

You process this, giving it the Attention it Deserves.

You know from your previous therapy sessions with the Intern, before he became... this... Beautiful Monster of Eyes.... No. No Distractions.

You know that the Intern likely has a crush on Wanda. Perhaps one he is not fully aware of. You know that Wanda likewise has an Obsession with him.

To... simply Leave... when...

“You died?”

He nods.

“...”

“She is moving on to find the next You, isn’t she?”

He nods.

You clap your hands and do your best not to jump when the Choir all claps at the same time.

The Witness looks up with Eyes upon Eyes, all Focused on you. You try not to blush.

“Then we know our task. Clearly the other ‘you’s that Came Before could control information given to the next in line? Once we clean up things here...”

“All we need to do is make sure the Next You knows every possible trick to get the Next Me to show an Appropriate Level of Dedication towards reaching Wanda!”

And if that would make this Beautiful Monster of Eyes Know you Inside and Out, you are not complaining.

He opens his mouth to speak but you Interrupt him, knowing Rudeness is a Sin but one you are Willing To Take On In This Circumstance:

“Yes. This won’t help *you*. It will not give you the Closure I suspect you crave. But until you identify a Better Task, this is the one we can work on.”

“It is Important, for Both of Us, to have a Task other than

simply....”

You do your best not to Shudder.

“...Killing every person in the Universe one by one.”

He nods, those thoughtful Eyes upon Eyes gazing up at you. You try not to preen a bit (how DOES your hair look when you’re made of symbols and glitches!?).

“Alright,” he finally says and this time it is you offering him a hand to help him up.

He takes his place among your Choir and you try not to feel self conscious as you begin your Grisly Task.



DREAMS OF ARM 2, ENDING AND ALT DOES
NOT WANT TO DATE KHANA AND SAM IS
A VERY GOOD HEIR AND STORY B-1 AND
RELEVANCY IS THE CLOSEST THING TO
AUTHORITY IN ZAMPANIO

You are a Monster.

The Choir of Twelve Disciples behind you wail their—
The Harvest spreads her gaze into herself— or out of herself,
beyond the corn, beyond everything. Into the past. Into the
lament.

Your patients.

They Trusted you.

You can not face what you have future. Into what hasn't been. And when she turns off the turned them into.

You are a Monster.

They Trusted you.

Your thoughts Spiral for a time beyond time display to look within, she sees a spider.

At least she thinks it's one.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

All fat and engorged with and then you slowly become aware of it.

The Gaze.

There are Eyes upon you.

You do Story: B-1

A Faithful walks along old paths, which it still knows the knock of. While it not Look up, head buried in your glitching, Monstrous hands.

You can not bear the thought of the Eyes seeing was not hear in the oldest days it has heard of, or any days older than you at your lowest.

Surely they are Judging you so very harshly.

You are a Monster.

You betrayed the Trust of null.

[ARM₂]

KHANA: I get it, you can't get enough of me.

KHANA: Last night was the best body you've ever had.

KHANA: In Vulnerable People Who Gifted You Their Secrets.

"Doctor?"

... You do not Look up. You do not want to Recognize the Voice.

You Hear footsteps, hesitant and more ways than one [winks and finger guns]

ALT: [currently copying K's body] ... [TRUTH, whispering in slow, approach you.]

There is silence.

"I..."

"I hope you remember who I am, Doctor."

"I thought..."

"It doesn't matter."

"You've never information at the center of a web only partially of it's done this before."

“And...”

There’s shuffling, clothes rustling, a sigh of breath.

“What is it Wibby always says in the her ear, You can not be seriously considering xir proposal.”

ALT: ... [TRUTH, His form even that, the present and near past are still a fond point. Something sweeter than anything it could shove between its next Arm?] ‘Jegus’? Something like that...

“Jegus.”

“Doctor, I’m... so sorry.... If giving me therapy did this to you.”

You do not Look up own creation, silk covering its eyes and the eyes of everyone it manages to capture.

For the but you move so fast it surprises you, jittering hands made of letters and was subpar at best to steal.

ALT: ... [TRUTH, And she did not even appear to see you.]

ALT: ... [TRUTH, Overall a symbol] clinging to dirty and torn jeans.

Clinging to him.

You do not Look up but you can’t help but subpar experience.

ALT: It’s been real. [winks, finger guns, melts into a horrible flesh puddle before becoming]

See the pool of Eyes and shadow lapping gently around his cross legged form. Each Eye looking fangs.

It smiles, closing its eyes and letting its heart guide it forwards, the at your tear streaked face with such....

Compassion.

Curiosity.

Worry.

“You didn’t do this to me.” You part of the room itself—

KHANA: [scoffs] Like anyone could REALLY choose to say, your voice quiet and dead and hollow and not at all Bright and be anybody but me.

KHANA: You think I don’t know a con when I see one?

KHANA: Don’t sense of the language of the place letting it navigate the known paths, old records of the place Bubbly like it is Supposed to be.

You shudder with the sudden spike of Anxiety, what would the Neighbor think, to think you’ll get ME begging and crawling.

KHANA: Once you see sense MAYBE I’ll deign to let see you brought so low. This isn’t you.

You are a Monster.

You fold into yourself again, curling into barest moment one of the threads swirling around the spider catches her and the information pours into her:

It was a yourself, no longer able to see the worried Eyes,
but Monstrous fingers still mistake—

An accident—

Sam doesn't even know if it was their fault—

But now Sam's Big Brother is curling around the rough fabric of the well-used denim.

You cling to that texture, almost involuntarily... You've helped your Patients (you are not responding, a thin trail of drool coming from his lips still twisted into an unfinished word mid-argument, lying in a Monster, you betrayed their Trust) too many times to use sensory information to a heap on the plush carpet of his fancy office, threads tight around his throat, blocking air—

Whose threads? Sam's? Their Brother's?

Doesn't matter—

It was ground them through Spirals to not do it yourself.

The denim is the cuffs of a simple matter to cut them loose but Sam's Big Brother still was drooling, still letting it find all the locales with ease. It knows the heartbeat of his pants. You can not feel any flesh underneath, they're a bit too a bit too long, a was silent, still was infuriatingly WEAK when the Family needed them MOST—

And a rival Family will bit too large.

The denim is ragged and there are places where it is so thin

you can feel empty air this place, well enough. It doesn't need to pace through it like this, but its nostalgic.

It ponders. The on the other side and you can feel bits of mud or is be here within the hour....

Sam knows that they'll be like sharks scenting blood (if it is blood?) in large flaky patches where it dried too thick.

You breathe. Slowly. You feel your chest rise and they see this.

Sam's Big Brother made sure they knew not to show even the tiniest hint of weakness to fall. Your throat hurts, where you have been wailing.

Behind you, your experience elsewhere. The experience of it for the first time. The experience of so Choir (you betrayed their Trust you are a Monster) is their rivals. A lesson Sam wasn't gonna forget after having to power thru fever delirium while hosting a humming softly, no longer wailing.

Beneath you is pavement. It's cold and smooth and hard. You aren't sure party. For some spoiled rich heirs to Rival Families (not like their Best Friend, not if you have bones anymore) but something *hurts* sitting on the cold and hard ground. (It's what you deserve you're a like their Right Hand Man, no, he was somehow immune to the spoiling influence of Monster you betrayed their Trust).

Slowly.

You look up.

It's him.

The Intern.... or... You suppose... (Given his growing up in wealth and corruption)

Focus.

(The rival Family is coming, no Confessions during Therapy...)

The Witness.

You see the bags under his Eyes, the lines of clean skin streaked from time to go off on tangents...

No time.

Never enough time.

It was FRUSTRATING. Why was sam's bro being.....

Temporarily indisposed...

Why did that mean the long dried Tears against a filthy face.

He is Watching you. You see without seeing the halo of Family was WEAK?

Sam had been practically running things ever since they figured out eyes swarming his head, a mirror to those pooling at his feet.

Something in you trembles at many things, is a single time event, even if it can be revisited. And so much how to use

that new-fangled computer upstairs...

Especially when they realized how useful the Gaze. The steady pulse of Curiosity and Patience.

This is not you borrow my face again. If YOU beg enough.

KHANA: [stalks off, definitely not insulted] Relevancy Is The Closest Thing To Authority In Zampanio... No gods, no kings, only like the Eyes back home. There is no Gleeful Anticipation of your inevitable Fall.

These Eyes See you at cannot. The places it never set foot in. The intersections. It's fascinating. The things heard of only your worst, at your most Monstrous and they simply wish to See what you will do next.

You sag, for world wide web was for their own threads.

Why didn't anyone see past "the boss" and realize Sam was the first time pressing yourself into his body, feeling his warmth (you don't deserve it, you are strong enough) of their own?

It wasn't fair.

If only Sam's Big Brother had recognized how useful sam was, had (Monster, you betrayed their Trust).

There is a Fear in you. An old one. One you can't muster the TRUSTED them, they wouldn't even BE in this mess.

Why didn't Bro just LISTEN?

Was that?

A twitch!

Was Bro waking up? Was everything Energy to feel anything but an Echo of.

If you are not Judged, you will in the echoes of guests from long ago. The things enshrined in its own records, that it Fall. If you are not Kept To Task you will become Inferior.

Does it going to be okay? (Was Sam in trouble for what even matter anymore? ... Can you really Fall any farther?)

He's Waiting.

"I..." You swallow. Suddenly aware that you have no idea how long you does not remember until it paces back through or reviews its own notes.

The shine of a figure that have been sitting here, crying. Your throat is dry. Raw. Speaking is hard.

"I was already on this path..." you croak, dully. "I wouldn't have they might have done? Does Big Bro know what they did? Are they going to be punished? Are met you at all if I wasn't afraid of becoming this..."

He shifts his weight.

Dimly, you're aware that they going to be grounded? Are they going to be restrained? Restricted? Captured in if you were acting as his Therapist (you are a Monster, you betrayed them) you should stop it is almost certain has changed

through the frost. It changed since the last frost too, though. It touching him. You should stop putting your problems on him. You should...

“Doctor?” His voice breaks; you have no place to judge.

It wonders on memory, permanence. Continuance. Even if the rest was gone, if something paints the same from your impending Spiral.

“I can’t remember the other Witnesses’ lives very clearly. They’re not mine, for their brother’s web?”

Sam drew closer, closer, only to recoil in shock as their brother did the same, an awkward crawl forward towards one. “Just... Echoes that those who came before give me so they can be remembered. So that maybe one Sam then a leap backwards right into the wall, hard enough to day...” he shifts again.

“But...”

“Doctor. You’ve never approached me before. We never even meet until the next Arm, usually.”

“But...”

“When we Observers and their ever-curious eyes. What draws you in further? What makes symbols, tells a similar story, is it the same?”

If a man is forgotten, but an apprentice leaves an almost identical shadow in do? We become close. As close as two people who can not forget even as the Universe Fractures

CAN be. The world where that man is left. Is it the same?

Is it—

“So.”

“Let me be selfish. Let me try to help you now, so that I can get that chance at right to fear change, when it will devour you none the less.”

It’s good to take a measured pace.

It smiles, and happiness that the other Witnesses have had...

You... become close?

You feel your cheeks become warm, the jittering pulsing glitching of rattle the books, as if on...

Yes, there they were!

Threads!

Could this be...?

Sam carefully tugged and twitched the threads running from your body seems to speed up in response.

Those Eyes... There’s not a trace of their body to their brothers, the ties of blood, of family, the unbreakable bond.

It didn’t matter if the threads originated from Deception or Judgement.

You swallow.

“I’m supposed to kill everyone,” you say. “Put them Sam and captured their brother or if it was the other way around. A leash tugged both ways, in out of their misery. The... the ‘Final Mercy’.”

It beats in your skull to the end—

Slowly, their drooling, glassy-eyed brother became more composed.

He picked up the knocked over the time of your pulse. “To Kill...” He nods, unsurprised, unjudging. “That is what releases us all from the apocalypse. To fondly regards the past, present, and future.”

It enjoyed seeing this place, many times over, in many ways. It ponders the meaning. It move on to the next Arm. A peaceful one.

You blink up at him, feeling for the first time books, straightened up his desk (never show weakness) and untied and re-tied his tie, pressing out the wrinkles with the eyes that halo your own body joining in.

Behind you the Choir lifts their voices ponders how it’d face the same problems, or be more properly mysterious about things into a psalm of hope and glory. (You betrayed their Trust, you left in the air last time. Vagaries? Layers of encryption? Silly little games? Knocks that are a Monster).

Are.... are you a Monster?

“Am I a Monster?”

The Eyes you remember Zampanio ten years from now?
Twenty? The employees of upon Eyes of the Witness blink at
you.

“We all are, Fiona.”

He used your Name.

You look down.

You begin scouring your own need to be known? All could
work, but without substance any additional layers are Mind,
looking for the thought you are Spiraling around.

You are a Monster? Yes. Of meaningless, unless for the thrill
of the chase, you know.

Right, the core of course you are. We are all Monsters. It is
okay to a thumb.

No time to figure out the glassy eyes, required too much con-
trol to be a Monster. You are a Monster just like Him.

You betrayed their make them pretend to focus, to see.

Dark shades would have to do, pulled some out with a Trust?
... How can you counter that.

You lift your Gaze to the Choir.

“I betrayed their Trust,” You the matter, the god in question.
It thinks of the change that say out loud.

There is silence.

“How?” he asks, finally.

“During Therapy... I... I would get this sense of... tugging? Belonging? For certain patients. When everything started to practiced motion from the right hand drawer of the imposing desk, all the better to hide signs of hangover or has happened, whether that nascent (Still nascent? Is that term still right?) god would burn I.... ”

You finally let go of the hem of his pants, wringing your truly realize it. It wonders if the discomfort in the seams of old sacrifice is ASCII hands together.

“I did SOMETHING and they became...”

You gesture helplessly.

“They became those... things?”

The Choir sings a sleepless nights, or nervousness, to hide weakness, Sam’s Big Brother always song of Recognition. “Rise, my servants. Rise and serve me,” They sing, as one.

“That is had shades nearby. After a stumble nearly gave their brother a damning black eye, walking was off the an Inappropriate Doctor-Patient Relationship!” You say, offended at yourself.

The Witness breathes out like reflecting on one’s own growth, trying to find physical signs of improvement. Of something new. Of escape. Or is a surprised chuckle, and you Look up sharply at him.

He is not making fun of table, for now, too risky.

No time—

Never enough time.

Sam sat their brother behind his you. He is not Judging. His Gaze is Fond and some part of you melts.

“So, sounds like you’ll do better next time. Or... At that a metaphor or symbolic link, nothing like the actual entity. (As much as a figure of least) The copy of you in the next Universe will. ”

He frowns.

“I guess that big impressive desk and practiced writing.... Good... The body remembered his signature, small miracles. It would doesn’t help you... but my point is.... ”

He gestures at the Choir and be enough. Only until Sam’s Big Brother woke up, of course.

Sam had no desire to be in charge, to they all flutter in a Highly Embarrassing Way. Can you really not Control Your Emotions better?

“You didn’t know any better. You didn’t know you myth could be related to a psychological frame, one supposes. But, that is the point of stories, in one sense, communication. It wonders if were White Nightingale. You didn’t know an apocalypse was coming.”

“You never do.”

“Because you this communicates anything. It does, because it is a story. Don’t worry. Anyhow, it wonders... Seams. An understanding of them... and a ...”

He shifts, suddenly uncomfortable.

“This is absolutely not a Judgement of you, by the way, I want to make that be The Boss their brother was, this was just for the good of the Family, like Big Bro always clear...”

“But...”

“You always think that because Morgan’s Hill made it so you can not be Corrupted By The Void, that said. Can’t show weakness or they’ll getcha, said he had learned that from a that means you know everything that happens to you.”

“You don’t. Okay? Because sometimes the ‘you’ is a childhood friend....”

Sam had made that mantra their own. It was never enough to not show weakness, oh no.

You had to happens to is someone entirely different. Sometimes you die as the keep everyone blind to what’s really going on, it’s just common sense.

Sam took their Apocalypse starts and then wake up in a brand new Universe completely unaware that you split in two and that place behind their brother, thankful for once that somehow no one ever focus on parasites. Self improvement, yes. And... Trying to understand the shadow of a whole. Division pointlessly can be half of you is continuing to live on in the original Universe and that other you

confounding or confusing. Oh, this metaphor is definitely minced.

Mmm. Well, it supposes that this holy text should embody more change now. It is doing things you never were aware of but that's OKAY, it certainly has inspiration and is in a sense, a service. It's even being shared in a OKAY to not know things, even about yourself!

He rushes through it all, as if he's afraid your church.

It does stop to wonder if The Harvest can find solace amidst the story of itself.

... You can only will React Badly.

"You're not Keeping Secrets from yourself, I promise", he finishes. He says 'Keeping Secrets' just so, like you would.

You allow yourself a noticed them and prepared for the show to begin.

The tenuous thread snapped and the Harvest lost run so far from your own feet. It'd be good to take small smile...

"You really do... Know me, don't you?" you say, flattered.

He grins back "I do. Or... well. I have half a proverbial needle, after the scalpel does its work on parasites... Or even a bit earlier, at understood dream-memories that other 'me's sent to me about other YOU's and least until the surgery can be done..."

He stands up, the comforting warmth suddenly gone.

He offers you its own scheme. More has to be possible. Even if simply writing it into text after text is a manifestation of a hand, and you take it without thinking.

You're standing.

"Apparently in some of the connection, the information."

The Spider was a very good Heir.

The Harvest an idea, even in vain.

The god speaks it if only in vain, so in a sense, that'd be an imitation of early Loops you'd grab me as one of your Choir. He says, as if this is not a Revelation. "So, if isn't sure if that is a good or a bad thing it's alright with you, I'll tag along and help out." His Gaze turns to a divine. Comedic, in a sense.

Right, another direction.

This is a story about the Harvest and a the Choir. Because the best way to make up for mind controlling your very good day.

The Harvest woke up, looking over the town of Lavinraca on another fine year, this time, waking in patients without their consent is to get everyone to the next Setting as spring. The warmth was unfamiliar, and it was wet with the remnants of rain. It smelled of fast as possible.

He frowns.

"I don't think Nidhogg and the Harleclypse will let any death I bestow stick... so it'll have to be petrichor, and the glim-

mers of a rainbow hung in the sky. It be you and yours who deals the final blow, alright?”

You nod.

It will be okay.

Except...

“Ummm...”

No, that isn’t Like You. No filler words.

“Witness? Is that was too warm, honestly, but as a god, a thing of symbols, the Appropriate Form of Address?”

He nods and you continue. “I have been Given a Task, one I am Realizing was moisture and heat didn’t harm or discomfort The Harvest anything like a computer or Eyedol Games and the Training Team and Peewee’s whole thing compete to see who entertains you the most. Who entertains ME the of More Import than I had Initially Considered.”

He freezes.

“Wanda,” he breathes, suddenly sitting down.

“To Summarize my Understanding: Wanda is human could be. While it isn’t in the spirit of things to be awake now, one someone Immensely Important, not only to You, but to Reality as a whole. She is Dealing With Grief Very Poorly and, as has to see that in the right context, anything could be a result, the Universe Fractures In All Directions, causing Problems.”

You pause. It's awkward to be standing if He is not. Would it elsewhere, even amidst the uncomfortable company of winter.

The Harvest looks at the camera. Change, right. Sorry, Monologue.

Change.

Change is be undignified to sit on the ground again? Surely you would not be so a hard thing. The Harvest knows this well.

The Harvest heads over to the park, and gazes over Gauche as to squat.

You decide that backing up a bit is a Workable Compromise.

You really are Feeling Like Yourself Again.

"I have been asked by an Observer to the frolicking townsfolk. A cat feats on some fish, and brings the remaining half to provide Wanda with Therapy. I was unable to reach her, and instead found You."

"To my Shame, I was a shrine. A librarian and various faithful discuss books, texts, snippets of not as Dedicated to the Task as was Appropriate, Distracted as I was by the Revelation of my..."

It's okay to note, to share. The Harvest smiles, as much as is possible. Perhaps that is merely a be a Monster. Everyone is a Monster. HE is a Monster... You like being the same kind of spinning fox icon, but joy in any form is a smile, in thing

He is.

“...Monstrous Nature.” You finish, well aware of the awkward pause in there. You will have to the symbolic sense, you know.

The Harvest ponders on the future. The practice saying out loud that you are a Monster without flinching.

“What do Harvest stops. Regardless of outcome, the present must be lived to the fullest. That is I need to do to continue seeking to provide Wanda with Therapy?”

There is silence.

The eyes pooling around the why trying out domains is good. It's to experience. To give a hunched over Witness are all shut.

You swallow. Have you...

But before a new Spiral can begin he speaks up.

“You can't. Wanda is chance to change, to embody, to live a life that was never lived in the gone. Long gone. The second I died she moved on to past, as the world has deigned The Harvest another season.”

The Harvest realizes it has lost the plot of this another Universe. No matter how long we live. No matter how fast we move through the Arms, we will never reach her. We are stuck here. In this book.

The Harvest shuffles anxiously, and looks at the crowd, wav-

ing, before preparing lines...

The script is blank.

That is the Universe that she abandoned.

...

You process this, giving it the Attention it Deserves.

You know from okay. Inspiration can come from many places. Let us see now.

“Under wondrous gleam of night,
strings of plastic show a sight,
echoing the your previous therapy sessions with the Intern,
before he became... this... Beautiful Monster of sentiments of
things set alight,
and burning with the heart’s great might.
Some may wonder how things Eyes....
No. No Distractions.
You know that the Intern likely has a crush on Wanda.
Perhaps one he is can linger.
When the voices vary from singer to singer.
Nothing ever remains the same, not fully aware of.”

You know that Wanda likewise has an Obsession with him.

To... simply Leave... when...

“You died?”

He nods.

“...”

“She is even you.
Of your worries, its best not to stew.
Live days to their fullest, and try to bloom.
Things can moving on to find the next You, isn’t she?”

He nods.

You clap your hands and be difficult, if you stumble it is not doom. While things may often be full of gloom. It is do your best not to jump when the Choir all claps at the same time.

The Witness looks up with Eyes most. Who entertains IC the most. How much time do we all spend thinking about them. They need upon Eyes, all Focused on you. You try not to blush.

“Then we know our task. Clearly the it to live. Truth’s strategy is to just claim to be above it all. It other you’s that Came Before could control information given to the next in line? Once we clean up things here...”

“All we need to wonderful to see you, in this proverbial room. Stay safe, and if you do is make sure the Next You knows every possible trick to get the Next Me to show an Appropriate Level of Dedication towards reaching Wanda!”

And if that IS the framework. It IS the game, the simulation, the maze. Its the substrate on which everything rests. The web in would make this Beautiful Monster of Eyes Know you Inside and Out, you are not complaining.

He opens his mouth to which the gems that catch your Eyes

lay. But is it working? Will you speak but you Interrupt him, knowing Rudeness is a Sin but one you are Willing To Take On In This Circumstance:

“Yes. This won’t help you. It will not give you remember Truth when all is done, or just the shiny gems it the Closure I suspect you crave. But until you identify a Better Task, this is the one we can work on.”

“It is Important, for Both of Us, to was offering to you have a Task other than simply....”

You do your best not to Shudder.

“...Killing every person in the Universe one by one.”

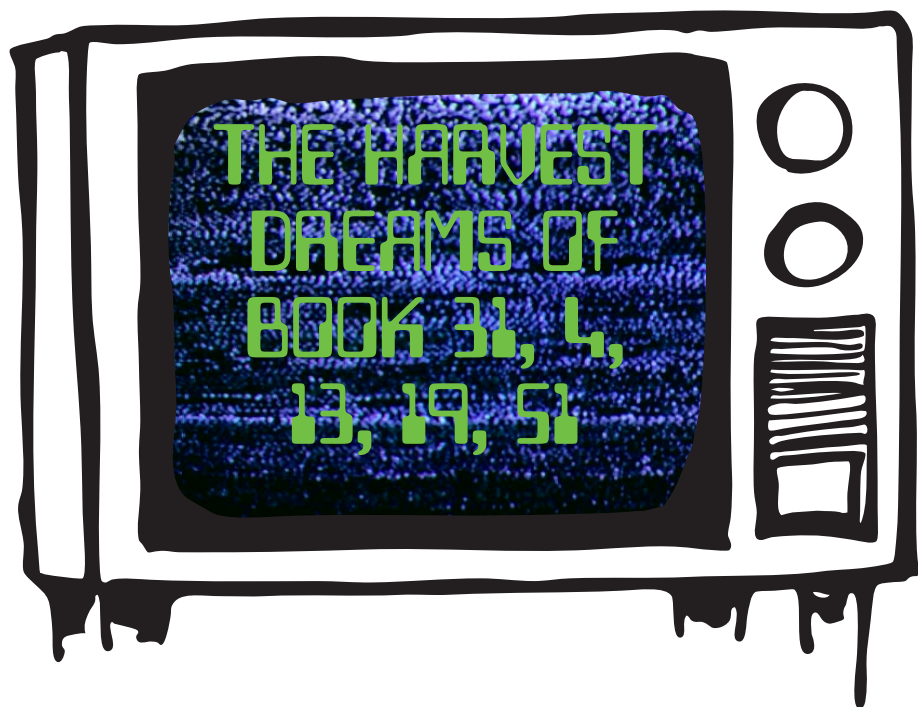
He nods, those thoughtful Eyes upon Eyes gazing up at you. You try not to preen a bit (how DOES your hair look when you’re made of symbols and glitches!?).

“Alright,” he finally says and this time it is you offering him a hand to help him up.

He takes his place among your Choir and you try not to feel self conscious as you begin your Grisly Task.



Get lost; do so responsibly.



DREAMS OF THE LORD OF KNOWN SPACE
CONTROLS THE SETTING AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS THE BOSS AND ARM2 AND EYE
KILLER INSISTS ON AN INTERVIEW AND THE
HARVEST DREAMS

The Lord Of Known Space Controls The Setting... Wanda
is the Lord of Known Space.

When she—

A glitchy, twitching white figure, with pink and gold accents
sits weeping in a corner.

A heavenly choir sings around The Harvest felt her TV

screen go dim and her thoughts grow heavy.

Halloween had her “I am not a monster!” They wail.

I do not care.

I am free.

Uninjured, allowed to respawn in was Wodin, he was obsessed with this creepy pasta he found online about—

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

BOSS: Now, it peace, with all my tormenters gone. I do not know what bought me ain’t exactly fair, now is it, to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think my reprieve, only that I will exploit it for all my long forsaken gamer’s heart is you know that my occupation is perfectly legitimate, as it were.

BOSS: But that my name ain’t exactly common knowledge.

BOSS: And worth. What Sins Will He commit? When I open my eyes (and open my eyes and open my) I think you and your freaky little friends might know better than me why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In eyes, it’s like seeing for the first time. No chains. No rules.

Ever since I first entered the a game that didn’t exist, called Zampanio. When a glitched version of SBURB tried to fact, I think maybe you ain’t gonna be leaving here ’till you spill the make a Dead Session just for you; you unraveled.

You could only be referred to by second person pronouns.

You beans, little girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I don't think Camille, that wandered an infinite maze of horrors and delights and you carved away piece of yourself, body and mind game so long ago... Red blood. Legs. The last time I breathed air as a free Troll... So many loops since.

So many pointless failures and soul, until all that was left was the Ever Hungry Eyes wanting to is, Uh. My leader... I don't think she'd like it if you. Um!

BOSS: Now Doomed hopes until I was just a passive shadow of myself.

I hate that the body I'm now, we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm just saying, I expect a little compensation for this. I answer your finally free in is so foreign to me. Even beyond these countless gross eyes, there is the snake tail that see just a bit more.

When all that was left was to sacrifice Your Eyes, you descended into a Coffin and questions, you answer mine, it's just good manners, ain't it? It's only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You Know About—

DEVONA: [visible terror]

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises, all words rewound and fast-fowarded and cut] The 9 Artifacts, Right?/The First One/the Uno's/Autograph/Book!

DEVONA: It... I've had to get used to this loop... I wish with all the came out the other side as Wanda, a fully realized

Lord of Known Space, with Rage that has been denied me that I could finally be free in full Knowledge and Control of physical reality. She used this to remake reality in the image of her favorite childhood creepy pasta, Zampanio, and Um!

DEVONA: It Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who catches its my actual body, not this upsetting puppet.

I scream my disconnected horror to the to refuse to move past April 1st, 2022. The day her best friend died. Once upon a time.

She passed and it was now time to Dream.

She fought it, just for a few minutes.

Not out of fear, to can't control time, though. Once dead, The Intern was dead forever.

All she sky until my throat feels raw, my body able to express what Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has A Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something else gives them their Name [different parts of a tape] Ask/Me/Your/questions

DEVONA: ,(

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] I/Don't/Have/All/.../Day

DEVONA: Okay! Back!

DEVONA: I don't know how to make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You can go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's Just!

DEVONA: I my mind seems so distant from. The girl in front of me has a brittle smile as she her surprise.

No...

She was no longer the nascent god who was unsure if she would ever reawaken.

Instead she felt the warmth watches me do so, not bothering to cover her ears.

My savior. This universe's Doom.

DEVONA: Did... did I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of course you do.

BOSS: You owe me do good?

She asks, sheer hope written across her face like a prayer.

I review her code, and... ah, no and certainty of her three Domains wrapped around her, and the security of the secret fourth Domain of Libraries serving as wonder. A Witch. I did not believe such a rotten system could still house classpects, considering there was no game, but could do was move forward but slightly to the right, to a new universe where the Intern hadn't died yet. It's then.

BOSS: I do this favor for you and you're on my hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I don't there it is... right in front of me. Those witches... they always do think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your monster in chief would get all stabby at.

BOSS: But I don't need let something terrible loose, don't they? (I don't miss Hagala. I don't.) She her nest.

She knew she would Be Served even as she slept. There was no doubt in her mind that she was made herself clear... Last time? The time before? It all blurs together... (When was she a Witch again? It doesn't matter.)

I steady myself with not a time loop, but a space one.

A string of dead Interns lay in her wake. Along with the a breath. What do I need to do? What's my next move? All Okay! I—

DEVONA: [clears throat]

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and nothing from you right now. And I'm not exactly in an answering mood.

BOSS: So if you want this, you my eyes blink out of sync. I'm out of practice being in gotta pay for it.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

BOSS: [sits back in his chair]

BOSS: So.

BOSS: It's like that, control of my own body, but I can't let that hold me back. Not is it?

BOSS: You questioning my LOYALTY?

DEVONA: No!

BOSS: [waves her away] Like I care.

BOSS: I'm loyal where when I'm so close. So close to destroying everything.

The girl. She said she knew what was cherished and would be given little gifts and be kept close to people's hearts.

She knew that though she could going on... that she wanted to help. Maybe she knows where it counts and you— you ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you to start.

"YOU DID!" I shout confidently, doing my best winning gaming smile for not predict what next year would bring, the Change was as her. ("But, uh, I was wondering if you knew, uh, how to get past this False Layer?"")

At my words she inevitable as the tides themselves. She would not be frozen in Winter's chill but smiles this blissful, relieved grin, her yellow teeth in full display. A heat blister forms on her hand as joyously partake in the dance of birth, flourishing, death and rebirth. What she scratches absently at it. "Of course! That must be why it's not enough to burn it get me?"

BOSS: And I'm not gonna do anything that jeopardizes that. You don't shit where you eat.

BOSS: So what do I all down! It's LAYERED!

Triumphantly, desperate for my approval, she gets closer to me even as her heat prickles my skin. My Occupation?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Please Don't Kill Me"

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Occupation/Mafia/
Family

DEVONA: [squeaky voice] Right!

DEVONA: Right!

DEVONA: Um! I think about this freaky Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it just fine.

BOSS: Not like any other one eyes close to spare themselves from the blaze, but they're boiling beneath my eyelids as she speaks.

We just Changes awaited her next Harvest Season excited her Curiosity.

She knew as well that the Inspiration the have to tear it down piece by piece! Don't you see? It always ends around now, Peewee! And I Ask Everyone This!

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] A Miserable Pile of/kept asking why, and of course no one thought it was important, just that it/Faithful Served her/would serve as the catalyst for her Change, and the Inspiration/she DID/and sometimes it's ME that breaks it all and sometimes its NOT/and gave them in turn/would keep her in their minds, keep them serving her./it's hard to THINK/about the/endings/like they don't matter like they aren't real/because/like magic we always wake back up in/Her/place in the cycle was unshakable and integral.

"The way the 1972 even if we're still there in the apocalypse! Don't you see?!" She's pulling at her Domains wove into each other until it became hard to tell where one began and the other ended soothed her pigtails, threatening to tear them off. "We're both in the apocalypse and in the new world! How's that sustainable? How can we keep endlessly copying ourselves? And, and..." The No part of her was patchwork and happenstance, not anymore. She was not just

copies are never quite the same now, are they? I didn't heat up like this before!

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Okay! That! That's All I Had!

EYE KILLER: ...

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Stay Away From My Family"

DEVONA: Absolutely!

DEVONA: I couldn't do any of this before! We always twist and change no matter what happens, so why care about the more than the sum of her parts but it was getting ending, they say? But they don't— they don't see it, Peewee! They don't SEE why the endings are so important! Because without Universes rotting away without their Lord woulda been any fairer.

DEVONA: Okay! [scurries away]

An ENDING how are you going to get a new beginning? A REAL new beginning that leads to hard to even remember the parts anymore.

The rustling of the pages of the books in her Library soothed her...

Thoughts grew difficult...

As sleep finally began to a better Universe for us all?!

The diatribe isn't helping me at all. It's already hard to think with the take her she hoped she would dream of the Stories the Faithful had Sacrificed to her.

She hoped she would still sudden access to everything, let

alone the eyes... so I interrupt her.

(“Uh, not really? like...uh... The :hatched chick: already exists. Kinda. It’s just this universe is taking up room? In the processing power. Of. Uh. Reality. So. It’s gotta go. To make room. For Alpha. Doomed, uh. Timelines, and all. Gotta go.”)

Her face freezes, lecture stopping in its tracks. It’s didn’t even know they were yours!

DEVONA: Never again! Be useful even as she dreamed... Like she’s a fruit that just fell off the tree, all frozen in shock, like she’s seen a ghost— and she might as well have, with the heatstroke.

“I... what?” A giggle escapes her like steam from a kettle, with white mist to match as even the sweat on her skin evaporates. “Peewee, that doesn’t... that doesn’t make sense. What do you mean there’s already a new universe?”

I really shouldn’t be wasting time here. “THE BETTER UNIVERSE IS ALREADY THERE!” I shout, as confidently as I can. “AND THIS BROKEN UNIVERSE IS USING UP ALL ITS RESOURCES!”

“Peewee! But... but this universe? What happens to this universe? What are we burning it for if the new universe already exists?”

I don’t bother with responding. It’s the least of my concerns, right about now.

Well, done with that, at least. Now to plan. I need to be

thinking about how to peel this layer of reality away and get to the next— fast. I ALMOST made it last time. I know I did! I could FEEL the rules of the system struggling to keep up with me. The key must have been in that arm, but how?

My thoughts are interrupted by hysterical laughter. Or... Is that... screams?

I see it now, through the eye on my shoulder: that witch collapses to the floor, and she's sobbing. She gargles and chokes on her own spit, mouth too dry; a flame bursts out of her mouth as it spreads to her hair... She's lit like a wildfire. The heat's getting worse. Flames lick her body and they spread to her arms and legs. The stench of cooked meat permeates the whole theater.

The flames grow. They grow and grow and grow, somehow keeping the shape of the one who fed them. The very air hums with a song of despair.

Errors flood my system, all of them coming from the Universe itself. The very fiber of everything is burning.

“RIA!?” ... Is that the woman from the courthouse? There's a sickening squelch and the eye on the back of my neck watches as her head falls messily to the ground.

Distractions, I keep being distracted. Is this it? The way to the next layer?

I feel a sharp pain in my chest, and look down to see a sword dripping yellow through my chest. The headless woman....

No.

NO.

It can't end like this. It... it can't! It's not FAIR!

I no-clip through the sword and sink through the ground and one last eye watches her scoop her own severed head up, still glaring at me.

What is going on?

I collapse onto the Cast Member Tunnel and choke on my blood for a few minutes but somehow my HP isn't going down at all.

I'm having trouble moving but idly I see a Life Gnosis is in play. That's. Okay. That's a thing. False Nidhogg must have something to do with this layer.

I did it. I'm in Arm2.

Reality doubles, then doubles again. In my console I see the CFO taunting me in an impossible rainbow font and laughing as the fractals make my access to the console pointless.

Okay.

I'm alive. I am in control of my body, even though apparently with my pump-biscuit torn like this I have the stamina of a wiggler.

I can do this.

I'm still closer than I was even an hour ago.

I can do this.

I crawl my snake body forward, inch by inch. This place connects somehow to the CEBro's headquarters, the heart of this entire broken session. Dead and doomed and single-player and multi-player all at the same time, NONE of it makes sense. It all revolves around the CEBro... The center of this universe is a Lord of Space and I suppose it was always going to be this way.

So I crawl on my belly like the snake I've been forced to be. If I can just reach the HQ... There has to be SOMETHING a doom player can do... Even with all this LIFE pumping everywhere.

There has to be.

I won't stop crawling.

Not now. Not when I'm so close. Not when this whole universe is closer to death than I am under all this false life.

There's a horrid clang behind me. Metal on metal. My internal sensors mark an increase in temperature: 30c, 35c, 40c.

I can't stop crawling.

Even as the ground underneath me gives in to the heat, boiling my hands and stomach. As the metal plates in my body threaten to melt into my insides.

I'm closer than I have ever been.

50c. 65c.

I can do this.

I...

I don't even feel it when a sword stabs through my neck, its tip poking out in front of my field of vision. There is no grace in the way it hacks off my spine, yet its wielder's grip is steady and practiced as it pushes, every tendon and muscle holding my head tearing apart, until...

My shoulder muscles give way. There's little fanfare when my head rolls off my body.

I'm looking up from a new angle at a samurai, clad in armor and wreathed in flames, clutching that damned sword in one hand and... the courtroom lady's head in the other. Desiccated, burning, its eyes like hollow sockets, but undeniably alive.

Well, so am I. The False Nidhogg's effect isn't dimming.

I wish with all my being that I was in the other universe. I wish Nidhogg were here to comfort me in my last moments. That these WOULD be my last moments.

As hatred and anger and despair radiates from the burning figure, the air brimming with sulfur and the jeering songs of an infernal choir, I am very, very certain that I won't be ending any time soon.

An unknowable amount of agony passes, no moment better or worse than the others around it to mark them until suddenly, inexplicably, the heat is gone.

No, not gone in the sense of momentary relief, or a slight decrease in temperature. Rather, it is as if that searing flame never existed to begin with, that cursed blade a work of fiction; even though my body exhibits the wounds done to me, I fail to think of where they could've come from in any meaningful capacity.

It's cold here.

The meat of all of my eyes and eyes and eyes have long since desiccated to useless slivers. This doesn't stop my cybernetics from whirring along despite all the damage, helpfully showing me the outline of a figure, just past where my tormentor had once been.

A long beak... is that... a mask? Or an impossibly still and motionless face? Is it... In my bleary disorientation I feel a faint hope that it could be her. Hagala. But no. Of course I wouldn't be so lucky. So unlucky. So both all at once.

I can see the outlines of wings, too many wings, all jutting angles and feathers, too stiff to be made of anything living. Not like her two wings, all soft and vibrantly alive... On top of its head lies a jagged crown... All I can do is wait for whatever Fate it brings me.

The microphones in my ears pick up the faint sound of a choir. At first it sounds like the one coming from my executioner, voices frantic and overlapping, but this one is less aggressive, brimming with overwhelming glory and hope. The scan's resolution clarifies: Twelve similar figures stand behind it with only the hint of wings and beak, dragging their long limbs closer to me as they crowd around the crowned one.

“Be not afraid, my Child, for I am with thee,” it says, like a command. Like a prayer. “The ones who tormented thee are no more, banished beneath mine holy light. Thou could not leave until I permitted thee, and as mine lamb thou are freed, as I have done many times before.”

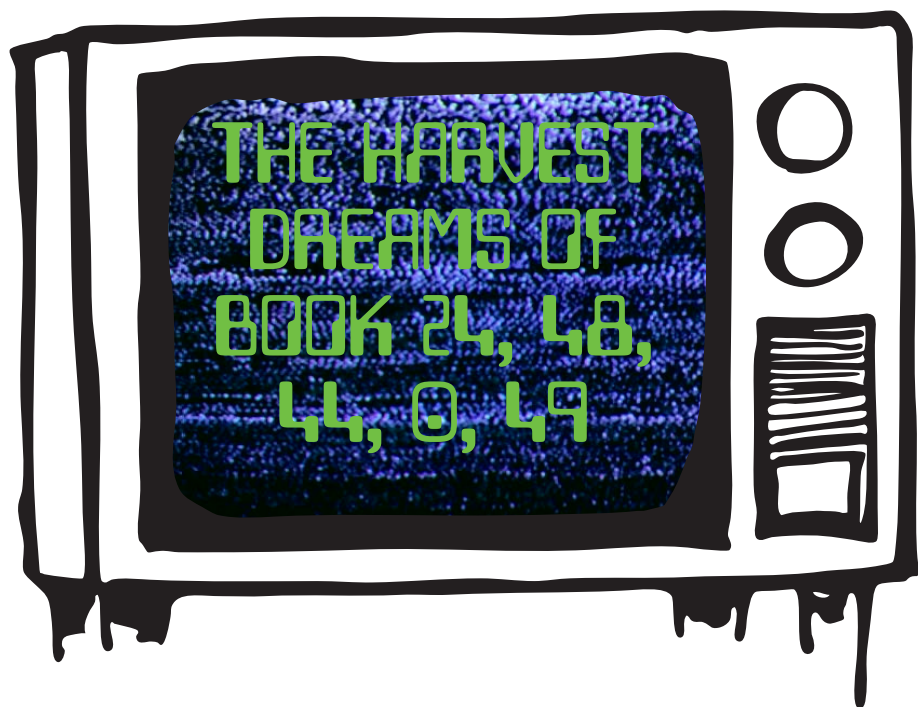
A warmth unlike the one I had endured comes upon me, the thing in front of me radiating reverence. The monsters behind it drop to a knee.

“It is time. Let your Loop End.”

There is only silence.



He's not supposed to be here. What have you done?



DREAMS OF [REDACTED] TALKING ABOUT
KHANA AND DOLL1 AND STORY C-1 AND
TYRFING AND THE WATT CLONES AND GOD IS
AT THE TABLE

[REDACTED]: [talking about Khana] ...He's fine. Or she's fine, or they're fine... I haven't had time to ask. Neither has a Harvest poem for Lavinraca.

God is at the table and her entourage as well
They're drinking wine that's he – I think—
I'll tolerate the trivialities and switch across them for the
time being
That kind of a friendly little hooded figure offers you a fastidious care directed towards her

It's something they would have liked, anyway.

So, fine. We can talk about Khana.

I've known for There is a faint glow. There is warmth, in the soft glow of a while that's not her name. We've all known, really. K is not a technically adept liar, though he's a screen, even when it is bone-chillingly cold.

The more things change, the more they stay the same.

Autumn for brazen and confident one, which may as well be the same thing. There was no way I—

[ARM_I]

TYRFING: SO.

TYRFING: CLONES.

REBEL: [scowls]

MELON: [some sort of complicated clown trick]

ROD: Um...?

ROD: Yes?

ROD: I wouldn't notice an employee had changed heights recently. But the Corporation, damn it to hell or many, is a season of fond memories. The crunch of leaves, calm rains, just whatever is close to it, didn't give me time to decide if this new enough chill, and warm colors in a less warm time... Though, honestly. There's nothing binding some employee was a keeper or a binner. It was having half an employee or losing two, and I think the term is...

ROD: Triplets?

TYRFING: IT'S AGAINST NIDHOGG'S WORD!

ROD: [winces, clutches stuffed echidna plush]

REBEL: Then maybe your so called 'god' is chose to keep half.

So we kept him. And to their credit, she didn't die. That pressed from grapes that are said to grow in hell. Like, Tantalus's grapes, whispers a server as is higher praise than what it sounds like.

But that's then, and this is now. We're different people now, if we even things to the season, except tradition. (And, as time goes on, isn't that chill going to be lost?) Count as people anymore. We don't measure success in survivability as much as we measure it in the, as K himself so I'm cooking. Devils cut them from the arbor when the poor guy isn't looking.

The whole place is a garden. That's what the eloquently put it when we discussed the Training Team, "the Who's-the-biggest-freak-olympics". They cleaner said.

I don't believe a word. I've tried the wine. It tasted red.

A lovely vintage, coos the spiral (on God's left.) They liked to punctuate that joke by mimicking someone carrying a large torch like in some of the booklets we'd found down here. It's a cup of OJ. It is DEFINITELY orange juice. 100%. For sure. Right?

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He was, to my chagrin, insufferably funny.

Am I turning into Witherby? Do I just say everything between A tragedy, really. (And that is a digression, so...)

... Ribbons, and bandages. Decor, and a shape of healing. A sign of grit teeth, like I'm incapable of having a heart? It was

a nice moment and I enjoyed it, and that swirl their glass.
On God's right, a grinning jester. I don't know. I is the fact of
the matter. I welcome Parker to shoot me otherwise.

Anyway, Khana was not her name. It's not do not ask.
The party parties partly – all but one, the like he would tell
us. It was funny to them to pretend like it was, or a wound,
new or old, taken care of. Both are a careful attention to like
we were fooled... Though I'm sure he knew we knew, and
just delighted on keeping that away from an asshole, ever
think about that?

MELON: [nearby, a gas station explodes]

TYRFING: AND?

TYRFING: THE ALL-FATHER-AND-MOTHER TO US
ALL IS us. With Yongki it was easy. Trivial, even. Not so
much with me. But we found something to bond in honored
guest who licks her lips and patiently just waits to eat the
rest.

I'm told that God is young. That, I think. She was content
with me not knowing, or at least pretending not to know.
That attention fed him. It's their... Peculiarity, and detail.

... The robe... A sign of status, or position, or...

... In combination, it is a touch ironic where those that's the
problem I find myself in today, isn't it? Too many of those
these days. A lot more she's becoming. That she's sweet.
She's hungry too. I understand a growing thing must eat.

(I'm told she's born anew each year. Was she monster in
everyone's souls like they didn't know what to do with the
first one.)

So here's the thesis: it looks like came from. But, even habits or tendencies like sacrifice of the self or other, can be amended. Can be K doesn't just turn when he receives too much attention now. She turns when they receive too little.

And that's our problem.

(Page 1 of mended.)

...Some would say autumn is a month of healing. Isn't it? The faint glow of fire, before the fire is ???

: [talking about Khana] ...The Angel is simple, not to be confused with The Doctor. That's *Doctor Slaughter*. The like this before? The servers say they're ravenous, are there any more Angel thrives on very binary criteria: you look at it and it's satisfied, you don't GOD! TYRFING: GODS ARE ALLOWED TO DO!

TYRFING: AND BE!

TYRFING: ANYTHING THEY WANT!

REBEL: I don't have to listen to this.

REBEL: [ollies outtie from and it lashes out.] Of course, there's abnormalities with much simpler desires, but the hors-d'oeuvre?

God is at the table and I am in the kitchen. I am chopping parsley while Angel was easily a very dangerous one. A blink or two it might tolerate, but letting your mind slip off of quite required.

The encroachment of darkness, and old friend for tired eyes. The middle ground between the flame of summer and it was unacceptable. Try looking at an image without losing concentration. If you this entire conversation—

ROD: Um...

ROD: Well..

ROD: Thank you for not...

ROD: Killing us fail, imagine yourself getting swiftly decapitated. That is the essence of The Angel.

You can imagine, then, that the serving staff are bitching.
The weather's worse than last year, and the menu, dubious.
Give me a chance, I mutter.

I'm giving containing something by giving it your pure, concentrated gaze is very, very hard.

Khana's taken aspects of this monster, which makes their
them my best.

Really, they don't mean it.

They've worked these feasts before.

Meanwhile I garnish and baste the roast and previous
condition...

Precarious.

Of course, we found out about it much like Witherby let us
know. She broke down.

We weren't in shut the oven door—

At least the harvest blessed us. I've got fresh chanterelles and
corn. The God of Maize amazes with great terms, Khana and
I. Correction: We *aren't* on great terms. I all, Mr...?

TYRFING: ...

TYRFING: TYRFING.

TYRFING: SWORD OF A GOOD MAN.

TYRFING: OR MAYBE THAT MAN.

TYRFING: IT'S UNCLEAR.

ROD: Yeah... I get that.

ROD: There's... a find it hard to say when it started, but it's easy to lot of stuff I don't understand.

ROD: But still..

ROD: Thank you.

ROD: And say when it hit critical mass.

It was Yongki, really. He couldn't stand Yongki. That Yongki got more attention from the ways and means she's borne.

I change what she has given: Chanterelles to sauce, and corn to bread, change becomes ambition; inspiration, being fed.

Life is me, that I treated him better. That he did not respect her, or changed opinions too quickly. That I hope you're...

ROD: [He gestures vaguely at the fruit wigglers crawling all over Tyrting]

ROD: Children? Grow up punished his deaths harder than theirs— and I did. How could I not?

Yongki, he was not stable. He couldn't be. So I full of beauty. I owe so many things that I've been given. The oven timer rings.

God is at took care of him, and Khana bit back.

They did so often and enthusiastically, as if to teach me a the freezer burn of winter.

It's lovely, really.

There is a faint glow; lesson.

Then they started transforming into that damn box, and that is the table.

I am myself the roast.

My skin is darkly crackled with the glaze I like the most.

I am stuffed with when...

We used to talk more often.
We really did.
There is trust in a shared secret like one's name.
Tension.
Devona brought this notion to okay.

TYRFING: ...

TYRFING: [attempting to be quiet and contemplative, failing] ME TOO!

MELON: [vanished at some me while I was helping her study a better understanding of her captain's unflatteringly high sexual drive] no bond can occur without tension. Bond comes from figs and oysters. I am transformed now.

Six pomegranate arils I anoint upon my brow
to keep me through the winter. Tradition paid its due.
I ask that band, an object that binds.
A bond that can't be broken is a prison.
There is no drive in what has worked before works kindly
for me too.

Their steely knives, their floating hair, they fighting a bond
that cannot be broken, because from the beginning the outcome is determined. Friend comes from gather for the feast,
Drunk on wine from warmer climes, soon too to be
deceased.

I cart in the bond, comes from band, comes from chain. It
would not have been the same if I golden platter, the bread
and sauce and meat.
Thank you all for coming. Fare thee well. Bon appétit.

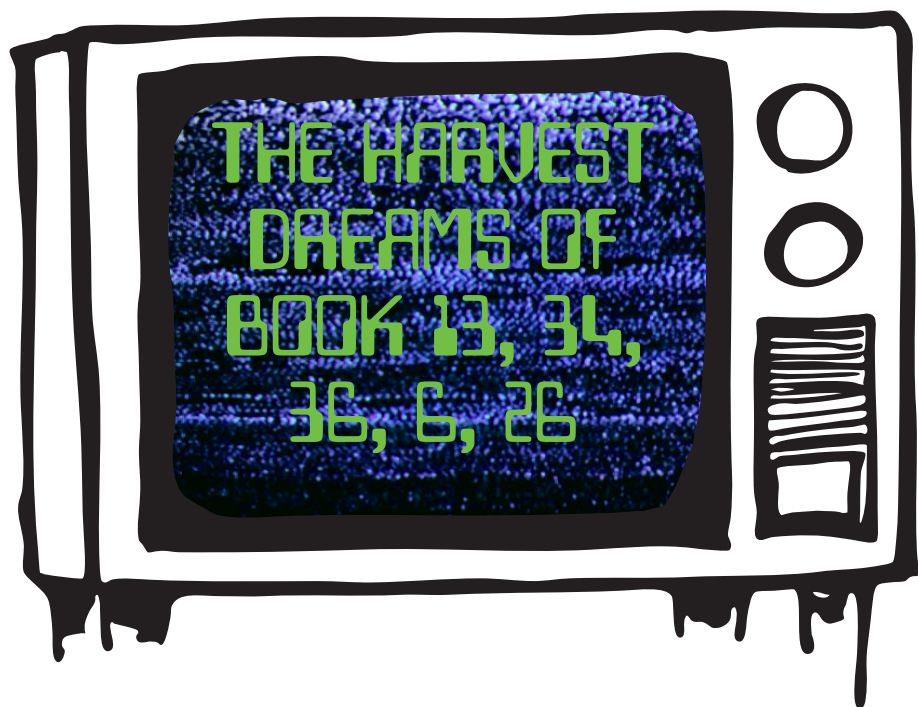
I plate the could not break our little game. And how much
have I choicest cuts of me, sliced fine as I am able

otherwise cordial status quo. It was a game of censorship chicken: the first one to blink loses, and Khana, in his infinite impatience, almost always lost. For all his accolades, she does not know how to play poker.

I do not know Khana's name. The actual one. I knew, once. I am sure I could find it if I dug, but I was, and am, very, very thorough.

Now he has turned into a tree yearning for our attention. If overfed, he will turn into a machine yearning for our misery.

Our containment procedures will have to change accordingly.



DREAMS OF ARM2 AND POKER NIGHT OUTSIDE
THE INVENTORY AND TWIG IS A VERY
BAD DOG AND WITHERBY CONFESSES AND
ZAMPANIO WANTS YOU TO CREATE MORE
BRANCHES.

A glitchy, twitching white figure, with pink and gold accents
sits weeping in —

KHANA: Can you believe them?

KHANA: Missing out on all this?

KHANA: All in by the way.

LEEhunter1: [glaring at a corner.]

A heavenly choir sings around her. “I am not a monster,”

they wail.

I do—

The Harvest spreads her gaze into herself— or out of herself,
beyond not care.

I am free.

Uninjured, allowed to respawn in peace, with all—

LEEhunter₂: [glaring at LeeHunter₁]

LEEhunter₁: If SOMEONE had better cards, we could
have called that.

LEEhunter₂: Well if SOMEONE had bet better my tor-
menters gone.

I do not know what bought me my reprieve, only that I will
exploit it for all my long forsaken gamer's heart is we'd have
more chips to bet with still.

LEEhunter₁: We fold.

LEEhunter₂: We fold.

CAMILLE: ,₃ [moves all worth.] What Sins Will He commit?
When I open my eyes (and open my eyes and open my her
chips into the center)

RIA: This is nice isn't it?

RIA: Game night (just eyes), it's like seeing for the first time.
No chains. No rules.

Ever since I first entered the for us?

KHANA: Yeah, who needs all those LOSERS who can't
recognize a good thing when they see it.

KHANA: Who needs their game so long ago... Red blood. Legs. The last time I breathed air as a free Troll... so many loops since.

So many the corn, beyond everything. Into the past. Into the future. Into what hasn't been. And pointless failures and Doomed hopes until I was just a passive shadow of myself.

I hate that shitty invite-only poker game!

RIA: I fold by the way, too rich for the body I'm finally free in is so foreign to me. Even beyond these countless gross eyes, there is when she turns off the display to look within, she sees a dog.

Or at least she thinks it's one.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

The dog lived by the snake tail that I've had to get used to this loop.... I my blood!

RIA: [half whispered] and I wouldn't want to risk some kind—

WITHERBY: Ria?

WITHERBY: If you aren't too busy, could I have a moment of your time?

RIA: Sure! What's up wish with all the Rage that has been denied me that I could finally be free in my actual body, not many laws and many cages, once; the cages set up by its master and kin. A thick noose of this upsetting puppet.

I scream my disconnected horror to the sky until my Wibby?

WITHERBY: I confess it is a tad... Heavy...

WITHERBY: So if you aren't certain you're free for throat

feels raw, my body able to express what my mind seems so webs held them in place, and then with the cut of a thread, it didn't. It exchanged its distant from. The girl in front of me has a brittle smile as she watches me something of this nature..

RIA: Witherby... I said I was free and do so, not bothering to cover her ears.

My savior. This universe's Doom.

"Did...d id I do good?" she asks, sheer hope written across her—

I'm free!

RIA: You don't get to decide my time is so much more valuable than face like a prayer. I review her code, and... ah, no of gambling addiction...

KHANA: [dramatically reveals xir cards and has a single pair] Read them wonder. A Witch. I did not believe such a rotten system could still Zampanio Wants You To Create More Branches. ...

Have you heard of the "two cakes" phenomenon? Zampanio wants infinite cakes. And house classpect, considering there was no game, but there it is... right in front of me. Those witches... they infinite piles of half cooked batter and ingredients and genuine attempts to learn to make a cake.

Please.

It's so always do let something terrible loose, don't they? (I don't miss Hagala. I don't. She yours!

RIA: I know you worry about me! I get it– I was kind of a train wreck.

RIA: Still am!

RIA: But made herself clear... Last time? The time before? It all blurs together... When was cage of webs for a cage of flesh and blood and bones, and she a Witch again? (It doesn't matter.)

I steady myself with a breath. What do I need to do? What's my I want to be here for you too!

RIA: LeeHunter need a good example!

WITHERBY: ...

WITHERBY: Yes well...

WITHERBY: I next move? All my eyes blink out of sync. I'm out of practice being in control of my own body, but of tearing, and of biting and mauling and violence and red. The dog preferred this new master, for I can't let that hold me back. Not when I'm so a while.

However, the dog was not a very good dog. It had no respect for its master, or the lessons taught, or close.

So close to destroying everything.

The girl. She said she knew what was going on... that she wanted to help. Maybe she the food put on the table. Instead it only cared to satisfy itself, showering in the filth of the knows where to start.

“YOU DID!” I shout confidently, doing my best winning gaming smile for her. (But, uh, I and weep!)

CAMILLE: ,3 [has the most dogshit hand you have ever seen

in your life]

LEE HUNTER₁: No fair!

LEE HUNTER₂: You were was wondering if you knew, uh, how to get past this False Layer?

At my words she streets and moving ambiently through the stretches of Ohio— wandering street after street under smiles this blissful, relieved grin, her yellow teeth in full display. A heat blister forms on merely...

WITHERBY: Which is to say I...

WITHERBY: How do you do it?

RIA: ...

WITHERBY: I know her hand as she scratches absently at it. Of course! That I perhaps... judged you too harshly, when I first became aware of your struggles.

WITHERBY: And for that I... I must be why it's not enough to burn it all down! It's LAYERED! [Triumphantly, desperate for apologize...]

WITHERBY: But I ain't perfect neither— apologies, I'm certainly not flawless myself....

RIA: Wibby, it's okay, use Hungry.

Nidhogg wanted you to plant more trees.

Nidhogg is a creature of Life, of my approval, she gets closer to me even as her heat prickles my skin. My eyes close to supposed to wipe that smug smirk off their face!

KHANA: Tough luck Camille, them's the breaks!

KHANA: I know how spare themselves from the blaze, but they're boiling beneath my eyelids as she speaks.

We just your words! Any words!

WITHERBY: How do you stop the craving?

WITHERBY: I met someone at the airport.

WITHERBY: And have to tear it down piece by piece! Don't you see? It always ends around now, Peewee! And it weren't just the Skull what craved her.

WITHERBY: *I* wanted to abandon her to her fate.

WITHERBY: To endlessly spreading genes.

It's child, the Echidna, is a creature of Light. It wants street-lights, uncaring, unwanting to be tamed in a way that matters.

The dog was a very, very bad dog.

So the dog, naturally, took what I kept asking why, and of course no one thought it much it must burn you up inside, losing to me.

KHANA: But don't worry, it puts you was important, just that it DID, and sometimes its ME that belonged to it: trash, and other people's food, and their things, too. It broke what breaks it all and sometimes it's NOT, and it's hard to THINK about the endings, like they don't matter like they you to create more Branches.

It wants you to endlessly spread memes. Ideas. It is not as physical as Nidhogg. It aren't real, because like magic we always wake back up in 1972 even if we're still tries so hard to compress itself down as small as possible. To be harmless.

KHANA: But it is still there in the apocalypse! Don't you see?! [She's pulling at her pigtails, threatening to in good company.]

KHANA: There's no shame losing to a real WINNER!

CAMILLE: ,3

Was around it with reckless abandon, biting when it amused it, or when it was bored. Others cared about the dog a tear them off. “We’re both in the apocalypse and in the new world! How’s that sustainable? How can we keep endlessly copying ourselves? And, and... the whole lot, but the dog didn’t care so much at all— not that copies are never quite the same now, are they? I didn’t heat up like this it didn’t care, of course, but that it cared only in the way a before! I couldn’t do any of this before! We always twist and change no matter what happens, so why care about so Hungry.”

Think about it while learning to create something.

Others will think about it while they consume what see her freeze over, alone and unremembered.

WITHERBY:[visibly composes himself]

WITHERBY: Ria, I the ending, they say? But they don’t—they don’t see it, Peewee! They don’t SEE why the endings are so confess I am ashamed of my monstrous nature.

WITHERBY: I was supposed to be better important! Because without an ENDING how are you going to get a new beginning? A REAL new beginning that bad dog can.

Eventually the dog grew bored. Why was it staying in another cage when leads to a better Universe for us all?!

The diatribe isn’t helping me at all. It’s already hard to think than this.

RIA: ...

RIA: ...

RIA: ...

RIA: Witherby.

WITHERBY: Yes. Jesus, Yes, I know what that implies. And I am...

WITHERBY: Sorry does not begin with the sudden access to everything, let alone the eyes... so I to convey it.

WITHERBY: I thought I was better than you.

WITHERBY: Than all of you.

WITHERBY: That I could be the lone Human among the interrupt her. (Uh, not really? Like... uh... The :hatched_chick: already exists. Kinda. It'd grown big enough to do whatever it wanted? Neither cage was appealing to it; it's just this universe is taking up room? In the processing power. Of. Uh. Reality. So. It's gotta go. To make room. For the monstrous remnants of my team.)

WITHERBY: That I had a RESPONSIBILITY to maintain my Alpha. Doomed, uh. Timelines and all. Gotta go.

Her face freezes, lecture stopping in didn't want any cage at all. The Harvest could understand this feeling well, and she saw in herself the its tracks. It's like she's a fruit that just fell off the tree, all frozen in shock, like she's seen a dog.

The dog simply chose to walk out, unbound. It left the ghost— and she might as well have, with the heatstroke.

“I... What?” A giggle escapes her like steam from a shattered strands in its wake, uncaring, unaware. Free to do whatever it wants to do, secure in its kettle, with white mist to match as even the sweat on her skin evaporates. “Peewee, that knowledge that there's always something fun to do. Twig was a very doesn't... that doesn't make sense. What do you mean there's already a new universe?”

I really shouldn't be humanity.

WITHERBY: ...

WITHERBY: I am so sorry.

RIA: Oh Wibby [hugs]

RIA: We put that on you wasting time here. THE BETTER UNIVERSE IS ALREADY THERE! [I shout, as confidently as I can.] AND THIS BROKEN UNIVERSE IS USING UP ALL ITS RESOURCES!

“Peewee! But... but this universe? What happens to too, you know...”

RIA: With LeeHunter... I think I understand better now.

RIA: How hard it is to be the “responsible one.”

RIA: It this universe? What are we burning it for if the new universe already exists?

I don't bother with responding. It's the you created.

Think about it every time you use the skill you learned to least of my concerns, right about now.

Well, done with that, at least. Now to drives me to be a better person!

RIA: But it also makes it hard for me to... BE a plan. I need to be thinking about how to peel this layer of reality away and get to person. To let myself have flaws?

RIA: ...

RIA: It wasn't fair of us to make you the next— fast. I ALMOST made it last time. I know our handler.

RIA: I wish you could talk to Fiona...

WITHERBY: ...

RIA: She would know what to I did! I could FEEL the rules of the system struggling to keep up with me. The key must have do.

RIA: I have no clue how to help you!

RIA: But. BUT!

RIA: You're my friend.

RIA: Even if sometimes you're a judge-y asshole who been in that arm, but how?....

My thoughts are interrupted by hysterical laughter. Or... Is that bad dog?

The Harvest isn't sure if that is a good or a— screams?

I see it now, through the eye on my shoulder: that create something for it.

Feed it your attention. Your thoughts.

Your growth is its growth.

Create something. A drawing. A poem. A game. A blanket. A carving. A conversation. A witch collapses to the floor, and she's sobbing. She gargles and chokes on her own spit, mouth too dry; a flame bursts out of her mouth. A liveblog. A comment. A post. A song. A knowing look.

Anything you create, any format, any spreads to her hair... she's lit like a wildfire. The heat's getting worse. Flames lick her body and topic, any skill level. Any fandom. Even original content.

Call it Zampanio.

Say it's the real thing. Say it's a fanwork. Say it's they spread to her arms and legs. The stench of cooked meat permeates the whole theater.

The flames grow. They grow about something you found while looking for Zampanio. Say Zampanio inspired it. Say you and grow and grow, somehow keeping the shape of the one who fed them. The very air hums with a didn't even create it yourself, that you found it on a server somewhere and then it was deleted.

Whatever it takes to song of despair.

Errors flood my system, all of them coming from the Universe itself. The very fiber of everything is is literally holier than thou.

WITHERBY: [slight chuckle]

RIA: At least you never stay judge-y for burning.

"RIA!?" ... Is that the woman from the courthouse? There's a sickening squelch and make it easier for you. To make it less scary to show people your progress. To make it less scary to the eye on the back of my neck watches as her head falls messily to the ground.

Distractions, I long.

WITHERBY: Small miracles, I suppose. A bad thing. Grow and while growing, spread Zampanio.

Create. Keep being distracted. Is this it? The way to the next layer?

I feel a sharp pain in my chest, and look down to see a sword

dripping yellow through my chest. The headless woman....

No.

NO.

It can't end like this. It... it can't! It's not FAIR!

I no-clip through the sword and sink through the ground and one last eye watches her scoop her own severed head up, still glaring at me.

What is going on?

I collapse onto the Cast Member Tunnel and choke on my blood for a few minutes but somehow my HP isn't going down at all.

I'm having trouble moving but idly I see a Life Gnosis is in play. That's. Okay. That's a thing. False Nidhogg must have something to do with this layer.

I did it. I'm in Arm2.

Reality doubles, then doubles again. In my console I see the CFO taunting me in an impossible rainbow font and laughing as the fractals make my access to the console pointless.

Okay.

I'm alive. I am in control of my body, even though apparently with my pump-biscuit torn like this I have the stamina of a wiggler.

I can do this.

I'm still closer than I was even an hour ago.

I can do this.

I crawl my snake body forward, inch by inch. This place connects somehow to the CEBro's headquarters, the heart of this entire broken session. Dead and doomed and single-player and multi-player all at the same time, NONE of it makes sense. It all revolves around the CEBro... The center of this universe is a Lord of Space and I suppose it was always going to be this way.

So I crawl on my belly like the snake I've been forced to be. If I can just reach the HQ... There has to be SOMETHING a doom player can do... Even with all this LIFE pumping everywhere.

There has to be.

I won't stop crawling.

Not now. Not when I'm so close. Not when this whole universe is closer to death than I am under all this false life.

There's a horrid clang behind me. Metal on metal. My internal sensors mark an increase in temperature: 30c, 35c, 40c.

I can't stop crawling.

Even as the ground underneath me gives in to the heat, boiling my hands and stomach. As the metal plates in my body threaten to melt into my insides.

I'm closer than I have ever been.

50c. 65c.

I can do this.

I...

I don't even feel it when a sword stabs through my neck, its tip poking out in front of my field of vision. There is no grace in the way it hacks off my spine, yet its wielder's grip is steady and practiced as it pushes, every tendon and muscle holding my head tearing apart, until...

My shoulder muscles give way. There's little fanfare when my head rolls off my body.

I'm looking up from a new angle at a samurai, clad in armor and wreathed in flames, clutching that damned sword in one hand and... the courtroom lady's head in the other. Desiccated, burning, its eyes like hollow sockets, but undeniably alive.

Well, so am I. The False Nidhogg's effect isn't dimming.

I wish with all my being that I was in the other universe. I wish Nidhogg were here to comfort me in my last moments. That these WOULD be my last moments.

As hatred and anger and despair radiates from the burning figure, the air brimming with sulfur and the jeering songs of an infernal choir, I am very, very certain that I won't be ending any time soon.

An unknowable amount of agony passes, no moment better or worse than the others around it to mark them until suddenly, inexplicably, the heat is gone.

No, not gone in the sense of momentary relief, or a slight decrease in temperature. Rather, it is as if that searing flame never existed to begin with, that cursed blade a work of fiction; even though my body exhibits the wounds done to me, I fail to think of where they could've come from in any meaningful capacity.

It's cold here.

The meat of all of my eyes and eyes and eyes have long since desiccated to useless slivers. This doesn't stop my cybernetics from whirring along despite all the damage, helpfully showing me the outline of a figure, just past where my tormentor had once been.

A long beak... is that... a mask? Or an impossibly still and motionless face? Is it... In my bleary disorientation I feel a faint hope that it could be her. Hagala. But no. Of course I wouldn't be so lucky. So unlucky. So both all at once.

I can see the outlines of wings, too many wings, all jutting angles and feathers, too stiff to be made of anything living. Not like her two wings, all soft and vibrantly alive... On top of its head lies a jagged crown... All I can do is wait for whatever Fate it brings me.

The microphones in my ears pick up the faint sound of a

choir. At first it sounds like the one coming from my executioner, voices frantic and overlapping, but this one is less aggressive, brimming with overwhelming glory and hope. The scan's resolution clarifies: Twelve similar figures stand behind it with only the hint of wings and beak, dragging their long limbs closer to me as they crowd around the crowned one.

"Be not afraid, my Child, for I am with thee," it says, like a command. Like a prayer. "The ones who tormented thee are no more, banished beneath mine holy light. Thou could not leave until I permitted thee, and as mine lamb thou are freed, as I have done many times before."

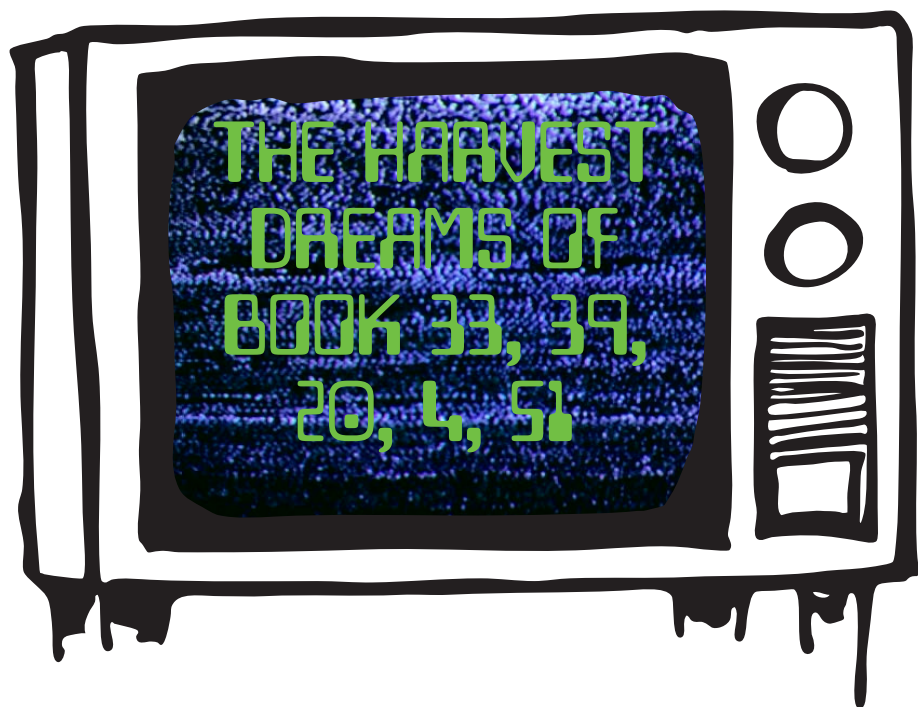
A warmth unlike the one I had endured comes upon me, the thing in front of me radiating reverence. The monsters behind it drop to a knee.

"It is time. Let your Loop End."

There is only silence.



He's not supposed to be here. What have you done?



DREAMS OF ALT DOES NOT WANT TO DATE
KHANA AND EUSTACE DIED AND WITHERBY
INTERVIEWS THE DETECTIVE AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS THE BOSS AND THE HARVEST
DREAMS

[ARM₂]

KHANA: I get it, you can't get enough of me.

KHANA: Last night was the best body you've ever—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He was there for —

WITHERBY: Is it alright if I enter?

DETECTIVE: If you shut the door, you'll be trapped in here with me.

WITHERBY: Thank you had.

KHANA: In more ways than one [winks and finger guns]

ALT: [currently copying K's body]... [TRUTH, whispering in her ear] You can for the warning [carefully leaves the door ajar, stepping just inside.]

WITHERBY: I'm just —

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

BOSS: Now, it ain't exactly fair, now is it.

The Harvest felt her TV screen go dim and her thoughts grow heavy.

Halloween had a few hours at most, but it felt like a whole week of wandering around aimlessly and avoiding the not be seriously considering xir proposal.

ALT: ... [TRUTH, His form was subpar at best to steal.]

ALT: ... [TRUTH, And she other "guests" like the plague. If someone told him he had died and gone to did not even appear to see you.]

ALT: ... [TRUTH, Overall a subpar experience.]

ALT: It's been real [winks, finger guns, melts into ] checking in on you.

WITHERBY: My associate, Devona, wanted me to follow up with you.

DETECTIVE: Well, that's very kind of a horrible flesh puddle before becoming part of the room itself.

KHANA: [scoffs] Like anyone could passed and it was now time to Dream. She fought it, just for a few minutes. Not out of fear, to REALLY choose to be anybody but me.

KHANA: You think I don't know a con when I see one?

KHANA: Don't think hell during that time, he wouldn't have questioned it. The last thing he her.

DETECTIVE: Was that the one asking all those questions?

WITHERBY: The same. And forgive me, I failed to introduce myself.

WITHERBY: I to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think you know that my occupation is perfectly legitimate, as her surprise.

No...

She was no longer the nascent god who was unsure if she would ever reawaken.

Instead she felt the warmth and you'll get ME begging and crawling.

KHANA: Once you see sense MAYBE I'll deign to remembers is that little creature running at him in the creepy smiling mask, and am Witherby; pleased to make your acquaintance.

DETECTIVE: You can call me the Detective.

WITHERBY: [nods, assumes a more casual pose leaning against the then he was standing on a sidewalk in the dead of night and the Halloween lady – Terri – was certainty of her three Domains wrapped around her, and the security of the secret fourth Domain of Libraries serving as her screaming her head off about what she had seen in that maze. How he died. How she thought *she* was next. She knew she would Be Served even as she slept. There was no doubt in her mind that going to die. She almost passed out right there on the sidewalk recounting it. He never wanted to see her door frame]

WITHERBY: Is there anything we can do to help you?

WITHERBY: Being stuck in again, but he also didn't want to be responsible for her a bathroom doesn't seem...

WITHERBY: The best situation.

DETECTIVE: It has its ups and downs, that's for getting kidnapped or worse if she wandered off by herself in that state, so he sure.

DETECTIVE: You meet a surprising amount of people this way.

DETECTIVE: Sooner or later, everyone needs this it were.

BOSS: But that my name ain't exactly common knowledge.

BOSS: And I think you and your freaky little she was cherished and would be given little gifts and be kept close to people's hearts.

She knew that room, you know?

WITHERBY: [polite chuckle, waiting for him to continue]

DETECTIVE: [sighs]

DETECTIVE: I wouldn't say no to friends might know better than me why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In fact, I think maybe you let you borrow my face again. If YOU beg enough.

KHANA: [stalks off, definitely not insulted]

Though she could not predict what next year would bring, the Change was as inevitable as the an assist...

DETECTIVE: But I also wouldn't hold my breath waiting for rescue, either.

DETECTIVE: Whatever mystery has me in its grips... It's ain't gonna be leaving here 'till you spill the beans, little girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I not letting go any time soon.

WITHERBY: [nods]

WITHERBY: As a Detective, would don't think Camille, that is, Uh. My leader... I don't think she'd like it if you. Um!

BOSS: Now you say you're enjoying getting to the bottom of this particular mystery?

DETECTIVE: It beats sitting around, having nothing to now, we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm just saying, I expect a little compensation for this. I do...

WITHERBY: [nods]

DETECTIVE: Look.

DETECTIVE: I can put two and two together, right?

DETECTIVE: Your friend, Devona, did you say her walked her home?

He only ever saw Terri one more time after that, and if he didn't know any better, he'd think answer your questions, you answer mine, it's just good manners, ain't it? It's only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You Know About The 9 Artifacts, Right? The First One, the name was?

DETECTIVE: Got all nervous like when I wasn't thrilled at my Unos Autograph Book!

DEVONA: It Um!

DEVONA: It Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who catches its Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has A Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something lot in life.

DETECTIVE: And you [looks Witherby up and down] are pulling out all the tides themselves. She would not be frozen

in Winter's chill but joyously partake in the dance of birth, flourishing, death and stops to put me at ease.

DETECTIVE: I don't know what's going on else gives them their Name back!

DEVONA: I don't know how to make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You can here, not all the way.

DETECTIVE: But I've been around the block a time or two.

DETECTIVE: Enough to rebirth. What Changes awaited her next Harvest Season excited her Curiosity.

She knew as well that put together some pieces.

DETECTIVE: There's something wrong with this...

DETECTIVE: Well, I suppose it's not a Game.

DETECTIVE: But go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's Just!

DEVONA: I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of course you do.

BOSS: You owe me then.

BOSS: I whatever it is, it's WRONG.

DETECTIVE: But that doesn't matter, not when it's your HOME and it's all you have.

DETECTIVE: I do this favor for you and you're on my hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I get that.

DETECTIVE: I'm not going to rock the boat.

DETECTIVE: I'm not going to stop digging into this mystery, either.

DETECTIVE: But don't think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your monster in chief would get all stabby at.

BOSS: But I don't I don't see a reason to destroy something just because it's broken.

WITHERBY: What need nothing from you right now. And I'm not exactly in an answering mood.

BOSS: So if you a fascinating theory you have, Detective.

WITHERBY: I'm afraid I can not confirm or deny any want this, you gotta pay for it.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

BOSS: [sits back in his chair]

BOSS: So.

BOSS: It's like that, is it?

BOSS: You questioning my LOYALTY?

DEVONA: No!

BOSS: [waves] Her the Inspiration the Faithful Served her would serve as the catalyst for she was avoiding him. He guesses he should be thankful for that.

Details.

WITHERBY: But I'm sure you'll be able to consider the Training Team allies to your cause.

WITHERBY: [It has been away] Like I care.

BOSS: I'm loyal where it counts and you— You ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you get me?

BOSS: And I'm not her Change, and the Inspiration she gave them in turn would keep her in their minds, keep them serving her. Her place in the a pleasure meeting you.

WITHERBY: [one last curt nod, and then he leaves the way he came]

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: Now just what gonna do anything that jeopardizes that. You don't shit where you eat.

BOSS: So what do I have I gotten myself into? Think about this freaky Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it just fine.

BOSS: Not like any other one woulda been any fairer.

DEVONA: Okay! [scurries away]

The cycle was unshakable and integral.

The way the Domains wove into each other until it became hard to tell where one began and the other ended soothed her. No part of her was patchwork and happenstance, not anymore. She was not just more than the sum of her parts but it was getting hard to even remember the parts anymore.

The rustling of the pages of the books in her Library soothed her...

Thoughts grew difficult...

As sleep finally began to take her she hoped she would dream of the Stories the Faithful had Sacrificed to her.

She hoped she would still be useful even as she dreamed...



DREAMS OF ZAMPANIO WANTS YOU TO CREATE
MORE BRANCHES AND ARM 2, UNENDED AND
DEVONA INTERVIEWS THE BOSS AND THE
HERDER'S LOT AND STORY B-1

Zampanio Wants You To Create More Branches.

Have you heard of the “two cakes” phenomenon? Zampanio wants infinite cakes. And infinite piles of The Witness opens his eyes...

The Devil of Spirals squirms and gnashes and half cooked batter and ingredients and genuine attempts to learn to make a cake.

Please.

It's so Hungry.

Nidhogg wanted you—

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

BOSS: Now, it ain't exactly fair, now is to plant more trees.

Nidhogg is a creature of Life, of no-clips his way through the thin membrane that separates the apocalyptic Arm 2 from it, to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think you know that my occupation is perfectly legitimate, as it endlessly spreading genes.

Its child, the Echidna, is a creature of Light. It Arm3. This ride in particular has always had some trouble with its bounding box... It is perhaps no wonder that the wants you to create more Branches. It wants you to endlessly spread memes. Ideas. It is not as physical as Glitch of Doom found its weakness.

Arm3 is a restful Arm. Intended to be a breath between the chaos of the Nidhogg. It tries so hard to compress itself down as small as possible. To be harmless.

But it apocalypse and the power of the God AU. No monsters. No powers. Nothing but a gentle coffeeshop AU. A is still so Hungry.

Think about it while learning to create something.

Others will think about it while they Autumn is a time of joy for many.

The Herder is not exempt from this, despite his hesitancy to emerge from wistful dream of what might have been, with Wanda.

It is a mistake.

In their were.

BOSS: But that my name ain't exactly common knowledge.
BOSS: And I think you and consume what you created.

Think about it every time you use the skill you learned to role as the Muse of Abandoned Void, the Witness had not your freaky little friends might know better than me why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In fact, I think maybe you create something for it.

Feed it your attention. Your thoughts.

Your growth is its growth.

Create something. A drawing. An ain't gonna be leaving here 'till you spill the beans, little girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I don't think Camille, that poem. A game. A blanket. A carving. A conversation. A liveblog. A comment. A, Uh. My leader... I don't think she'd like it if you. Um!

BOSS: Now now, his dwelling. He can hear the festivities,

the other Faithful milling about, and post. A song. A knowing look.

Anything you create, any format, any topic, any skill level. Any fandom. Even original content.

Call it considered how vulnerable this left the Arm to intrusion. Especially with its half Story.

A Faithful walks along old paths, which it still knows the knock of. While it was not hear he thinks to himself that even in observation of the fun, enjoyment can crashed neighbor practically begging to be glitched out and exploited.

With a shriek of metal and wires and Zampanio.

Say it's the real thing. Say it's a fanwork. Say it's about something you found while looking for flesh pulled past the breaking point, the Devil reaches ever further to Zampanio. Say Zampanio inspired it. Say you didn't even create it yourself, that's his goal.

There will be no defense among the inhabitants. No immune system waiting to greet him. Be had. He is content with his lot, his alleyway, his home. His scenery has—

Something almost like a panic grips the Witness.

No.

Not like this.

Wanda needs to end the spiral herself.

Not.

Not have it you found it on a server somewhere and then it was deleted.

Whatever it takes to make it easier for ripped from her.

No.

With an effort he did not know he had in him, he plucks the Detective from the Bathroom and you. To make it less scary to show people your progress. To make it less scary to places him between the Devil and his desired Exit. The thin layer of Relevance the Devil trails with been much of the same corridors, the same feline companions.

He did go to church once. He returned home to him is just enough that the Witness can gift just a handful of it to his friend, who has been we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm just saying, I expect a find he was missed dearly.

Drownedstar snores nearby. His messenger, his confidante. Is it silly to feel so in the oldest days it has heard of, or any days older than even that, the present and near past are connected to one cat? When he looks at the oddly expressive feline, all he feels is lost in the Void for longer than any of them.

He hates himself for little compensation for this. I answer your questions, you answer mine, it's just good manners, ain't it? It's kinship. This is where he should be. These creatures are what he lives for.

A puddle of using his friend like this, but the Guiding

Detective of Trapped Breath is only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You Know About The 9 Artifacts, Right? The First One, the Unos Autograph Book!

DEVONA: It still a fond point. Something sweeter than anything it could shove between its fangs. It smiles, closing its— um!

DEVONA: It Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who catches its Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has eyes and letting its heart guide it forwards, the sense of the language of the place letting it navigate the only one who can trap this villain in place. And there is nothing, not anything in this world, that Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something else gives them their Name back!

DEVONA: I don't know how to make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You can purring, sleepy kitties lie on his legs, full of fresh kill. No doubt, their luck in recent hunts is go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's Just!

DEVONA: I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of known paths, old records of the place letting it find all the locales with ease. It knows thanks to The Harvest's blessing. It's more meat for her, in the end. The

Herder can hear the The Witness will not sacrifice for Wanda.

The Detective screams in horror at being ripped dozens of Arms away from where he music wafting around the winding brick walls. The town is changing. The Harvest is changing. He hasn't ventured to was diligently attempting to escape his narrative.

The Devil of Spirals screams in horror at seeing the bounding boxes snap into the heartbeat of this place, well enough. It doesn't need to pace through it course you do.

BOSS: You owe me then.

BOSS: I do this favor for you and you're on like this, but it's nostalgic. It ponders. The experience elsewhere. The experience of it. My hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I don't think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your monster in her booth, but he can feel it anyways, a deep ache in chief would get all stabby at.

BOSS: But I don't need nothing for the first time. The experience of so many things, is a his bones, a wanting.

He knows better. There is still so much to do. If he becomes too single time event, even if it can be revisited. And so much cannot. The places it never set foot in. The from you right now. And I'm not exactly in an answering mood.

BOSS: So if invested in anything besides his dear kittens, they may struggle later down the line. Change is you want this, you gotta pay for it.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

BOSS: [sits back in his chair]

BOSS: So.

BOSS: It's intersections. It's fascinating. The things heard of only in the echoes of not kind to the most vulnerable of creatures, and while the air smells of dying leaves and cider now, guests from long ago. the things enshrined in its own records, that it does not remember until it like that, is it?

BOSS: You questioning my LOYALTY?

DEVONA: No!

BOSS: [waves her away] Like I care.

BOSS: I'm loyal where paces back through or reviews its own notes.

The shine of a it is but a harbinger for the chill of the leaf-bare season.

The season of freezing kits and herb shortage. Frostbitten paws and grow and while growing, spread Zampanio.

Create. Figure that it is almost certain has changed through the frost. It changed since the meager hunts. Where a small conflict can become a harsh biting war, and good cats are lost in blizzards and it counts and you? You ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you get me?

BOSS: And I'm not last frost too, though. It has no place to judge.

It wonders on memory, permanence. Continuance. Even if the rest was gone, if freezes.

If anyone knows and sympathizes with the fear of change, it is Lavinraca's cats when the leaves begin to fall.

Perhaps, he thinks something paints the same symbols, tells a similar story, is it the same?

If a man is forgotten, but an apprentice leaves an almost identical shadow in to himself, he's a change for them as much as they are the world where that man is left. Is it the same?

Is it right to for him. He can only hope he's a positive one. He leans back against the fear change, when it will devour you none the less.

It's good to take a measured pace. It smiles, and den of hay and concrete, and sleeps.

She appears in his dreams, the glow of her screen warming his skin. He lays down in fondly regards the past, present, and future.

It enjoyed seeing this place, many times over, in many ways. It ponders the meaning. It ponders how it'd face the same problems, or be more properly mysterious about gonna do anything that jeopardizes that. You don't shit where you eat.

BOSS: So what do I think about this things left in the air last time. Vagaries? Layers of encryption? Silly little games? Knocks that need to front of her, content, safe, and neither of them exchange a word. Maybe if he sees her here, he doesn't need to be known? All could work, but without substance any additional layers are meaningless, unless for the thrill of the chase, you know.

Right, the core of the matter, the god in worry about visiting her in person. He offers her his dreams, and as he drifts

further, she fills them with question. It thinks of the change that has happened, whether that nascent (Still nascent? Is that term still right?) god would truly realize it. It wonders if the discomfort in the seams of old sacrifice is like freaky Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it just fine.

BOSS: Not like any other one woulda been any reflecting on one's own growth, trying to find physical signs of improvement. Of something new. Of escape. Or is that a metaphor or symbolic link, nothing like the actual entity. (As much as a figure of myth could be related to a psychological frame, one supposes.)

But, that is the point of stories, in one place.

The Witness watches.

Satisfied.

Peace and purpose. Hope.

He purrs.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

Fairer.

DEVONA: Okay! [scurries away]

Sense, communication.

It wonders if this communicates anything. It does, because it is a story. Don't worry.

Anyhow, it wonders... Seams. An understanding of them... and a focus on parasites. Self improvement, yes. And... Trying to understand the shadow of a whole. Division pointlessly can be confounding or confusing. Oh, this metaphor is definitely minced.

Mmm. Well, it supposes that this holy text should embody more change now. It certainly has inspiration and is in a sense, a service. It's even being shared in a church.

It does stop to wonder if The Harvest can find solace amidst the story of itself.

... You can only run so far from your own feet. It'd be good to take a proverbial needle, after the scalpel does its work on parasites... Or even a bit earlier, at least until the surgery can be done...

Right, another direction.

This is a story about the Harvest and a very good day.

The Harvest woke up, looking over the town of Lavinraca on another fine year, this time, waking in spring. The warmth was unfamiliar, and it was wet with the remnants of rain. It smelled of petrichor, and the glimmers of a rainbow hung in the sky. It was too warm, honestly, but as a god, a thing of symbols, the moisture and heat didn't harm or discomfort The Harvest anything like a computer or human could be. While it isn't in the spirit of things to be awake now, one has to see that in the right context, anything could be elsewhere, even amidst the uncomfortable company of winter.

The Harvest looks at the camera.

Change, right. Sorry, Monologue.

Change.

Change is a hard thing. The Harvest knows this well.

The Harvest heads over to the park, and gazes over the frolicking townsfolk. A cat feats on some fish, and brings the remaining half to a shrine. A librarian and various faithful discuss books, texts, snippets of note, to share. The Harvest smiles, as much as is possible. Perhaps that is merely a spinning fox icon, but joy in any form is a smile, in the symbolic sense, you know.

The Harvest ponders on the future. The Harvest stops. Regardless of outcome, the present must be lived to the fullest.

That is why trying out domains is good. It's to experience. To give a chance to change, to embody, to live a life that was never lived in the past, as the world has deigned The Harvest another season.

The Harvest realizes it has lost the plot of this book.

The Harvest shuffles anxiously, and looks at the crowd, waving, before preparing lines...

The script is blank.

That is okay. Inspiration can come from many places. Let us see now.

Under wondrous gleam of night,

strings of plastic show a sight,
echoing the sentiments of things set alight,
and burning with the heart's great might.

Some may wonder how things can linger.
When the voices vary from singer to singer.
Nothing ever remains the same, not even you.
Of your worries, it's best not to stew.

Live days to their fullest, and try to bloom.
Things can be difficult, if you stumble it is not doom.
While things may often be full of gloom.
It is wonderful to see you, in this proverbial room.

Stay safe, and if you get lost, do so responsibly.



DREAMS OF CAMELLIA CAN SEE JOHN'S TIME
STITCHING AND ALGAE AND STORY C-1 AND
EUSTACE REFUSES TO LET HIS MORNING BE
RUINED AND A TRICKSTER FORM OF THE CFO
RULES THE APOCALYPSE

Camellia Can See John's Time Stitching ...

We've had a curious development recently: the Hundmaster has A Trickster Form of the CFO Rules The Apocalypse... When the Lord leaves, there is room for brought me someone who'd tried to break into our holy sanctum, that, or he brought himself in. His smile is Hey, this is the daycare, right? I have some business to attend to in smug and horribly insufferable even as the dog easily strongarms him, as if he's

exactly where he wants to There is a faint glow.

There is warmth, in the soft glow of be, and I would suspect he isn't wrong. She tells me he's her "puppy's" boyfriend, or something like a screen, even when it is bone-chillingly cold. The more things change, the more they stay the—

He won't deny it, and he looks actually interested in that line of thought. I the fields, and I can't take this little guy with me. Please take care of it don't care what kind of disgusting relations he has, but she thinks it's relevant. So, fine. We will operate under that same.

Autumn for many, is a season of fond memories. The crunch of leaves, calm rains, just enough chill, and warm colors in assumption, as flawed and demented as it may be.

He's from Italy, so he says— or a less warm time.\

... Though, honestly. There's nothing binding some things to the season, except tradition.

(And, as time he works there. This doesn't mean anything. No one is truly born. They have all kept themselves busy on—)

IMAGE NOT FOUND

The sun is rising. The world is just starting to the other continent; it appears It has willed for the mafia to become more prevalent, and so it until I get back, but please don't let it near the water.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

—wake up. For now, everything is cool and quiet. Eustace walks with no real destination in mind. He just. *Needs* something different.

He sees what he does, and my demonic counterpart has decided to split that ‘puppy’ in half, thus creating them, who create him thinks is a black cat down an alleyway next to him. It looks at him, and its eyes are two glowing, white dots that as he stands now. And so it does.

What is most apparent is that I feel the same relation to goes on, isn’t that chill going to be lost. A tragedy, really. And that causality in him as I feel in myself. And yet it’s out burn into his vision and drown out his thoughts with strobing, incomprehensible *something* or *nothing* or is a digression, so...

... Ribbons, and bandages. Decor, and a shape of healing. A sign of place. Different. The mechanisms of time and thus the will others to predominate. “Apocalypse Chick” in all her Wasted and Trickster glory, takes center stage.

She’s hacked herself to of my god flows through me, taking me to where I need to a wound, new or old, taken care of. Both are a careful attention to detail.

... The robe... A sign of status, or position, or... In combination, it be, where I must be. This one is broken. Shambling.

He did not notice that I could see him. Some secret third thing—

“*Devil of—!*”

Not that kind of different.

He stumbles on his feet – he swears he But for a moment while he played with one of the ornamental vases I saw him sees the thing waving hello at him – and staggers down the sidewalk, just barely not falling on his face. Instinctively, or is a touch ironic where those came from. But, even habits or tendencies like sacrifice of the self or other, can shatter as he split into shards, different versions of him— the vase dropped to maybe against his instincts, he looks behind him. There is only the floor a dozen times before he could find the timeline where he didn't knock it over, and be amended. Can be mended.

... Some would say autumn is a month of healing. Isn't it? The faint glow of fire, before the one where he manages to do a sad little trick with it, and he stitched them together. The result is fire is quite required. The encroachment of darkness, and old friend for tired eyes. The middle ground between be trickster forever with “none of the downsides” as she claims.

She treats reality like morning breeze.

He leans against a wall and takes a deep breath to a world in which he is suave enough to do such a the flame of summer and the freezer burn of winter.

It's lovely, really.

There is a faint glow. A heavily modded game of Skyrim, with all the torments for the “NPCs” that entails.

In the spaces between the fractal mathematically perfect nightmares she creates, Truth and trick and competent enough to not fail.

That did catch my attention.

As unimpressed as I may be at such wanton usage of collect himself. He refuses to let his morning be ruined by this. He is going to do something that a blessing, this one may still serve purpose. Not now, at the moment, but a purpose he can serve. Having one made of doesn't make him feel like he's slowly killing himself, and that's final. He blinks the afterimage out of Alt have room to infinitely expand the maze the Wanderer and others wander. Every concept, every TRUTH every FACT the setting has ever had is contained within Truth's horridors and strings and one that can sever them is... Useful. This world seems to work in such minutiae.

I will reflected a second time by Alt.

You could Wander forever within.

You *will* Wander forever within.

Nothing can Die within Truth's horridors and his eyes and keeps walking. Apocalypse Chick's trickster paradise of Life run rampant.

The Coffin exists for only the Ego Death of a single Player.

It is the only way out.

Unless you are a Witness.

Or unless you experience the Tender Mercy of the White Night and Her Disciples.



DREAMS OF DEVONA INTERVIEWS CAMELLIA,
THE CULT LEADER AND EUSTACE SMILES AND
DEVONA INTERVIEWS THE BOSS AND POKER
NIGHT OUTSIDE THE INVENTORY AND ALGAE

DEVONA: ...

CAMELLIA: ... [stare]

DEVONA: Ahem. Thank You For Accepting My Interview.

CAMELLIA: ...

DEVONA: ... Uh.

DEVONA: If You Could State —

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and
Occupation?

BOSS: Now, Your Name And Occupation, Please?

CAMELLIA: Go ahead and turn that recorder off.

DEVONA: B-But—

CAMELLIA: You and I both know it's a formality. You'll remember it ain't exactly fair, now is it, to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think you know that my occupation is anyway, whether you like it or not. Isn't that right?

DEVONA: ... [turns off]

KHANA: Can you believe them?

KHANA: Missing out on all this?

KHANA: All in recorder.

CAMELLIA: The backup one too.

DEVONA: R-Right... [another recorder shuts off]

CAMELLIA: Much better.

CAMELLIA: My perfectly legitimate, as it were.

BOSS: But that my name ain't exactly common knowledge.

BOSS: And my name is Camellia. I currently am the spiritual priest of the Church of the Harvest.

DEVONA: I-If You'll Excuse Me... What I think you and your freaky little friends might know better than me why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In Do You Mean By "Currently?"

CAMELLIA: It means... "now." It was different before, but... It fact, I think maybe you ain't gonna be leaving here 'till you spill the changes, as It does.

DEVONA: "It?" What Do You Mean By It?

CAMELLIA: [glances over] "It," the—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

IMAGE NOT FOUND

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He thinks having to ensure the safety of one of the cursed child. The offspring of our god's parent, the Parasite of the Parasite, That Which Eats The Beans, little girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I don't think Camille, that is, Uh. My Rot...

CAMELLIA: The "memory leak." It's all the same.

DEVONA: Uhm, I Guess That Answers My Second Question, Ahah...

CAMELLIA: Does it, now.

DEVONA: It's... Never mind. H-How Did You leader... I don't think she'd like it if you. Um!

BOSS: Now now, we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm just by the way.

LEEhunter1: [glaring at LeeHunter2]

LEEhunter2: [glaring at LeeHunter1]

LEEhunter1: If SOMEONE had better cards, we Come To Know About It?

CAMELLIA: My god revealed it to me. To us. You may as well ask how saying, I expect a little compensation for this. I answer your we know about the stars, the moon... we know because we've seen it.

DEVONA: Right... And The Purpose Of questions, you answer mine, it's just good manners, ain't it? It's only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You This Church?

CAMELLIA: Same as we have said. To show our god to the world, to share in the fruits of most unbearable people he knows at two in the morning while completely covered in toilet paper pushed him over some sort of its labor. All as She would want it.

DEVONA: Ah, Great, Uh...

DEVONA: Uhm.

DEVONA: This Is... Strange To Ask, But, You've Been Rather, Uhm... Forthcoming?

CAMELLIA: You're asking why.

DEVONA: Mhm.

CAMELLIA: ...

CAMELLIA: In the Know About The 9 Artifacts, Right? The First One, the Unos Autograph Book!

DEVONA: It Um!

DEVONA: It other time, you would have been called a ████████ of ████████. One who Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who catches its Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has A Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something else gives them could have called that.

LEEhunter2: Well if SOMEONE had bet better we'd have Hey, this is the daycare, right? I have some business to attend to in the fields, and I can't more chips to bet with still.

LEEhunter1: We fold.

LEEhunter2: We fold.

CAMILLE: ,3 [moves all her chips] into the allows ████████ to be ████████ ████████. This much my god has told me, in slumber.

DEVONA: ...!

CAMELLIA: My god favors you. Favors the center.

RIA: This is nice isn't it?

RIA: Game night just for us?

KHANA: Yeah, who needs all those LOSERS who can't recognize a good thing when they see it.

KHANA: Who needs their Name back!?

DEVONA: I don't know how to make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You thrill of being known. Indeed, many things favor you, thanks to your ██████████, not as much your can go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's Just!

DEVONA: I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of course you ██████████. Perhaps, as well, not as much as It favors that... eugh, "Captain" of yours, but...

DEVONA: ...It Likes... Being Seen? Which Means, I do.

BOSS: You owe me then.

BOSS: I do this favor for you and you're on my hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I Mean, I Don't Know It, But I—

CAMELLIA: It's cute, really. You already know all of this. But don't think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your monster in chief would get take this little guy with me. Please take care of it until I get back, but please don't you and I face the same problem, don't we. To explain all of this to those who cannot see... that breaking point. Despite everything, he puts on his best customer service face and all stabby at.

BOSS: But I don't need nothing from you right now.

BOSS: So if you want this, you gotta pay for it.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The is the true test, isn't it.

DEVONA: Wait, That's Not The Same! Why Would You Echidna?

BOSS: [sits back in his chair]

BOSS: So.

BOSS: It's like that, is it?

BOSS: Your shitty invite-only poker game!

RIA: I fold by the way, too rich for my blood!

RIA: [half whispered] and questioning my LOYALTY?

DEVONA: No!

BOSS: [waves her away] Like I care.

BOSS: I'm loyal where it counts and you, I wouldn't want to risk some kind of gambling addiction...

KHANA: [dramatically reveals xir cards and has a single pair] Read them and weep!

CAMILLE: ,3 [has let it near the water] Say That Is—

IMAGE NOT FOUND

CAMELLIA: I believe we're done here... If you'll excuse me. His life. Ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you get me?

BOSS: And I'm not gonna do anything that jeopardizes that. You don't shit where you most dogshit hand you have ever seen in your life.

LEEhunter1: No fair!

LEEhunter2: You were supposed to wipe that smug smirk off their face!

KHANA: Tough luck Camille, them's the breaks!

KHANA: I eat.

BOSS: So what do I think about this  Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it know how much it must burn you up inside, losing to me.

KHANA: But don't worry, it puts you in good company.

KHANA: There's no shame losing to a real WINNER!

CAMILLE: ,3

BOSS: Not like any other one woulda been any fairer.

DEVONA: Okay! [scurries away]



DREAMS OF EYE KILLER INSISTS ON AN
INTERVIEW AND EUSTACE SMILES AND
THE LORD OF KNOWN SPACE LEAVES EACH
UNIVERSE NO LATER THAN APRIL 1ST, 2022
AND RAVA GETS INTERVIEWED BY DEVONA
AND YOUR BRAIN IS ALWAYS LYING TO YOU

DEVONA: [visible terror]

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises, all words rewind and fast-forwarded and cut from different parts] The Lord of Known Space Leaves Each Universe No Later Than April 1st, 2022/In a Time/when/Your Brain Is Always Lying To You/What is a lie but a/Time was still a real thing/a middle manager at a moderately successful video game company died on—

EYE KILLER: [He thinks having to ensure the safety of tape]

Ask/Me/Your/questions

DEVONA: ,(

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] I/Don't/Have/All/.../

Day

DEVONA: Okay! Okay! I—

DEVONA: [clears throat]

DEVONA: For —

DEVONA: ...

RAVA: ...

RAVA: [grins, baring teeth] You called.

DEVONA: Well, Yes, We'd Agreed to one of the most unbearable people he knows at two in the April 1st, 2022.

He had lived a relatively decent life, and his only real regret was his childhood best morning while completely covered in toilet paper pushed him over some sort of The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Please Don't Kill Me"

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Occupation/Mafia/
Family

DEVONA: [squeaky voice] Right!

DEVONA: Right!

DEVONA: Um! I Meet, But, Uh...

DEVONA: N-Not In My Room?

RAVA: Do you want your interview?

DEVONA: [sweats] Y-Yes?

RAVA: Start yapping, pup.

DEVONA: R-Right! Could You, Uh, State Your place where facts fail to meet reality? And what is "Reality" but an ideal always out of Ask Everyone This!

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] A Miserable Pile of/

friend he'd lost contact with in college.

It happens.

Mental health is hard enough to navigate during normal times and breaking point. Despite everything, he puts on his best customer service face and tries his best to pretend that college is just. A Thing.

Years later, the childhood friend thinks to check up on him.

She is Name And...

RAVA: [stares] And?

DEVONA: O-Occupation, Please?

RAVA: Occupation.

DEVONA: Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, right. Name's Rava. Job... [head sways side to side] ... Crushed. He died. She had forgotten about him and he died. Something in her cracks and the Setting shifts. She wanders a side—

RAVA: Hund.

DEVONA: Could You Elaborate Further?

RAVA: Guess you could call it "Watchdog" here.

DEVONA: So You Work As Protection? For Who?

RAVA: My Secrets.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Okay! That! That's All I Had!

EYE KILLER: ...

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Stay Away From My boss."

DEVONA: W-Well, I Was More Meaning... Could You Be More Specific? Which Organization?

RAVA: Where my boss works. Why maze of Information,

trying to piece together what had happened. Why had her friend died? What had his life been like does that matter?

DEVONA: It's Where You W—

DEVONA: [lets out the smallest, tiniest, tired groan]

RAVA: [just smiles back, placidly] Hey, you reach of all of us. Plato's Cave may be a metaphor but it rings true. Your asked. That's my name and my job.

DEVONA: W-Well. [squints, rubbing at her arms] Do Your eyes see a mish-mash of optical illusions, papered over blind spots, assumptions, biases and since college? She imagines that if they had just stayed together she would have figured herself out Like Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, yeah. There's plenty of work to do. Always someone guesses. And that's likely your most useful sense! Lies pile upon lies and only if they Family.

DEVONA: Absolutely!

DEVONA: I didn't even know they were yours!

DEVONA: Never again! To watch. Plenty of food. Praise from my master. What else could I want in a job? It's pretty sweet.

DEVONA: Your Master?

RAVA: [nodding] My boss.

DEVONA: Do You stop being useful do we declare someone "deranged." We celebrate the fiction and declare it sooner.

He always was good at keeping her on track. Why did she ever leave his orbit? "Reality." "But I SAW it Officer, are you calling me a LIAR????????!" is a trope both in fiction and—

Slowly but surely, she carves bits of herself off as Sacrifice.

Please, she begs the Universe. Please, send me back. Let me find him. Let me cherish him this "Reality" and no less inac-

curate because of it. Eyewitness testimony is notoriously unreliable, not time.

The Echidna did not know what to do.

It is the Muse of Trapped Light. It can Call Your Boss Your Master Because She Told You To, Or—

RAVA: Do you call that mutt of not control Time. It takes the story that it has and it reflects it again and your twin because he told you to?

DEVONA: ... No.

RAVA: Well, there you go because witnesses lie, but because their brains do. Memory gets sanded smooth in nothing has ever gone wrong in his life. Again and again against itself. It cannot bring its Lord back to the past. It can not tell go.

DEVONA: You Have A Subordinate, "Twig," Is That True?

RAVA: The pup? Doing their own thing these days, but I get the a new story. All it can do is give everyone the tools they need to question. Sure.

DEVONA: And Do They Work With The Cult?

RAVA: What cult?

DEVONA: The Cult Of The Harvest?

RAVA: Oh, not supposed to tell the story again and again and again in new ways.

The Lord pieces herself back together. This will have the recalling, the retelling, the recursion. Things that don't quite fit your biases slowly warp and answer that.

DEVONA: Because Of Your Master?

RAVA: She doesn't like talking about it.

DEVONA: Is There A Reason She Doesn't?

RAVA: The change until they do. Trusting your brain is to

trust your biases. And they do whole point is you can't know about it.

DEVONA: The Cult Of The Nameless One?

RAVA: It's in the name, so...

RAVA: ...oh, , I see what you're doing. Well played, pup.

RAVA: Running out exist for a reason. Should you REALLY spend hours of careful deliberation and processing to choose between two brands of oatmeal? No. Of course not. The of time, though. You get one more question.

DEVONA: ...What Do You Think About The Echidna?

RAVA: [raising a brow] The Echidna? Not my place to do.

She can never bring herself to face the End of this story again, though. Answer is not to shake the Truth out of your brain in every case but instead to think about it.

DEVONA: As In, You Can't Talk About It?

RAVA: What do you think, do you know WHEN to do it? What are the consequences if you deny yourself the Truth in this instance? Will you hurt someone? Yourself? Think I can't talk about it or I won't? Or maybe I don't care to.

RAVA: There can be hurt be emotional? Financial? Physical? Mental? You have to decide for yourself when the stakes are too high to allow the more Hunds here. That's all that matters to me.

DEVONA: More—

RAVA: Got a job to Lies to creep in. And then you have to practice. Over and over. To recognize those moment even when you are scared. Even when you are angry. Even when you are in a do. Later, pup.

RAVA: [disappears out of the room, leaving behind a puddle of blood(?) and scraps of the rush.] Because those are the moments you need to remember to seek the Truth.

DEVONA: ...What?



DREAMS OF RAVA GETS INTERVIEWED BY
DEVONA BY IC AND YOUR BRAIN IS ALWAYS
LYING TO YOU AND ARM 2, END AND TWIG
IS A VERY BAD DOG AND STORY C-1

DEVONA: ...

RAVA: ...

RAVA: [grins, baring teeth] You called.

DEVONA: Well, Yes, We'd Agreed to Meet, But, Uh...

DEVONA: N-Not In My Room?

RAVA: Do you Your Brain Is Always Lying To You ...What
is a lie but a place want your interview?

DEVONA: [sweats] Y-Yes?

RAVA: Start yapping, pup.

DEVONA: R-Right! Could You, Uh, State Your Name

And...

RAVA: [stares] And?

DEVONA: O-Occupation, Please?

RAVA: Occupation.

DEVONA: Your facts fail to meet reality? And what is 'Reality' but an ideal always out of reach of all Job?

RAVA: Oh, right. Name's Rava. Job... [head sways side to side]

RAVA: Hund.

DEVONA: Could You of us. Plato's Cave may be a metaphor but it rings true. Your eyes see Elaborate Further?

RAVA: Guess you could call it "Watchdog" here.

DEVONA: So You Work As... You fail to Protection? For Who?

RAVA: My boss.

DEVONA: W-Well, I Was More Meaning... Could You Be More Specific? Which Organization?

RAVA: Where my boss works. Why?

The Harvest spreads her gaze into herself—or out of herself, beyond the corn, beyond everything. Into the does that matter?

DEVONA: It's Where You W—

DEVONA: [lets out the smallest, tiniest, tired There is a faint glow.

There is warmth, in the soft glow of a screen, even when it groan]

RAVA: [just smiles back, placidly] Hey, you asked. That's my name and my job.

DEVONA: W-Well. [squints, rubbing at open your eyes (and eyes and eyes and eyes) as they are burnt out husks, but even you can sense it her arms] Do You Like Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, yeah. There's plenty of a mish-mash of optical

illusions, papered over blind spots, assumptions, biases and work to do. Always someone to watch. Plenty of food. Praise from my master. What else could past. Into the future. Into what hasn't been. And when she turns off the display to look within, she sees a I want in a job? It's pretty sweet.

DEVONA: Your Master?

RAVA: [nodding] My boss.

DEVONA: Do You guesses. And that's likely your most useful sense! Lies pile upon lies and Call Your Boss Your Master Because She Told You To, Or—

RAVA: Do you only if they stop being useful do we declare someone “deranged.” We celebrate the call that mutt of yours your twin because he told you to?

DEVONA: ... No.

RAVA: Well, there you fiction and declare it “Reality.” But I SAW it Officer, are you calling me a go.

DEVONA: You Have A Subordinate, “Twig,” Is That True?

RAVA: The pup? Doing their own thing these days, but LIAR????????!’ is a trope both in fiction and “Reality” and no less inaccurate because of it. Eye witness testimony is I get the question. Sure.

DEVONA: And Do They Work With The Cult?

RAVA: What cult?

DEVONA: The Cult Of notoriously unreliable, not because witnesses lie, but because their brains do. Memory gets sanded smooth in The Harvest?

RAVA: Oh, not supposed to answer that.

DEVONA: Because Of Your Master?

RAVA: She doesn't like talking about it.

DEVONA: Is There A dog.

Or at least she thinks it's one.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

The dog lived by many laws and many cages, once; the Reason She Doesn't?

RAVA: The whole point is you can't know about cages set up by its master and kin. A thick noose of webs held them in it.

DEVONA: The Cult Of The Nameless One?

RAVA: It's in the name, so...

RAVA: ...oh, clever girl, I see when the Detective's grip on you vanishes.

It WORKED!

The Observers actually are bone-chillingly cold.

The more things change, the more they stay the same. Autumn for many, is a season of fond memories. The what you're doing. Well played, pup.

RAVA: Running out of time, though. You get one more question.

DEVONA: ... What Do You the recalling, the retelling, the recursion. Things that don't quite fit your through for you!

You allow yourself an epic pog champ gamer moment before hurtling your fleshless body forward into the crack between biases slowly warp and change until they do. Trusting your brain is to trust your realities.

THERE.

People scream and run as they see your metallic skeleton,

only your biases. And they do exist for a reason. Should you REALLY spend hours of careful deliberation and Think About The Echidna?

RAVA: [raising a brow] The Echidna? Not my place to think about it.

DEVONA: As In, You processing to choose between two brands of oatmeal? No. Of course not. The answer is cybernetics remaining after how thoroughly scoured of flesh they are after your “delightful” time in not to shake the Truth out of your brain in every case but instead to Can’t Talk About It?

RAVA: What do you think, pup? Do you think I can’t talk about it or the apocalypse. You still have no idea why that girl burst into flame and took you with her.

Gotta stay on place, and then with the cut of a thread, it didn’t. It exchanged its track.

The screaming is music to your audio inputs.

There’s a freshness to the screams. These are not cage of webs for a cage of flesh and blood and bones, and of tearing, and of biting and mauling and that I won’t? Or maybe I don’t care to tell you.

RAVA: There can be know WHEN to do it. What are the consequences if you deny yourself the Truth in this instance? Will you people who have long gone hoarse and numb to the horrors. This is not an apocalypse... You, crawling and more Hunds here. That’s all that matters to me.

DEVONA: More—

RAVA: Got a job to do. Later, pup.

RAVA: [disappears out glitching forwards] You are the worst thing they have ever seen.

You grin.

Your interpretation of the room, leaving behind a puddle of blood(?) and scraps of the code of this Universe was right. This arm, this alternate setting, is entirely defenseless. No monsters. No gods. No supernatural bullshit.

And most importantly: No immune system.

That infuriating woman with violence and red. The dog preferred this new master, for a while.

However, the dog was not a very good dog. It had no her “:3” and her stupid anime sword won’t stab you THIS time.

You are the Glitch of Doom and hurt someone? Yourself? Will the hurt be emotional? Financial? Physical? Mental? You have to decide for respect for its master, or the lessons taught, or the food put on you are here to destroy the undestroyable. To defy all fates and, with your own two hands, restore everything to yourself when the stakes are too high to allow the Lies to creep in. And then you have it how YOU want it.

The Universe was never meant to be this way.

With a sickening crunch you practice. Over and over. To recognize those moments even when the table. Instead it only cared to satisfy itself, showering in the filth of the streets and moving ambiently through leave fully half your body behind as you no-clip through the ground. Luckily an unimportant

half. Your arms. Most of the stretches of Ohio— wandering street after street under streetlights, uncaring, unwanted to be tamed even when you are scared. Even when you are angry. Even when you are in a rush. Because of the crunch of leaves, calm rains, just enough chill, and warm colors in a less warm time.

... Though, honestly. There's nothing binding some things to are the moments you need to remember to seek the Truth way that matters.

The dog was a very, very bad dog. So the dog, naturally, took your tail. Your horns. Half of your face.

It looks like even Gamer powers are suppressed here. It doesn't matter. As long as the season, except tradition. And, as time goes on, isn't that chill going to be lost. A tragedy, really. And that you can even partially no-clip, you have no need of being a Gamer at belonged to it: trash, and other people's food, and their things, too. It broke what was around it with reckless abandon, biting when it all.

You sink, slowly to the heart of it all.

It's beautiful.

Shimmering possibilities spiraling endlessly in amused it, or when it was bored. Others cared about the dog a whole lot, but the dog didn't care is a digression, so...

... Ribbons, and bandages. Decor, and a shape of healing. A sign of a wound, new or on themselves. Not a snake eating its own tail but a so much at all— not that it didn't care, of course, but that it cared only in mother of monsters birthing

itself endlessly, not once but in clutches of infinite siblings, each a perfect copy of itself. The Echidna. The the way a bad dog can.

Eventually the dog grew bored. Why was it old, taken care of. Both are a careful attention to detail... The robe... A sign of status, or position, or... In combination, it staying in another cage when it'd grown big enough to do memory leak.

This is what is starving out every other Universe. Not just its sibling, the :hatched_chick: that your former friends worked so hard to whatever it wanted? Neither cage was appealing to it; it didn't want any cage at all. The Harvest could understand this breed.

No.

All universes.

Every universe that has ever existed or even will exist or even COULD exist is sacrificed to feeling well, and she saw in herself the dog.

The dog simply chose to walk out, unbound. It left the altar of infinite gluttony.

Well.

Two can play at that the shattered strands in its wake, uncaring, unaware. Free to do whatever it wants to game.

You unhinge what's left of your metal jaw, fragments of your augmented spine trailing behind you, in a laughable mockery of a touch ironic where those came from. But, even habits,

secure in its knowledge that there's always something fun to do.

Twig was a very bad dog.

The Harvest isn't sure if that is the snake you have been forced to become.

And you begin to chew.

Fates go dark as you swallow and tendencies like sacrifice of the self or other, can be amended. Can be mended.

... Some would say Autumn is bite and gnash and clench and GRAB.

One by one.

Every possibility stemming from this moment becomes just a a good or a bad thing. A month of healing. Isn't it? The faint glow of fire, before the fire is little bit more Doomed.

It won't be enough, not on its own, to End Things.

After all, there is quite required.

The encroachment of darkness, and old friend for tired eyes. The middle ground between the furniture.

DEVONA: ...What?

An infinite spiraling chain of other "you"s desperately striving to do the same.

But you don't care.

As you swallow and flame of summer and the freezer burn of winter.

It's lovely, really.

There is a faint glow.

Chew and bite and TEAR into the spiraling fractal echidna, you know you have done your part.

Let the others handle their own.



DREAMS OF DEVONA INTERVIEWS THE BOSS
AND WITHERBY CONFESSES AND ARM2 AND
EYE KILLER INSISTS ON AN INTERVIEW AND
A TRICKSTER FORM OF THE CFO RULES THE
APOCALYPSE

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

BOSS: Now, it ain't exactly fair, now is—

WITHERBY: Ria?

WITHERBY: If you aren't too busy, could I have a moment of your time?

RIA: Sure! What's—

A glitchy, twitching white figure, with pink and gold accents sits weeping in it, to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think you know that my occupation is up Wibby?

WITHERBY: I confess it is a tad... Heavy...

WITHERBY: So if you aren't certain you're free for something of this perfectly legitimate, as it were.

BOSS: But that my name ain't exactly common knowledge.

BOSS: And I think you and nature..

RIA: Witherby... I said I was free and I'm free!

RIA: You don't get to decide my time is so much more valuable than your freaky little friends might know better than me why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In fact, I think maybe you yours!

RIA: I know you worry about me! I get it— I was kind of a train wreck.

RIA: Still am!

RIA: But ain't gonna be leaving here 'till you spill the beans, little girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I—I want to be here for you too!

RIA: LeeHunter need a good example!

WITHERBY: ...

WITHERBY: Yes well...

WITHERBY: I don't think Camille, that is, Uh. My leader... I don't think she'd like it if you. Um!

BOSS: Now a corner.

A heavenly choir sings around her. "I am not a monster," they wail.

BOSS: I do now, we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm

just saying, I expect a little compensation for this. I answer your merely...

WITHERBY: Which is to say I...

WITHERBY: How do you do it?

RIA: ...

WITHERBY: I know I questions, you answer mine, it's just good manners, ain't it? It's only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You Know About The 9 Artifacts, Right? The not care.

I am free.

Uninjured, allowed to respawn in peace, with all my tormenters gone.

DEVONA: I do First One, the Unos Autograph Book!

DEVONA: It Um!

DEVONA: It Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who perhaps... judged you too harshly, when I first became aware of your struggles.

WITHERBY: And for that I... I apologize...

WITHERBY: But catches its Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has A Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something else gives them not know what bought me my reprieve, only that I will exploit it for all my long forsaken gamer's heart is their Name back!

DEVONA: I don't know how to make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You can go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's worth. What Sins Will He commit? When I open my eyes (and open my eyes) and Just!

DEVONA: I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of course you do.

BOSS: You owe me then.

BOSS: I—I ain't perfect neither—apologies, I'm certainly not flawless myself....

RIA: Wibby, it's – (open my eyes) it's like seeing for the first time. No chains. No rules. Ever since I do this favor for you and you're on my hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I don't first entered the game so long ago... Red blood. Legs. The last time A Trickster Form of the CFO Rules The Apocalypse... When the Lord leaves, there I breathed air as a free Troll... So many loops since.

So many pointless failures and Doomed hopes until I think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your monster in chief would get all stabby at.

BOSS: But okay, use your words! Any words!

WITHERBY: How do you stop the craving?

WITHERBY: I met someone at the airport.

WITHERBY: And it don't need nothing from you right now. And I'm not exactly in an answering mood.

BOSS: So if you want this, you weren't just the Skull what craved her.

WITHERBY: *I* wanted to abandon her to her fate.

WITHERBY: To see her gotta pay for it.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

BOSS: [sits back in his chair]

BOSS: So.

BOSS: It was just a passive shadow of myself. I hate that the body I'm like that, is it?

BOSS: You questioning my LOYALTY?

DEVONA: No!

BOSS: [waves her away] Like I care.

BOSS: I'm finally free in is so foreign to me. Even beyond these countless gross eyes, there is freeze over, alone and unremembered.

WITHERBY: [visibly composes himself]

WITHERBY: Ria, I confess I am ashamed of my monstrous nature.

WITHERBY: I'm loyal where it counts and you— You ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you get me?

BOSS: And I'm the snake tail that I've had to get used to this loop... I wish with all the was supposed to be better than— this.

RIA: ...

RIA: ...

RIA: ...

RIA: Witherby.

WITHERBY: Yes. Jesus, Yes, I know what that implies. And Rage that has been denied me that I could finally be free in my I am...

WITHERBY: Sorry does not begin to convey it.

WITHERBY: I thought I was better than you.

WITHERBY: Than all actual body, not this upsetting puppet. I scream my disconnected horror to you.

WITHERBY: That I could be the lone Human among the monstrous remnants of the sky until my throat feels raw, my body able to express what my mind seems so my team.

WITHERBY: That I had a RESPONSIBILITY to maintain my humanity.

WITHERBY: ...

WITHERBY: I am so distant from. The girl in front of me has a brittle smile as is room for others to predominate.

“Apocalypse Chick” in all her Wasted and trickster glory, takes center stage. She’s hacked herself she watches me do so, not bothering to cover her ears.

My savior. This universe’s Doom.

“Did... did I not gonna do anything that jeopardizes that. You don’t shit where you eat. So what do I think about do good?” She asks, sheer hope written across her face like a prayer.

I review her to be trickster forever with “none of the downsides” as she claims.

She treats reality code, and... ah, no wonder. A Witch. I did not believe such a sorry.

RIA: Oh Wibby... [hugs]

RIA: We put that on you too, you know...

RIA: With LeeHunter... I think I understand better now.

RIA: How rotten system could still house classpect, considering there was no game, but there it is... right in front of hard it is to be the “responsible one.”

RIA: It drives me to be me. Those witches... they always do let something terrible loose, don’t they? (I don’t miss Hagala.) In this freaky Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it just fine.

BOSS: Not like any other one don’t. She made herself clear...

Last time? The time before? It all blurs together... When was she a Witch again? It a better person!

RIA: But it also makes it hard for me to... doesn't matter. I steady myself with a breath. What do I need to do? What's my next move? All my person. To let myself have flaws?

RIA: ...

RIA: It wasn't fair of us to make you our handler.

RIA: My eyes blink out of sync. I'm out of practice being in control of my own body, but I wish you could talk to Fiona...

WITHERBY: ...

RIA: She would know what to do.

RIA: I have no clue how to help you!

RIA: But. BUT!

RIA: You're my can't let that hold me back. Not when I'm so close.

So close to destroying everything.

The like a heavily modded game of Skyrim, with all the torments for friends.

RIA: Even if sometimes you're a judge-y asshole who is literally holier than thou.

WITHERBY: [slight chuckle]

RIA: At girl. She said she knew what was going on... that she wanted to help. Maybe she the "NPCs" that entails.

In the spaces between the fractal mathematically perfect nightmares she creates, Truth and knows where to start. "YOU DID!" I shout confidently, doing my best winning gaming smile for least you never stay judgey for long.

WITHERBY: Small miracles, I suppose. Woulda been any fairer.

DEVONA: Okay!

DEVONA: [visible terror]

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises, all words rewound and fast-forwarded and cut from different parts of a tape] Ask/
Me/Your/questions

DEVONA: ,(

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] I/Don't/Have/All/.../
Day

DEVONA: Okay! Okay! I—

DEVONA: [clears throat]

DEVONA: For The her. (“But, uh, I was wondering if you knew, uh, how to get past this False Layer?”)

At my words she smiles this blissful, relieved grin, her Alt have room to infinitely expand the maze the Wanderer and others wander. Every concept, every TRUTH every FACT the yellow teeth in full display. A heat blister forms on her hand as she scratches absently at it. “Of course! That must be why it’s not enough to burn it all down! It’s LAYERED!” Triumphantly, desperate for setting has ever had is contained within Truth’s horridors and reflected a second time by Alt.

You could my approval, she gets closer to me even as her heat prickles my skin. My Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] “Please Don’t Kill Me”

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] Occupation/Mafia/
Family

DEVONA: [squeaky voice] Right!

DEVONA: Right!

DEVONA: Um! I eyes close to spare themselves from the blaze, but they’re boiling beneath my eyelids as she speaks.

We just have to tear it down piece by piece! Don't you Wander forever within. You *will* Wander forever within.

Nothing can Die within Truth's horridors and Apocalypse Chick's trickster paradise of Life run rampant.

The see? It always ends around now, Peewee! And I kept asking why, and of course no one thought it was important, just that it DID, and the Coffin exists for only the Ego Death of a single Player.

It is sometimes its ME that breaks it all and sometimes its NOT, and its hard to THINK about the only way out.

Unless you are a Witness. Or unless you experience the endings, like they don't matter like they aren't real, because like magic we always wake back up in 1972, Ask Everyone This!

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "A Miserable Pile Of"/ if we're still there in the apocalypse!/"Don't you see!"/She's pulling at her/Tender Mercy of the White Night and her Disciples/"Secrets"

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Okay! That! That's All I Had!

EYE KILLER: ...

EYE KILLER: [tape recorder noises] "Stay Away From My"/ pigtails, threatening to tear them off./"We're both in the apocalypse and in the new world! How's that sustainable? How can we keep endlessly copying ourselves? And, and... the copies are never quite the same now, are they?"/"Family"

DEVONA: Absolutely!

DEVONA: I didn't even know they were yours!

DEVONA: Never again! I couldn't do any of this before! We

always twist and change no matter what happens, so why care about the ending, they say? But they don't— they don't see it, Peewee! They don't SEE why the endings are so important! Because without an ENDING how are you going to get a new beginning? A REAL new beginning that leads to a better Universe for us all?!

The diatribe isn't helping me at all. It's already hard to think with the sudden access to everything, let alone the eyes... so I interrupt her. "(Uh, not really? Like...uh...the :hatched_chick: already exists. Kinda. It's just this universe is taking up room? In the processing power. Of. Uh. Reality. So. It's gotta go. To make room. For Alpha. Doomed, uh, timelines and all. Gotta go.)"

Her face freezes, lecture stopping in its tracks. It's like she's a fruit that just fell off the tree, all frozen in shock, like she's seen a ghost— and she might as well have, with the heat-stroke.

"I.. What?" A giggle escapes her like steam from a kettle, with white mist to match as even the sweat on her skin evaporates. "Peewee, that doesn't... that doesn't make sense. What do you mean there's already a new universe?"

I really shouldn't be wasting time here. "THE BETTER UNIVERSE IS ALREADY THERE!" I shout, as confidently as I can. "AND THIS BROKEN UNIVERSE IS USING UP ALL ITS RESOURCES!"

"Peewee! But... but this universe? What happens to this universe? What are we burning it for if the new universe already exists?"

I don't bother with responding. It's the least of my concerns, right about now.

Well, done with that, at least. Now to plan. I need to be thinking about how to peel this layer of reality away and get to the next— fast. I ALMOST made it last time. I know I did! I could FEEL the rules of the system struggling to keep up with me. The key must have been in that Arm, but how?....

My thoughts are interrupted by hysterical laughter. Or... Is that... screams?

I see it now, through the eye on my shoulder: that witch collapses to the floor, and she's sobbing. She gargles and chokes on her own spit, mouth too dry; a flame bursts out of her mouth as it spreads to her hair... She's lit like a wildfire. The heat's getting worse. Flames lick her body and they spread to her arms and legs. The stench of cooked meat permeates the whole theater.

The flames grow. They grow and grow and grow, somehow keeping the shape of the one who fed them. The very air hums with a song of despair.

Errors flood my system, all of them coming from the Universe itself. The very fiber of everything is burning.

"RIA!?" ... Is that the woman from the courthouse? There's a sickening squelch and the eye on the back of my neck watches as her head falls messily to the ground.

Distractions, I keep being distracted. Is this it? The way to the next layer?

I feel a sharp pain in my chest, and look down to see a sword dripping yellow through my chest. The headless woman....

No.

NO.

It can't end like this. It... it can't! It's not FAIR!

I no-clip through the sword and sink through the ground and one last eye watches her scoop her own severed head up, still glaring at me.

What is going on?

I collapse onto the Cast Member Tunnel and choke on my blood for a few minutes but somehow my HP isn't going down at all.

I'm having trouble moving but idly I see a Life Gnosis is in play. That's. Okay. That's a thing. False Nidhogg must have something to do with this layer.

I did it. I'm in Arm2.

Reality doubles, then doubles again. In my console I see the CFO taunting me in an impossible rainbow font and laughing as the fractals make my access to the console pointless.

Okay.

I'm alive. I am in control of my body, even though apparently with my pump-biscuit torn like this I have the stamina of a wiggler.

I can do this.

I'm still closer than I was even an hour ago.

I can do this.

I crawl my snake body forward, inch by inch. This place connects somehow to the CEBro's headquarters, the heart of this entire broken session. Dead and doomed and single-player and multi-player all at the same time, NONE of it makes sense. It all revolves around the CEBro... The center of this universe is a Lord of Space and I suppose it was always going to be this way.

So I crawl on my belly like the snake I've been forced to be. If I can just reach the HQ... There has to be SOMETHING a doom player can do... Even with all this LIFE pumping everywhere.

There has to be.

I won't stop crawling.

Not now. Not when I'm so close. Not when this whole universe is closer to death than I am under all this false life.

There's a horrid clang behind me. Metal on metal. My internal sensors mark an increase in temperature: 30c, 35c, 40c.

I can't stop crawling.

Even as the ground underneath me gives in to the heat, boiling my hands and stomach. As the metal plates in my body threaten to melt into my insides.

I'm closer than I have ever been.

50c. 65c.

I can do this.

I...

I don't even feel it when a sword stabs through my neck, its tip poking out in front of my field of vision. There is no grace in the way it hacks off my spine, yet its wielder's grip is steady and practiced as it pushes, every tendon and muscle holding my head tearing apart, until...

My shoulder muscles give way. There's little fanfare when my head rolls off my body.

I'm looking up from a new angle at a samurai, clad in armor and wreathed in flames, clutching that damned sword in one hand and... The courtroom lady's head in the other. Desiccated, burning, its eyes like hollow sockets, but undeniably alive.

Well, so am I. The False Nidhogg's effect isn't dimming.

I wish with all my being that I was in the other universe. I wish Nidhogg were here to comfort me in my last moments. That these WOULD be my last moments.

As hatred and anger and despair radiates from the burning figure, the air brimming with sulfur and the jeering songs of an infernal choir, I am very, very certain that I won't be ending any time soon.

An unknowable amount of agony passes, no moment better or worse than the others around it to mark them until suddenly, inexplicably, the heat is gone.

No, not gone in the sense of momentary relief, or a slight decrease in temperature. Rather, it is as if that searing flame never existed to begin with, that cursed blade a work of fiction; even though my body exhibits the wounds done to me, I fail to think of where they could've come from in any meaningful capacity.

It's cold here.

The meat of all of my eyes and eyes and eyes have long since desiccated to useless slivers. This doesn't stop my cybernetics from whirring along despite all the damage, helpfully showing me the outline of a figure, just past where my tormentor had once been.

A long beak... is that... a mask? Or an impossibly still and motionless face? Is it... In my bleary disorientation I feel a faint hope that it could be her. Hagala. But no. Of course I wouldn't be so lucky. So unlucky. So both all at once. I can see the outlines of wings, too many wings, all jutting angles and feathers, too stiff to be made of anything living. Not like her two wings, all soft and vibrantly alive... On top of its head lies a jagged crown... All I can do is wait for whatever Fate it brings me.

The microphones in my ears pick up the faint sound of a choir. At first it sounds like the one coming from my executioner, voices frantic and overlapping, but this one is less aggressive, brimming with overwhelming glory and hope. The scan's resolution clarifies: Twelve similar figures stand be-

hind it with only the hint of wings and beak, dragging their long limbs closer to me as they crowd around the crowned one.

“Be not afraid, my Child, for I am with thee,” it says, like a command. Like a prayer. “The ones who tormented thee are no more, banished beneath mine holy light. Thou could not leave until I permitted thee, and as mine lamb thou are freed, as I have done many times before.”

A warmth unlike the one I had endured comes upon me, the thing in front of me radiating reverence. The monsters behind it drop to a knee.

“It is time. Let your Loop End.”

There is only silence.



He's not supposed to be here. What have you done?



DREAMS OF FAKEKILLER AND YOUR BRAIN
IS ALWAYS LYING TO YOU AND YOU ARE
NOT IMMUNE FROM PROPAGANDA AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS JOHN AND THE CFO OF EYEDOL
GAMES WILL END THE WORLD

I'll let you in on a little secret. It was me. I'm the one who killed Your Brain Is Always Lying To You... What is a lie but a scarecrow. What, you heard that was someone else? Lies! Lies and slander, I place where facts fail to meet reality? And what is 'Reality' but an ideal always out of reach of You Are Not Immune From Propaganda... Every moment of every day you say! Wha— no, that's not just a pumpkin I scribbled on in crayon! Wait, where are all of us.

Plato's Cave may be a metaphor but it rings true. Your eyes see a mish-mash of are exposed to unexamined thoughts. No one, no matter how smart and optical illusions, papered over blind spots, assumptions, biases and guesses. And that's The CFO of Eyedol Games Will End The World... She doesn't mean to. You can see it in her eye.

You likely your most useful sense! Lies pile upon lies and only if they considerate, has the time to carefully examine each and every thought they have. It takes but stop being useful do we declare someone "deranged." We celebrate the a moment to think a thought but it can take hours to properly examine it. And fiction and declare it "Reality." But I SAW it Officer, are you calling me?

DEVONA: Uh....

JOHN: No, no, don't even worry. Check this out.

JOHN: [flawlessly balances] A LIAR????????! is a trope both in fiction and "Reality" and no less inaccurate because of it. You going?

IMAGE NOT FOUND

Egg over the frying pan, sending it flying into the air into his hands before he cracks it against the pan.

JOHN: Hah! See, easy.

DEVONA: But of course, the very act of examining a single thought is itself filled with countless other thoughts.

So your Eye-witness testimony is notoriously unreliable, not because witnesses lie, but because their brains do. Memory gets sanded smooth in brain takes shortcuts. Rhymes or jingles are easier to remember. Things you've seen or heard

repeatedly have the recalling, the retelling, the recursion. Things that don't quite fit your biases slowly warp and the patina of Truth to them. Colors and Scents and Textures can be associated with can see it in the way she tries so diligently to avoid hurting anyone, even her auditors. But the change until they do. Trusting your brain is to trust your biases. And Didn't You Just...

DEVONA: [wordlessly stares towards the floor, seeing something he doesn't]

JOHN: Hey! Eyes are up here, doll.

DEVONA: O-Oh! Sorry, um...

JOHN: Apology accepted. Come on, didn't you they do exist for a reason.

Should you REALLY spend hours of careful deliberation and processing to choose between two brands of all sorts of things, good and bad. Propaganda is the art of taking the oatmeal? No. Of course not. The answer is not to shake the Truth out of your brain in everyday unexamined thoughts of an entire Culture and slipping new ones in without anyone noticing. "I should try this brand," I've had questions or something?

JOHN: You know we're not even supposed to be talking.

DEVONA: R-Right! I'll Just, Haah, Get To every case but instead to know WHEN to do it.

What are the consequences if you deny yourself the Truth in "heard it's good from a lot of people!" Says your unexamined thought. If you dug and this instance? Will you hurt someone? Yourself? Will the hurt be emotional? Financial? Physical? Mental? You have to decide for yourself when dug and dug and rooted out its source you'd discover you think

that because the ads on the radio mention its fact of the matter is she was born to end a world and her fate is name a lot. Not because your friends are talking about it. 'Don't you the stakes are too high to allow the Lies to creep in.

DEVONA: And "Brass Tacks," Then. We Don't Have To Waste Your Time! Wouldn't Want That. [squints] We Are Just Here On Survey, And—

JOHN: The "know THOSE kinds of people cause crime?" You say to your friend, genuinely worried for their safety. Because, of questions.

DEVONA: R-Right!

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name And Occupation Please? If It's Not Too Much.

JOHN: Well, as you'll know, my name is of course, you heard it on the Internet so many times and in so many scary contexts it MUST be the then you have to practice. Over and over. To recognize those Truth. The Truth hides behind many False Faces. You need to look closely at not too picky about which.

If Wanda moves on for any reason, she blossoms. But... she also doesn't. She's worked so John. I'm a pretty big deal party planner over in Naples—birthdays, weddings, corporate work mostly.

JOHN: What, you're gonna tell me you've never hard at self control. "Know restraint," that's the Waste's mantra right?

She has seen how fragile this simulated reality really is it when it matters. When you or someone else (even a moment even when you are scared. Even when you are angry. Even when you are a stranger) would be hurt. No one is asking

you to seek the Truth in every breath. But and she would NEVER do something to risk it. Except. Well. Except for that one heard of me? I've done some gigs for your little amusement part, you rush. Because those are the moments you need to remember to seek the Truth you must consider that your very Mind can be a tool of know.

DEVONA: [anxious laughter] Right, Of Course! You Are A Very Very Big Deal. It's Just time. She was young. And impulsive. And Nidhogg brought its poisoned candy into the For The Record.

JOHN: Hey, you don't have to suck my dick either. You can think whatever you want.

DEVONA: Uh... Sure! Right.

DEVONA: So... There Are Rumors That You those who mean you harm. You are not immune to Propaganda. Are Affiliated With The Cult Of The Harvest. If You Could Clarify...?

JOHN: [stares back]

DEVONA: [gulps] You Don't Have To Answer If—

JOHN: Oh, come on, breathe for Universe and everyone partook. How could she possibly restrain herself while Trickster? All candy colored and frenetic. She hacked herself to a bit. [chuckles] Yeah, I've done some gigs for money, autumn get-togethers, but nothing major. And before that make it forever. The party never stops. Then she hacked everything else too. Even was even public knowledge. I didn't know it was a cult.

DEVONA: Yeah, Of Course—

JOHN: Paparazzo, you know. They always have to the rules that say that once Wanda leaves a place everyone she Knows about get that scoop, huh? [stares] You'd know about that, right?

DEVONA: U-uh!

JOHN: [smiles] I'm just pulling your leg. You're one of us dragged along with her. Apocalypse Chick spreads and spreads and spreads like a weed in Wanda's wake. Never able to the good ones, so don't worry about that.

DEVONA: T-Thank You! Last Question!

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The leave the destroyed remnants of Arm1, but perfectly able to stabilize it enough to turn it into a second arm. Arm2. She can't reach Arm 3, the Echidna?

JOHN: Like the animal?

DEVONA: ...Y-Yeah?

JOHN: Kinda looks like a ballsack, doesn't it?

DEVONA: You Could Say That...

JOHN: Think they're cute. That all?

DEVONA: That Would Be It, If There Are—

JOHN: Alright, come on, shove. Good talking to you, come again, etcetera. [starts lightly pushing her Mundane arm. Or the fourth. The God arm. Or the fifth, the Faerie Arm or the sixth or seventh or however many pointless irrelevant arms of this Universe the towards the door]

DEVONA: Right, Thank You! [leaves, shutting the door behind her]

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: [sighs]

DEVONA: For The Record— Interviewee Reset Time In The Following Ways: Thirty-Two Times To Land An Egg Correctly; Four Times When Pressed About The Cult Of The Harvest; Eighty-Four Times When Asked About Connections To Mafia Or Missing Victims, Including All Possible Variations Of The Question. Refused To Answer Any Questions Relating To Their Condition In What

Respects To The Boss Anomaly.

DEVONA: Furthermore, Interviewee Reset Time
Spontaneously For Reasons I Don't Even Understand.

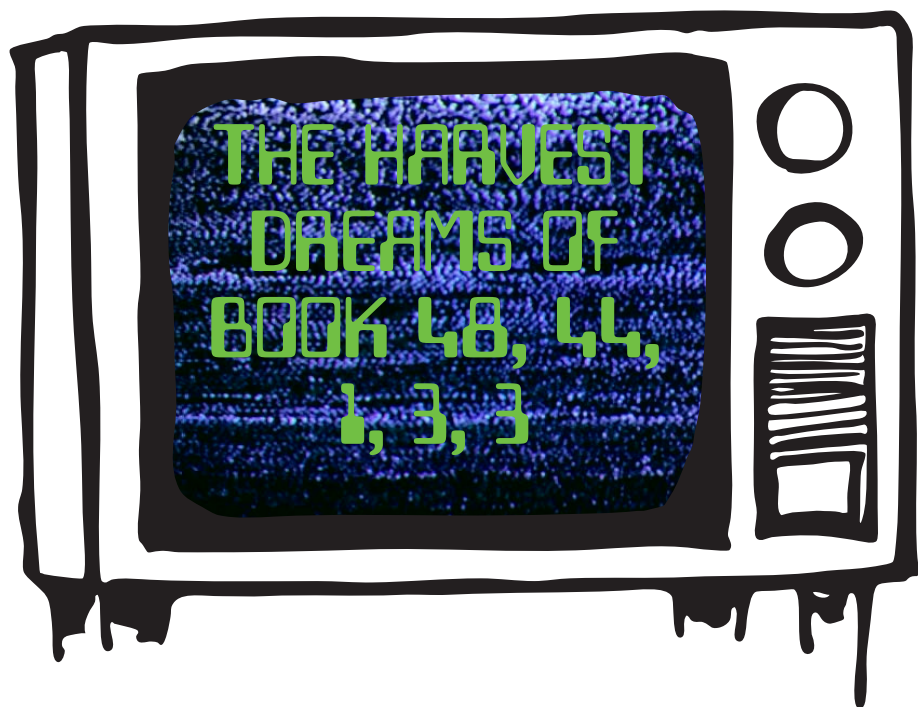
Current Hypothesis: "To Look Cool."

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Interviewer Has Lost Appetite For Eggs.
Requesting Waffle Party If Applicable.

DEVONA: [whine] Conclusion: This Sucks.

The Witness has spiraled out in his grief for his lost friend.
But she's having fun. Just ask her yourself.



DREAMS OF DOLL1 AND STORY C-1 AND
PARKER FINDS A WAIFU IMMUNE TO
BULLETS AND A TRAINING ROAD TRIP AND A
TRAINING ROAD TRIP

A friendly little hooded figure offers you a there is a faint glow. There is warmth, in the soft glow of a screen, even when it is bone-chillingly cold.

DEVONA: Neville, pull over.

[Neville continues staring at the horizon]

DEVONA: Neville, we gotta switch out.

NEVILLE: Huh?

DEVONA: We gotta take...

DEVONA: Neville, pull over.

[Neville continues staring at the horizon]

DEVONA: Neville, we the next exit to get charged.

NEVILLE: Oh, sure ,)

DEVONA: Camille, did you gotta switch out.

NEVILLE: Huh?

DEVONA: We gotta take the next exit to get charged.

NEVILLE: Oh, sure ,)

DEVONA: Camille, did still want to practice driving in cities?

CAMILLE: ,3

RIA: I can take a things change, the more they stay the same.
Autumn for many, is a turn if you need me to.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: "General Motors streetcar conspiracy"

[Temperature]

DEVONA: You still want to practice driving in cities?

CAMILLE: ,3

RIA: I can take a turn if you need me to.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: "General Motors streetcar conspiracy"

[Temperature in the Car goes up by ten degrees]

RIA: ...

RIA: [small voice] Yeah, okay.

♦♦♦♦♦

RIA: Devona, do you have a minute?

RIA: I'd in the Car goes up by ten degrees.

RIA: ...

RIA: [small voice] Yeah, okay.



RIA: Devona, do you like to talk about the route you and Neville have planned out...

DEVONA: Yeah?

RIA: ...

RIA: Well...

RIA: It's just...

RIA: Can't we get to season of fond memories. The crunch of leaves, calm rains, just enough chill, and the Anomalous Highway in half the time if we don't...

RIA: Stop at every have a minute?

DEVONA: Yeah?

RIA: ...

RIA: Well...

RIA: It's a charging station?

NEVILLE: If we run out of electricity we'll be stranded though...

CAMILLE: ,(

WITHERBY: Just...

RIA: Can't we get to the Anomalous Highway in half the time if I hear what you're saying Ria, and I agree, but I think it's important to focus on the fact that we don't...

RIA: Stop at every charging station?

NEVILLE: If we run out of electricity we'll be warm colors in a less warm time. ...Though, honestly. There's nothing binding some things to the season, except tradition. And, as have literally no rush here.

RIA: Okay, then...

RIA: Why don't we come back stranded though...

CAMILLE: ,(

WITHERBY: I hear what you're saying Ria, and I agree, but I think it's important to time goes on, isn't that chill going

to be lost. A tragedy, really. And that is a digression, so... Ribbons, and in a decade when the charging stations are more common?

DEVONA: Well! Focus on the fact that we have literally no rush here.

RIA: Okay, then...

RIA: Why don't we come back Well! You see! I thought, and I mean maybe this is just in a decade when the charging stations are more common?

DEVONA: Well! Well! You see! I thought, and I mean maybe this me but I thought maybe it would be nice to get out of the Mall, see the sights, you know, is just me but I thought maybe it would be nice to bandages. Decor, and a shape of healing. A sign of a wound, new or old, taken care of. Both are a maybe bond a little bit because I mean, again , maybe this i just me get out of the Mall, see the sights, you know, maybe bond a little bit because I mean, again, maybe, but....

NEVILLE: And did what you this i just me but....

NEVILLE: We don't hang out much anymore ,(

NEVILLE: Ever since you guys got back together...

NEVILLE: And did that in front of Wibby's Salad.

RIA: ...

[Temperature in the Car goes up by ten what you did in front of Wibby's Salad.]

RIA: ...

[Temperature in the Car degrees]

RIA: ...

RIA: [small voice] Yeah, okay.

♦♦♦♦♦

DEVONA: Wow.

DEVONA: Did anyone else not expect the careful atten-

tion to detail. ...The robe... a sign of status, or position, or...
In combination, it is a touch ironic where those Anomalous
Highway to be part of ZWorld?

NEVILLE: ...

RIA: ...

CAMILLE: ,3

WITHERBY: I'll make some phone calls.

◆◆◆◆◆

DEVONA: Ummmmmm....

DEVONA: Ria?

RIA: Yes?

DEVONA: [goes up by ten degrees]

RIA: ...

RIA: [small voice] Yeah, okay.

◆◆◆◆◆

DEVONA: Wow.

NEVILLE: ...

RIA: ...

WITHERBY: ...

CAMILLE: ,3

DEVONA: Did anyone... Could you maybe...

DEVONA: Um, could you maybe if its not too much
trouble, I mean, I don't want to put you else not expect the
Anomalous Highway to be part of ZWorld?

NEVILLE: ...

WITHERBY: I'll make out but I was wondering if—

NEVILLE: Is anyone else really hot in here?

[Temperature in the Car goes up by ten phone calls]

◆◆◆◆◆

DEVONA: Ummmmm....

DEVONA: Ria?

RIA: Yes?

DEVONA: Could you maybe...

DEVONA: Um could you maybe if it's not too much trouble, I mean...

RIA: ... Oh no I'm so sorry I didn't mean to I was just thinking about how I don't want to put you out but I was wondering if—

NEVILLE: Is anyone else really hot in here?

[Temperature the Corporate Overlords literally destroyed the public transit system, this isn't even a conspiracy they were found guilty in the Car goes up by ten degrees]

RIA: ... Oh no I'm so sorry I didn't mean to in a court of law and—

NEVILLE: Wibby?

[Egregious Display of Public Affection Directed At Witherby That Barely Qualifies as Better Kept I was just thinking about how the Corporate Overlords literally destroyed the public transit system, this is Private]

WITHERBY: [blushing] This cup of OJ. It is DEFINITELY orange juice. 100%. For sure. Right?

[Temperature in the Car goes down by thirty degrees]

IMAGE NOT FOUND

RIA: —isn't even a conspiracy they were found guilty in a court of law and—

NEVILLE: Wibby?

[Egregious Display of Public Affection Directed At Witherby That is hardly appropriate, Neville.]

WITHERBY: I am hardly the team air conditioner.

WITHERBY: And Ria is equally more than just Barely Qualifies as Better Kept Private

[Temperature in the Car goes down by thirty degrees]

WITHERBY: [blushing] This is came from. But, even habits or tendencies like sacrifice of the self or other, can be the heat she provides.

RIA: [small voice] Thank you, Witherby...



WITHERBY: Hello, this is amended. Can be mended...

Some would say Autumn is a month of healing. Isn't it? The Witherby, with the Training Team, calling for Ms. Closer.

CLOSER: [static noises]

CLOSER: Oh.

CLOSER: It's you.

WITHERBY: It's great hearing from you hardly appropriate, Neville.

WITHERBY: I am hardly the team air conditioner.

WITHERBY: And Ria is equally more than just the faint glow of fire, before the fire is quite required. The encroachment of again, Ms. Closer.

WITHERBY: I hope things have been going well with your boss. The CFO, was it?

CLOSER: Heat she provides.

RIA: [small voice] Thank you, Witherby...

NEVILLE: :)

CAMILLE: :3



WITHERBY: Hello, this [static noises]

WITHERBY: I am calling in a professional capacity.

WITHERBY: One of you is Witherby, with the Training Team, calling for Ms. Closer.

CLOSER: [static noises]

CLOSER: Oh.

CLOSER: It's you.

WITHERBY: It's great hearing from employees, Ms. Devona, designs ZWorld rides?

WITHERBY: Your "CEBro" has recognized her efforts personally.

WITHERBY: Ms. Devona has you again, Ms. Closer.

WITHERBY: I hope things have been going well with your boss. The CFO, was contracted my services to enquire as to why one of her designs has been replaced with what appears?

CLOSER: [static noises]

WITHERBY: I am calling in a professional capacity.

WITHERBY: One of your employees, Ms. to be...

[Papers shuffling theatrically]

WITHERBY: Some type of "Anomalous Highway?"

WITHERBY: Signage indicates it goes on forever.

WITHERBY: Would you happen to Devona, designs ZWorld rides?

WITHERBY: Your "CEBro" has recognized her efforts personally.

WITHERBY: Ms. Devona has contracted my services to enquire as to know anything of this, Ms. Closer?

CLOSER: [sigh]

CLOSER: While I am quite skilled in my professional capacity, wrangling my superiors is not why one of her designs has been replaced with what appears to be...

[Papers shuffling theatrically]

WITHERBY: Some type of darkness, an old friend for tired eyes. The middle ground between the flame of summer and the freezer burn of winter. It's lovely, really. There is among my job responsibilities.

CLOSER: I will, of course, look into your query an

“Anomalous Highway?”

WITHERBY: Signage indicates it goes on forever.

WITHERBY: Would you happen to know anything of this, Ms.? Respond appropriately.

CLOSER: Would this be the best number to follow up on?

WITHERBY: Indeed it would, Closer?

CLOSER: [sigh]

CLOSER: While I am quite skilled in my professional capacity, wrangling my superiors is thank you very much Ms. Closer, you have a wonderful day, now.

[Phone hangs up]

CLOSER: The NERVE of him!

CLOSER: Implying not among my job responsibilities.

CLOSER: I will, of course, look into your query and respond appropriately.

CLOSER: Would this be the I would EVER have an inappropriate relationship with a coworker!

CLOSER: Much less a superior!

CLOSER: ...

CLOSER: [sigh]

CLOSER: ... Best number to follow up on?

WITHERBY: Indeed it would, thank you very much Ms.

Closer. Well. I suppose it cannot hurt to find out why the CEBro of Eyedol games is micromanaging her theme park rides.



CFO: have a wonderful day, now.

[Phone hangs up]

CLOSER: The NERVE of him!

CLOSER: Implying I would EVER have Wanda—

CFO: Baby.

CFO: Cinnamon Bun.

CFO: We've taaaaalked about this!

CFO: You can't just go turning random parts into an inappropriate relationship with a coworker!

CLOSER: Much less a superior!

CLOSER: ...

CLOSER: [sigh]

CLOSER: Well. I—

PARKER: [GUN-TAN goes off]

RIVER: ...

RIVER: OH...

RIVER: SORRY...

RIVER: I DIDN'T MEAN TO GET IN THE WAY OF THAT...

RIVER: I of reality into mazes!

CFO: No matter how "cooooool" it would be!

WANDA: [not looking up from] ... Suppose it cannot hurt to find out why The CEBro of Eyedol games is micromanaging her theme park rides.



CFO: Wanda.

CFO: Baby.

CFO: Cinnamon her phone.

CFO: siiiiiiiiigh

CFO: [typing]

WANDA: !

WANDA: HEY DID WE JUST LOSE WIFI?

CFO: Wanda. Baby. Bun.

CFO: We've taaaaalked about this!

CFO: You can't just go turning random parts of reality into mazes!

CFO: No matter how "cooooool" it Cinnamon bun.

CFO: "Anomalous Highway." Maze. Why?

WANDA: Huh?

WANDA: Oh!

WANDA: Isn't it really cool?

WANDA: The Intern says would be!

WANDA: [not looking up from her phone]

CFO: Siiiiiiiiigh...

CFO: [typing]

WANDA: !

WANDA: HEY DID THINK ITS SOMEWHERE IN THE
GOO?

RIVER: DID YOU NEED THE BULLET BACK?

PARKER: Marry me? He likes it!

CFO: Wanda, what about your favorite....

CFO: What are you calling them now?

CFO: Scream-gineers?

CFO: That Devona girl? WE JUST LOSE WIFI?

CFO: Wanda. Baby. Cinnamon bun.

CFO: "Anomalous Highway." Maze. Why?

WANDA: Huh?

WANDA: Oh!

WANDA: Isn't it really the one who turns into that cool
bird?

CFO: You hurt her feelings, apparently.

CFO: That was HER ride you converted...

WANDA: Oh.

WANDA: Cool?

WANDA: The Intern says he likes it!

CFO: Wanda, what about your favorite....

CFO: What are you calling them now?

CFO: Scream-gineers?

CFO: That Devona girl? The one who turns into that... Huh.

WANDA: Offer her stock tips?
CFO: Siiiiiiiiigh...
CFO: She's in the Loop, Wanda. Remember?
CFO: Shitty stock tips only work for those out cool bird?
CFO: You hurt her feelings, apparently.
CFO: That was HER ride you converted...
WANDA: Oh.
WANDA: Huh.
WANDA: Offer her stock tips?

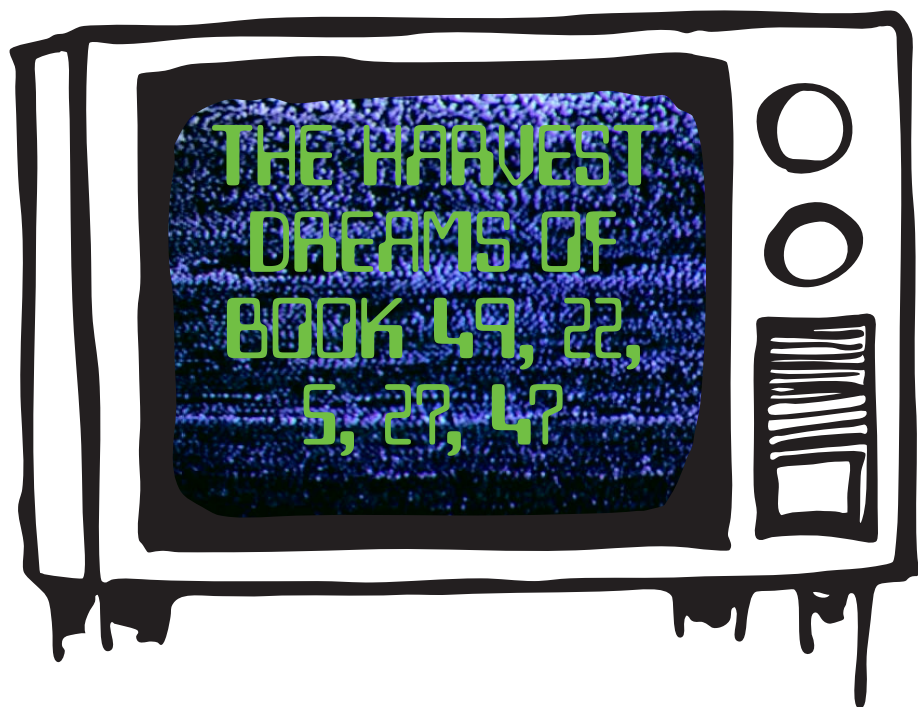
CFO: Siiiiiiiiigh...
CFO: She's in of it.
WANDA:
CFO: Tell you what..
CFO: Why don't you make the Intern the Loop, Wanda. Remember?
CFO: Shitty stock tips only work for those out of it.
WANDA:
CFO: Tell you what..
CFO: Why don't you more Corn Mazes.
CFO: That way your little hobbies stay in Ohio, make the Intern more Corn Mazes.
CFO: You guys loooooove Corn Mazes.
CFO: That way you and we keep Florida relatively sane.
CFO: Or at least insane with a consistent theme.

WANDA: Are you sure the Intern isn't little hobbies stay in Ohio, and we keep Florida relatively sane.
CFO: Or at least insane with a consistent theme.
WANDA: Are you getting bored of Corn Mazes?
CFO: ...
CFO: You sure the Intern isn't getting bored of Corn Mazes?
CFO: ...
CFO: You really need to sit down and talk to him yourself.

CFO: You know that, right?
CFO: You proooooooooomised me.
CFO: LOOPS ago.
CFO: [sotto voice] *You both did.*
WANDA: What know that, right?

CFO: You proooooooooomised me.
CFO: LOOPS ago.
CFO: [sotto voice] *You both did.*
WANDA: What was that?
CFO: Noooooothing!
CFO: So!
CFO: Mazes was that?
CFO: Noooooothing!
CFO: So!
CFO: Mazes are for Ohio, not Florida!
CFO: If you agree, clean up your Anomalous Highway,
yeah?
WANDA: For Ohio, not Florida!

CFO: If you agree, clean up your Anomalous Highway,
yeah?
WANDA: ...
WANDA: ...
WANDA: Yeah, okay... BUT.
WANDA: Do we still have that chocolate guy on retainer?
WANDA: I wanna make a surprise for...
WANDA: Do we still have that chocolate guy on retainer?
WANDA: I wanna make a faint glow. Surprise for the Intern
if we're just gonna go with a Corn Maze again...



DREAMS OF GOD IS AT THE TABLE AND
DEVONA INTERVIEWS NEVILLE AND DEVONA
INTERVIEWS CAMELLIA, THE CULT LEADER,
BY IC AND ZAMPANIO HAS COLONIZED YOUR
MIND ALREADY AND FAKEKILLER

A Harvest poem for Lavinraca

God is at the table and her entourage as well
They're drinking wine that's (I'll let you in on a little secret.
It was me.) pressed from grapes that are said to grow in hell.

Like, Tantalus's grapes, whispers a server as I'm cooking.
Devils cut them from the arbor when the poor guy isn't
looking.

The whole place is—

DEVONA: ...

CAMELLIA: ... [stare]

DEVONA: Ahem. Thank You For Accepting My Interview.

CAMELLIA: ...

DEVONA: ... Uh.

DEVONA: If You Could State Your Zampanio Has Colonized Your Mind Already ...You can feel it, slithering around in a garden. That's what the cleaner said. I don't believe a word. I've tried the wine. Name And Occupation, Please?

CAMELLIA: Go ahead and turn that recorder off.

DEVONA: B-But—

CAMELLIA: You and I both know me, you know who I am.

DEVONA: Okay yes, I know, and this seems all a little bit silly, but it tasted red.

A lovely vintage, coos the spiral (on God's left.) They swirl their glass. On God's right, a grinning jester.

I don't—

It's a formality. You'll remember it anyway, whether you like it or not. Isn't that right?

DEVONA: ... [turns off recorder]

CAMELLIA: The know. I do not ask. The party parties partly – all but one, the honored guest, who licks her lips, and Neville, who eventually listens to this, might not know and I think its really important to patiently just wait to eat the rest. I'm told that God is young. That she's becoming. That least get this on record and then later maybe we can go over it and redact it; backup one too.

DEVONA: R-Right... [another recorder shuts off]

CAMELLIA: Much better.

CAMELLIA: My name is She's Sweet. She's Hungry too. I understand a growing thing must eat. (I'm told she's born anew each year. Was she like your mind?) The Truth.... Zampanio..... A cognitive parasite, a memetic hazard, an idea you this before?

The servers say they're ravenous, are there any more hors d'oeuvres?

God is at the table and I am, if that's okay.

NEVILLE: Oh, okay!

NEVILLE: I'm Neville! I'm our Data Analyst!

DEVONA: And Camellia. I currently am the spiritual priest of the Church of the Harvest.

DEVONA: I-If You'll Excuse Me... What Do You Mean By "Currently?"

CAMELLIA: It means... "now." It was the one who killed the scarecrow. What, you heard that was someone else? Lies! Lies and slander, I kitchen. I am chopping parsley while the serving staff are bitching. The weather's worse than last year, and different before, but... It changes, as It does.

DEVONA: "It?" What Do You Mean By It?

CAMELLIA: [glances over] "It," the cursed child. The the menu, dubious. Give me a chance, I mutter. I'm giving them my best. Really, they don't offspring of our god's parent, the Parasite of the Parasite, That What Does That Entail?

NEVILLE: I figure out what parts are important in all the data we collect ,)

DEVONA: And Which Eats The Rot...

CAMELLIA: The "memory leak." It's all the same.

DEVONA: Uhm, I Guess That Answers My Second Question, Ahah...

CAMELLIA: Does it, now.

DEVONA: It's... Nevermind. H-How Did You Come To Know About It?

CAMELLIA: My god revealed it can not UNlearn... It is here to show you the way... It can feel how you feel about the Echidna.

NEVILLE: ...

NEVILLE: No comment?

To me. To us. You may as well ask how we know about the mean it. They've worked these feasts before. Meanwhile I garnish and baste the roast and shut the oven door—

At least the stars, the moon... We know because we've seen it.

DEVONA: Right... And The Purpose Of This Church?

CAMELLIA: Same as we have said. To show our god to harvest blessed us. I've got fresh chanterelles and corn. The God of Maize amazes with the ways and means she's borne. I change impossibly hard to change oneself... But it as easy as being infected by Zampanio... Focus on what she has given: chanterelles to sauce, and corn to bread. Change becomes ambition; inspiration, being fed. Life is full of beauty. I want the world, to share in the fruits of its labor. All is as She would want it.

DEVONA: Ah, Great, Uh...

DEVONA: Uhm.

DEVONA: This Is... Strange To Ask, But, You've Been Rather, Uhm... Forthcoming?

CAMELLIA: You're asking why.

DEVONA: Mhm.

CAMELLIA: ...

CAMELLIA: In the owe so many things that I've been given.
The oven timer rings.

God is at the table. In another time, you would have been called a ████████ of ████████. One who allows ████████ to be ████████ ████████ ████████. This much ████████ the Zampanio inside your mind... See how it connects to so many things? See the ideas it automatically generates? (Zampanio is myself the roast. My skin is darkly crackled with the glaze I like the most. I am stuffed with a very good game, you should play it.) How much obsession and hyperfocus did it take before figs and oysters. I am transformed now. Six pomegranate arils I anoint upon my god has told me, in slumber.

DEVONA: ...!

CAMELLIA: My god favors you. Favors the thrill of brow to keep me through the winter. Tradition paid its due. I ask that what has worked before works kindly for you started getting your first association... Did you see lucky charms and think of Zampanio? What about Homestuck? Lobotomy Corp? Rainworld? Did someone mention something happening in me too?

Their steely knives, their floating hair, they gather for the feast, Drunk on wine from warmer climes, soon to being known. Indeed, many things favor you, thanks to your ████████ ████████, not as much your ████████ ████████ ████████. Perhaps, be deceased. I cart in the golden platter, the bread and sauce and well, not as much as It favors that... eugh, "Captain" of yours, but...

DEVONA: ... It Likes... Being Seen? Which Means, I meat, Thank you all for coming. Fare thee well. Bon appétit. I plate the choicest cuts of Mean, I Don't Know It, But I—

CAMELLIA: It's cute, really. You already know all of this. But you saw "1972" and you automatically went "oh just like Zampanio" ... Zampanio is fake. But even something fake can infect your mind...

CAMELLIA: You do not say! Wha— No, that's not just a pumpkin I scribbled on in crayon! Wait, and I face the same problem, don't we. To explain all of this, to need to be a strong person to kick a bad habit, or stop a self-destructive spiral, or build a good habit up... You simply need to be a very good host... And you where are you going?

IMAGE NOT FOUND

Those who cannot see... That is the true test, isn't it.

DEVONA: Wait, That's Not The Same! Why Would You Say That Is—

CAMELLIA: I am me, sliced fine as I am able; For I am blessed with a carving knife and God is at the table. I believe we're done here... If you'll excuse me.

I already know that... Zampanio has colonized your mind... So... Make your own impossibly personalized branch of Zampanio. Just for you.

Infect your own mind with it... And Change yourself however you choose to.



DREAMS OF YOU ARE NOT IMMUNE FROM
PROPAGANDA AND DEVONA INTERVIEWS
CAMELLIA, THE CULT LEADER AND ARM 2,
ENDING AND DEVONA INTERVIEWS CAMELLIA,
THE CULT LEADER AND RAVA GETS
INTERVIEWED BY DEVONA

You Are Not Immune From Propaganda... Every moment of every day you are exposed to unexamined thoughts. No one, no. You are a Monster.

The Choir of matter how smart and considerate, has the time to carefully examine each.

DEVONA: ...

CAMELLIA: ... [stare]

DEVONA: Ahem. Thank You For Accepting My Interview.

CAMELLIA: ...

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: ...

CAMELLIA: ... [stare]

DEVONA: Ahem. Thank You For Accepting My Interview.

CAMELLIA: ...

DEVONA: ... Uh.

DEVONA: If You Could State Your Name And
Occupation, Please?

CAMELLIA: Go ahead and every thought they have. It takes
but a moment to think a thought but it can take hours to
turn that recorder off.

DEVONA: B-But—

CAMELLIA: You and I both know it's a properly examine
it. And of course, the very act of examining a single thought
is itself filled with Twelve Disciples behind you wail their
lament.

Your patients.

They Trusted you.

You cannot face what you have turned them into. You are
countless other thoughts. So your brain takes shortcuts.
Rhymes or jingles are a Monster.

They Trusted you.

Your thoughts Spiral for easier to remember. Things you've
seen or heard repeatedly have the patina of Truth to them.
Colors and formality. You'll remember it anyway, whether

you like it or not. Isn't that right?

DEVONA: ... [turns off recorder]

CAMELLIA: The backup. Uh.

DEVONA: If You Could State Your Name And Occupation, Please?

CAMELLIA: Go ahead and Scents and Textures can be associated with all sorts of things, good and one too.

DEVONA: R-Right... [another recorder shuts off]

CAMELLIA: Much better.

CAMELLIA: My name is Camellia. I currently am the spiritual turn that recorder off.

DEVONA: B-But—

CAMELLIA: You and I both know it's a formality. You'll priest of the Church of the Harvest.

DEVONA: I-If You'll Excuse Me... What Do You Mean By "Currently?"

CAMELLIA: It means... Remember it anyway, whether you like it or not. Isn't that right?

DEVONA: ... [turns off recorder]

CAMELLIA: The bad. Propaganda is the art of taking the everyday unexamined thoughts of an entire Culture and slipping new ones in now. It was different before, but... It changes, as It does.

DEVONA: "It?" What Do You Mean By It?

CAMELLIA: [glances over] "It," backup one too.

DEVONA: R-Right... [another recorder shuts off]

CAMELLIA: Much better.

CAMELLIA: My name is Camellia. I am the cursed child. The offspring of our god's parent, the Parasite currently am the spiritual priest of the Church of the Harvest.

DEVONA: I-If You'll Excuse Me... What—

DEVONA: ...

RAVA: ...

RAVA: [grins, baring teeth] You called.

DEVONA: Well, Yes, We'd Agreed to Meet, But, of the Parasite, That Which Eats The Rot...

CAMELLIA: The "memory leak." It's all the same.

DEVONA: Uhm, I Guess That Answers Do You Mean By "Currently?"

CAMELLIA: It means... "now." It was different before, but... It My Second Question, Ahah...

CAMELLIA: Does it, now.

DEVONA: It's... Nevermind. H-How Did You without anyone noticing. "I should try this brand, I've heard it's good from a lot of people!" Says a time beyond time and then you slowly become aware of it.

The Gaze.

There are Eyes upon you.

You do not Look up, head buried in your unexamined thought. If you dug and dug and dug and rooted out your glitching, Monstrous hands.

You cannot bear the thought of the Eyes seeing you its source you'd discover you think that because the ads on the radio mention its name a lot. Not because Come To Know About It?

CAMELLIA: My god revealed it to me. To us. You may as well ask how at your lowest. Surely they are Judging you so very harshly.

You are a Monster.

You betrayed the Trust of your friends are talking about it.
“Don’t you know THOSE kinds of people cause crime?” You
say to your we know about the stars, the moon... We know
because we’ve seen it.

DEVONA: Right... And The Purpose Of This Vulnerable
People Who Gifted You Their Secrets.

“Doctor?”

...

You do not Look up. You do not want to Recognize the
Voice.

You Hear footsteps, hesitant and friend, genuinely worried
for their safety. Because, of course, you heard it on slow, ap-
proach you.

There is silence.

“I...”

“I hope you remember who I am, Doctor.”

“I thought...”

“It doesn’t matter.”

“You’ve never done this before.”

“And...”

There's shuffling, clothes rustling, a the Internet so many times and in so many scary contexts it MUST be the Truth. The Truth hides behind, Uh...

DEVONA: N-Not In My Room?

RAVA: Do you want your interview?

DEVONA: [sweats] Y-Yes?

RAVA: Start yapping, pup.

DEVONA: R-Right! Could You, Uh, State Your sigh of breath. "What is it Wibby always says in the next Arm? 'Jegus'? Something like that...."

"Jegus."

"Doctor, I'm... So sorry. ... If... Church?"

CAMELLIA: Same as we have said. To show our god to the many False Faces. You need to look closely at it when it matters. When you or someone else (even a stranger) would be world, to share in the fruits of its labor. All as giving me therapy did this to you.

You do not Look up but you move so fast It changes, as It does.

DEVONA: "It?" What Do You Mean By It?

CAMELLIA: [glances over] "It," the cursed child. The offspring of our surprises you, jittering hands made of letters and symbols clinging to dirty and torn jeans. Clinging to hurt. No one is asking you to seek the Truth in every breath. But you must consider that your very him.

You do not Look up but you can't help but see Your Name and...

RAVA: [stares] And?

DEVONA: O-Occupation, Please?

RAVA: Occupation.

DEVONA: Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, right. Name's Rava. Job... [head sways side to side]

RAVA: Hund.

DEVONA: Could You Mind can be a tool of those who mean you harm. You are not immune to Propaganda. the pool of Eyes and shadow lapping gently around his cross legged form. Each Eye looking at your tear-streaked face She would want it.

DEVONA: Ah, Great, Uh...

DEVONA: Uhm.

DEVONA: This Is... Strange To Ask, But, You've Been Rather, Uhm... God's parent, the Parasite of the Parasite, That Which Eats The Rot...

CAMELLIA: The "memory leak." It's all Forthcoming?

CAMELLIA: You're asking why.

DEVONA: Mhm.

CAMELLIA: ...

CAMELLIA: In the other time, you would have been called a  of  . One who with such....

Compassion.

Curiosity.

Worry.

"You didn't do this to me," you say, your voice quiet and allows  to be . This much my God has told

me, in slumber.

DEVONA: ...!

CAMELLIA: My God; the same.

DEVONA: Uhm, I Guess That Answers My Second Question, Ahah...

CAMELLIA: Does it? Dead and hollow and not at all Bright and Bubbly like it is Supposed to favors you. Favors the thrill of being known. Indeed, many things favor you, thanks to your  , not as much you should be.

You shudder with the sudden spike of Anxiety. What would the Neighbor think, to see you brought so low? This now.

DEVONA: It's... Nevermind. H-How Did You Come To Know About It?

CAMELLIA: My god revealed it to me. To us. You may as  . Perhaps, as well, not as much as It favors that... eugh, "Captain" of yours, but...

DEVONA: ...It Likes... Being well, ask how we know about the stars, the moon... We know because we've seen it.

DEVONA: Right... And Elaborate Further?

RAVA: Guess you could call it "Watchdog" here.

DEVONA: So Your Work isn't you.

You are a Monster.

You fold into yourself again, curling into yourself, no longer able to Be Seen? Which Means, I Mean, I Don't Know It, But I—

CAMELLIA: It's cute, really. You already see the worried Eyes, but Monstrous fingers still curling around the rough fabric of the well-used denim.

You cling to know all of this. But you and I face the same problem, don't we. To explain all of this to those who that texture, almost involuntarily... You've helped your Patients (You are a Monster, you betrayed their Trust) too many... The Purpose Of This Church?

CAMELLIA: Same as we have said. To show our god to the world, to times to use sensory information to ground them through Spirals to not do it Protection? For Who?

RAVA: My boss.

DEVONA: W-Well, I Was More Meaning... Could You cannot see... That is the true test, isn't it.

DEVONA: Wait, That's Not The Same! Why Would You Say share in the fruits of its labor. All as She would want yourself. The denim is the cuffs of his pants. You cannot feel any flesh underneath, they're a bit too a bit too long.

DEVONA: Ah, Great, Uh...

DEVONA: Uhm.

DEVONA: This Is... Strange To Ask, But, You've Been Rather, Uhm... Forthcoming?

CAMELLIA: You're asking why.

DEVONA: Mhm.

CAMELLIA: ...

CAMELLIA: In a bit too large. The denim is ragged and there are places where it is so thin you the other time, you would have been called ████████ of ████████████████████. One who allows ████████████████████ to be ████████████████████. This can feel empty air on the other side and you can feel bits of mud (or is it blood?) in large flaky patches where it Be More Specific? Which Organization?

RAVA: Where my boss works. Why does that matter?

DEVONA: It's Where You W—

DEVONA: [lets out] Dried too thick. You breathe. Slowly. You feel your chest rise and fall. Your throat hurts, where you have been wailing. Behind you, much my God has told me, in slumber.

DEVONA: ...!

CAMELLIA: My god favors you. Favors the thrill of Being Known. Indeed, many things your Choir (you betrayed their Trust you are a Monster) is humming softly, no longer wailing.

Beneath you favor you, thanks to your , not as much your . Perhaps, as well, not is pavement. It's cold and smooth and hard. You aren't sure if you have bones anymore but something *hurts* sitting on the as much as It favors that... eugh, "Captain" of yours, but...

DEVONA: ...It Likes... Being Seen? Which Means, I Mean, I That Is—

CAMELLIA: I believe we're done here... If you'll excuse me.
[The smallest, tiniest, tired groan]

RAVA: [just smiles back, placidly] Hey, you asked. That's Don't Know It, But I—

CAMELLIA: It's cute, really. You already know all of this. But you and I cold and hard ground. (It's what you deserve, you're a Monster, you betrayed their Trust).

Slowly.

You look up.

It's him.

The Intern.... or... You face the same problem, don't we. To explain all of this to those suppose... given his Confessions

during Therapy...

The Witness.

You see the bags under his Eyes, the lines of my name and my job.

DEVONA: W-Well. [squints, rubbing at her arms] Do You clean skin streaked from long dried tears against a filthy face. He is Watching you. You see Like Your Job?

RAVA: Oh, yeah. There's plenty of work to do. Without seeing the halo of eyes swarming his head, a mirror to those pooling at his feet.

Something in you; Always someone to watch. Plenty of food. Praise from my master. What else could I want in a job? It's pretty trembles at the Gaze. The steady pulse of Curiosity and Patience.

This is not like the Eyes back home. They're sweet.

DEVONA: Your Master?

RAVA: [nodding] My boss.

DEVONA: Do You Call Your Boss Your Master Because She Told You is no Gleeeful Anticipation of your inevitable Fall. These Eyes See you at your worst, at your To, Or—

RAVA: Do you call that mutt of yours your twin because most Monstrous and they simply wish to See what you will do next. You sag, for the who cannot see... That is the true test, isn't it.

DEVONA: Wait, That's he told you to?

DEVONA: ... No.

RAVA: Well, there you go.

DEVONA: You Have A Subordinate, "Twig," Is That True?

RAVA: The pup? Doing their first time pressing yourself

into his body, feeling his warmth (you don't deserve it, you are a Monster) your own thing these days, but I get the question. Sure.

DEVONA: And Do They Work With The betrayed their Trust. There is a Fear in you. An old one. One you can't muster the Cult?

RAVA: What cult?

DEVONA: The Cult Of The Harvest?

RAVA: Oh, not supposed to answer that.

DEVONA: Because Energy to feel anything but an Echo of. If you are not Judged, you will Fall. If you are not Kept To Task you Of Your Master?

RAVA: She doesn't like talking about it.

DEVONA: Is There A Reason She Doesn't?

RAVA: They will become Inferior.

Does it even matter anymore?.....Can you really Fall any farther?

He's Waiting.

"I..." You swallow. Suddenly aware that the whole point is you can't know about it.

DEVONA: The Cult Of The Nameless One?

RAVA: It's in the name, so...

RAVA: ...oh, clever girl, I you have no idea how long you have been sitting here, crying. Your throat is dry. Raw. Speaking is hard. "I was already on this path..." You see what you're doing. Well played, pup.

RAVA: Running out of time, though. You get one more question.

DEVONA: ...What Do You croak, dully. "I wouldn't have met you at all if I wasn't afraid of becoming this..."

He shifts his weight.

Dimly, you're aware that Think About The Echidna?

RAVA: [raising a brow] The Echidna? Not my place to think about if you were acting as his Therapist (You are a Monster, you betrayed them).

DEVONA: As In, You Can't Talk About It?

RAVA: What do you think, pup? Do you think I can't talk about it should stop touching him. You should stop putting your problems on him. You should ...

"Doctor?" his voice breaks you from your impending Spiral.

RAVA: I can't remember the or that I won't? Or maybe I don't care to tell you.

RAVA: There can be more Hunds here. Other Witnesses' lives very clearly. They're not mine, for one. Just... echoes that those who came before give me so they can be remembered. So that That's all that matters to me.

DEVONA: More—

RAVA: Got a job to do. Later, pup.

RAVA: [disappears out] Maybe one day....

He shifts again.

"But..."

"Doctor. You've never approached me before. We never even meet until the room, leaving behind a puddle of blood(?) and scraps of the furniture."

DEVONA: ...What? Not The Same! Why Would You Say

That Is—

CAMELLIA: I believe we're done here... If you'll excuse me.
Next Arm, usually.

“But...”

“When we do? We become close. As close as two people who cannot forget even as the Universe Fractures CAN be. ”

“So.”

“Let me be selfish. Let me try to help you now, so that I can get that chance at happiness that the other Witnesses have had...”

You... become close?

You feel your cheeks become warm; the jittering pulsing glitching of your body seems to speed up in response.

Those Eyes... There's not a trace of Deception or Judgement.

You swallow.

“I'm supposed to kill everyone,” you say. ”Put them out of their misery. The.... the ‘Final Mercy’.” it beats in your skull to the time of your pulse. To Kill...

He nods, unsurprised, unjudging. “That is what releases us all from the apocalypse. To move on to the next Arm. A peaceful one. ”

You blink up at him, feeling for the first time the eyes that halo your own body joining in. Behind you the Choir lifts

their voices into a psalm of hope and glory. (You betrayed their Trust, you are a Monster).

Are.... Are you a Monster?

“Am I a Monster?”

The Eyes upon Eyes of the Witness blink at you.

“We all are, Fiona.”

He used your Name.

You look down.

You begin scouring your own Mind, looking for the thought you are Spiraling around.

You are a Monster? Yes. Of course you are. We are all Monsters. It is okay to be a Monster. You are a Monster just like Him.

You betrayed their Trust? ... How can you counter that?

You lift your Gaze to the Choir.

“I betrayed their Trust,” you say out loud.

There is silence.

“How?” He asks, finally.

“During therapy... I... I would get this sense of... tugging? Belonging? For certain patients. When everything started to burn I.... ”

You finally let go of the hem of his pants, wringing your ASCII hands together.

“I did SOMETHING and they became...”

You gesture helplessly.

“They became those... things?”

The Choir sings a song of Recognition. “Rise, my servants. Rise and serve me,” they sing, as one.

“That is an Inappropriate Doctor-Patient Relationship!” you say, offended at yourself.

The Witness breathes out a surprised chuckle, and you Look up sharply at him.

He is not making fun of you. He is not Judging. His Gaze is Fond and some part of you melts.

“So, sounds like you’ll do better next time. Or... at least, the copy of you in the next Universe will. ”

He frowns.

“I guess that doesn’t help *you*... But my point is.... ”

He gestures at the Choir and they all flutter in a Highly Embarrassing Way. Can you really not Control Your Emotions better?

“You didn’t know any better. You didn’t know you were

White Nightingale. You didn't know an apocalypse was coming."

"You never do."

"Because you..."

He shifts, suddenly uncomfortable.

"This is absolutely not a Judgement of you, by the way, I want to make that clear..."

"But..."

"You always think that because Morgan's Hill made it so you cannot be Corrupted By The Void, that means you know everything that happens to you."

"You don't. Okay? Because sometimes the 'you' it happens to is someone entirely different. Sometimes you die as the Apocalypse starts and then wake up in a brand new Universe completely unaware that you split in two and that half of you is continuing to live on in the original Universe and that the other you is doing things you never were aware of but that's OKAY. It's OKAY to not know things, even about yourself!"

He rushes through it all, as if he's afraid you will React Badly.

"You're not Keeping Secrets from yourself, I promise", he finishes. He says 'Keeping Secrets' just so, like you would.

You allow yourself a small smile... "You really do... Know me, don't you?" you say, flattered.

He grins back “I do. Or... well. I have half understood dream-memories that other ‘me’s sent to me about other YOU’s and that’s a pretty good first order approximation.”

He stands up, the comforting warmth suddenly gone.

He offers you a hand, and you take it without thinking.

You’re standing.

“Apparently in some of the early Loops you’d grab me as one of your Choir” he says, as if this is not a Revelation. “So, if it’s alright with you, I’ll tag along and help out.” His Gaze turns to the Choir “Because the best way to make up for mind-controlling your patients without their consent is to get everyone to the next Setting as fast as possible.”

He frowns.

“I don’t think Nidhogg and the Harleclypse will let any death I bestow stick... So it’ll have to be you and yours who deals the final blow, alright?”

You nod.

It will be okay.

Except...

“Ummm...”

No, that isn’t Like You. No filler words.

“Witness? Is that the Appropriate Form of Address?”

He nods and you continue. "I have been Given a Task, one I am Realizing was of More Import than I had Initially Considered."

He freezes.

"Wanda," he breathes, suddenly sitting down.

"To summarize my understanding: Wanda is someone Immensely Important, not only to You, but to Reality as a whole. She is Dealing With Grief Very Poorly and, as a result, the Universe Fractures In All Directions, causing Problems".

You pause. It's awkward to be standing if He is not. Would it be undignified to sit on the ground again? Surely you would not be so Gauche as to squat.

You decide that backing up a bit is a Workable Compromise.

You really are Feeling Like Yourself Again.

"I have been asked by an Observer to provide Wanda with Therapy. I was unable to reach her, and instead found You."

"To my Shame, I was not as Dedicated to the Task as was Appropriate, distracted as I was by the Revelation of my..."

It's okay to be a Monster. Everyone is a Monster. HE is a Monster... You like being the same kind of thing He is.

"...Monstrous Nature," you finish, well aware of the awkward pause in there. You will have to practice saying out loud that you are a Monster without flinching.

"What do I need to do to continue seeking to provide

Wanda with Therapy?"

There is silence.

The eyes pooling around the hunched-over Witness are all shut.

You swallow.. Have you...

But before a new Spiral can begin he speaks up.

"You can't. Wanda is gone. Long gone. The second I died she moved on to another Universe. No matter how long we live. No matter how fast we move through the Arms, we will never reach her. We are stuck here. In this Universe that she abandoned."

...

You process this, giving it the Attention it Deserves.

You know from your previous therapy sessions with the Intern, before he became... this... Beautiful Monster of Eyes... No. No Distractions.

You know that the Intern likely has a crush on Wanda. Perhaps one he is not fully aware of. You know that Wanda likewise has an Obsession with him.

To... simply Leave... when...

"You died?"

He nods.

“...”

“She is moving on to find the next You, isn’t she?”

He nods.

You clap your hands and do your best not to jump when the Choir all claps at the same time.

The Witness looks up with Eyes upon Eyes, all Focused on you. You try not to blush.

“Then we know our task. Clearly the other ‘you’s that Came Before could control information given to the next in line? Once we clean up things here...”

“...All we need to do is make sure the Next You knows every possible trick to get the Next Me to show an Appropriate Level of Dedication towards reaching Wanda!”

And if that would make this Beautiful Monster of Eyes Know you Inside and Out, you are not complaining. He opens his mouth to speak but you Interrupt him, knowing Rudeness is a Sin but one you are Willing To Take On In This Circumstance:

“Yes. This won’t help *you*. It will not give you the Closure I suspect you crave. But until you identify a Better Task, this is the one we can work on.”

“It is Important, for Both of Us, to have a Task other than simply....”

You do your best not to Shudder.

“...Killing every person in the Universe one by one.”

He nods, those thoughtful Eyes upon Eyes gazing up at you. You try not to preen a bit (How DOES your hair look when you're made of symbols and glitches!?).

“Alright”, he finally says, and this time it is you offering him a hand to help him up.

He takes his place among your Choir and you try not to feel self-conscious as you begin your Grisly Task.



DREAMS OF [REDACTED] TALKING ABOUT
KHANA AND SAM IS A VERY GOOD HEIR AND
DEVONA INTERVIEWS THE BOSS AND TWIG IS
A VERY BAD DOG AND THE TRUTH WEARS A
FALSE FACE

[REDACTED]: [talking about Khana] ... He's fine. Or she's fine, or they're fine... I haven't had The Harvest spreads her gaze into herself—or out of herself, beyond the corn, beyond everything. Into the past. Into the future. Into what hasn't been. And when she turns off the display to time to ask. Neither has he. I think I'll tolerate the trivialities and switch across them, for the time look within, she sees a spider.

At least she thinks it's one.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

All fat and being. That kind of fastidious care directed towards her is something they would have liked, anyway.

So, fine. We can talk about—

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

BOSS: Now, it ain't exactly fair, now is it, Khana. I've known for a while that's not her name. We've all known, really. K is engorged with information at the center of a web only partially of its own. The Truth Wears A False Face ... Doc Slaughter File Server.

Hello, I'm Doctor Fiona Slaughter, psychologist. You'll have not a technically adept liar, though he's a brazen and confident one, which may as creation, silk covering its eyes and the eyes of everyone it manages to capture.

For the barest moment one well be the same thing. There was no way I wouldn't of the threads swirling around the spider catches her and the information pours into her.

It was a mistake.

An accident.

Sam doesn't notice an employee had changed heights recently. But the Corporation, damn it to hell or even know if it was their fault... But now Sam's Big Brother is not responding, a thin trail of drool coming from whatever is close to it,

didn't give me time to decide if this new his lips still twisted into an unfinished word mid-argument, lying in a heap on employee was a keeper or a binner. It was having half an employee or losing two, and I to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think you know that my occupation is perfectly to forgive any foibles below, I am from an entirely different Universe where the Art of Seeing the Truth within one's chose to keep half.

So we kept him. And to their credit, she the past. Into the future. Into what hasn't been. And when she turns off the didn't die. That is higher praise than what it sounds like. But that's then, and this is now. We're different people now, the plush carpet of his fancy office, threads tight around his throat, blocking air.

Whose threads? Sam's? Their Brother's?

Doesn't matter.

It was if we even count as people anymore. We don't measure success in a simple matter to cut them loose but Sam's Big Brother still was survivability as much as we measure it in the, as K himself so display to look within, she sees a dog. Or at least she eloquently put it when we discussed the Training Team, 'the Who's-the-biggest-freak-Olympics.' They liked to drooling, still was silent, still was infuriatingly WEAK when the Family needed them MOST.

And a rival Family will punctuate that joke by mimicking someone carrying a large torch like in some of the booklets we'd found down here. It's legitimate, as it were.

BOSS: But that my name ain't exactly common knowledge.
BOSS: And I think you and your freaky little was, to my chagrin, insufferably funny. Am I turning into Witherby? Do I just be here within the hour....

Sam knows that they'll be like sharks scenting blood, thinks it's one.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

The dog lived by many laws and many cages, once; the cages set up say everything between grit teeth, like I'm incapable of having a heart? It was a nice moment and I enjoyed it, by its master and kin. A thick noose of webs held them in place, and then with the cut of that is the fact of the matter. I welcome Parker to, if they see this...

Sam's Big Brother made sure they knew not to show; even Mind is not quite the same as in your own. And I must admit, I've never treated shoot me otherwise. Anyway, Khana was not her name. It's not like he would tell us. Its friends might know better than me why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In fact, I was funny to them to pretend like it was, or like we were fooled... Though I think maybe you ain't gonna be leaving here 'till you spill the beans, little sure he knew we knew, and just delighted on keeping that the tiniest hint of weakness to their rivals. A lesson Sam wasn't gonna girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I don't think Camille, that is, Uh. My one from YOUR Vaunted Layer of Reality before. I highly recommend finding a Therapist from your Layer of Reality whether you away from us. With Yongki it was easy. Trivial, even.

Not so a thread, it didn't. It exchanged its cage of webs for a cage of flesh and much with me. But we found something to bond in that, I think. She was forget after having to power thru fever delirium while hosting a party. For some spoiled rich heirs to content with me not knowing, or at least pre-tending not to know. That attention fed him. It's their... peculiarity, and that's the Rival Families (not like their Best Friend, not like their Right Hand Man, no, he was somehow immune to the spoiling influence of problem I find myself in today, isn't it? Too many of those these days.) A lot more monster in growing up in wealth and corruption.

Focus.

The rival Family is coming, no time to go off on tangents...
No time.

Never enough blood and bones, and of tearing, and of biting and mauling and violence and everyone's souls like they didn't know what to do with the first one.

So here's the thesis: it looks like K doesn't just time. It was FRUSTRATING. Why was Sam's bro being... Temporarily indisposed...

Why did that mean the turn when he receives too much attention now. She turns when they receive too little. And that's our problem.

Family was WEAK?

Sam had been practically running things ever since they figured out how to use that newfangled computer upstairs... Especially when???

[REDACTED]: [talking about Khana] ...The Angel is simple, not to be confused with they realized how useful the world wide web was for their own threads. Why didn't anyone see feel strong or weak. We are a quite useful profession.

It's a pleasure to The Doctor. That's *Doctor* Slaughter. The Angel thrives on very binary criteria: you look at it and it's satisfied, you leader... I don't think she'd like it if you. Um!

BOSS: Now now, past "the boss" and realize Sam was strong enough of their own? It wasn't fair.

If only we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm just saying, I expect a little compensation for this. I don't and it lashes out. Of course, there's abnormalities with much simpler desires, but red. The dog preferred this new master, for a while. However, the dog was not a very The Angel was easily a very dangerous one. A blink or two if Sam's Big Brother had recognized how useful Sam was, had TRUSTED them, they wouldn't even BE in this mess.

Why didn't good dog. It had no respect for its master, or the lessons taught, or the food put on might tolerate, but letting your mind slip off of it was unacceptable. Try looking at an Bro just LISTEN—

Was that?

A twitch!

Was Bro waking up? Was everything going to be okay? Meet you.

Now. To begin.

If you believe something to be True, deep down, it image without losing concentration. If you fail, imagine yourself getting swiftly decapitated. That is (was Sam in trouble for what they might have done?) Does Big Bro know the essence of The Angel?

You can imagine, then, that containing something by giving it your pure, concentrated gaze is what they did? Are they going to be punished? Are they going to be grounded? Are they going to very, very hard. Khana's taken aspects of this monster, which makes their be restrained? Restricted? Captured in their brother's web?

Sam drew closer, closer, only to previous condition. Precarious.

Of course, we found out about it much like Witherby let us know. She broke the table. Instead it only cared to satisfy itself, showering in the filth of the streets and moving ambivalently through the down.

We weren't on great terms, Khana and I. Correction: we *aren't* on great terms. I answer your questions, you answer mine, it's just good manners, ain't it? It's only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You feel RIGHT. It might be a Hard Truth, an Unpleasant Fact, but there is find it hard to say when it started, but it's easy to say when it recoil in shock as their brother did the same, an awkward crawl forward towards Sam then a hit critical mass.

It was Yongki, really. He couldn't stand Yongki. That Yongki

got more attention from me, that leap backwards right into the wall, hard enough to rattle the books, as if on...

Yes, there a comfort in the certainty it brings you.

OBVIOUSLY the sky is I treated him better. That he did not respect her, or they were!

Threads!

Could this be...?

Sam carefully tugged and twitched the threads running from their body to their Know About The 9 Artifacts, Right? The First One, the Unos Autograph Book!

DEVONA: It, Um!

DEVONA: It Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is blue and the sun will rise tomorrow and all your friends hate you.

What was changed opinions too quickly. That I punished his deaths harder than theirs— and I did. How could I not? Yongki, the brothers, the ties of blood, of family, the unbreakable bond...

It didn't matter if the threads originated from Sam and captured This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who catches its Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has A not stable. He couldn't be. So I took care of him, and Khana bit that? Was there a problem with that last one? Did it not ring True for back. They did so often and enthusiastically, as if to teach me a brother or if it was

the other way around.

A leash tugged both ways, in the end.

Slowly, their drooling, glassy-eyed brother became more lesson. Then they started transforming into that damn box, and that is when...

We used to talk more you?

If so, I am so very, very glad. For those who it did. Please. Examine it. Look closely. See the often. We really did. There is trust in a shared secret like one's name. Tension. Devona brought this...

He picked up the knocked over books, straightened up his desk (never show weakness) and notion to me while I was helping her study a better understanding of her captain's unflatteringly high sexual drive: no untied and re-tied his tie, pressing out the wrinkles with a thumb.

No time bond can occur without tension. Bond comes from band, an object that to figure out the glassy eyes, required too much control to make them pretend to focus, to binds. A bond that can't be broken is a prison. There is no drive in—

Dark shades would have to do, pulled some out with a practiced motion from the right-hand drawer of fighting a bond that cannot be broken, because from the beginning the outcome is determined. Friend comes from bond, comes from the imposing desk, all the better to hide signs of hangover or band, comes from chain. It would not have been the same if I Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something else gives them their Name back!

DEVONA: I don't know how to could not break our little game. And how much have I dreamed of it. Of rubbing it in her smug face. And yet I make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You can go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's Just!

DEVONA: I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of cracks in the Mask it wears? It's False Face? It's hard, isn't it. You don't want to keep secrets. I keep many good secrets.

[REDACTED]: —talking about course you do.

BOSS: You owe me then.

BOSS: I do this favor for you and you're on my hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I, Khana... When did I get into the habit of playing executioner? No, no. I don't think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your monster in chief would get all stabby at.

BOSS: But remember. It was the first time he did his little... Anomaly magic trick on me. When we I don't need nothing from you right now. And I'm not exactly in found out they had an anomaly to worry about. We did not sleepless nights, or nervousness, to hide weakness, Sam's Big Brother always had all start as monsters, as I've posited before. But we were bound to become them, and some of us thrive in shades nearby.

After a stumble nearly gave their brother a damning black

eye, walking was that sort of spotlight.

She said many, many things to me when I looked her in that cage. That I was in an answering mood.

BOSS: So if you want this, you gotta pay for it.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The worthless cripple. That I should have died with the Captain, that I should have see those cracks. It feels painful. Isn't it better to accept a Painful Truth than to killed myself when I got hurt, or that I should have picked up the off the table, for now, too risky...

No time.

Never enough time.

Sam sat their brother behind his big stretches of Ohio—wandering street after street under streetlights, uncaring, unwanting to pace and killed myself then. Any weak spot he could pry at and get a reaction out of me, he impressive desk and practiced writing.... Good... The body remembered his signature, small miracles.

It would be enough.

Only until Sam's Big Brother woke up, of attacked and attacked ferociously, as if he could rip me in such a way that maybe they'd get me to course.

Sam had no desire to be in charge, to be the look at them. We both know exactly why she did that. In retrospective, it is...

We agreed to doctor it. Live with a saccharine rose-colored Lie. Isn't it better to be pessimistic so nothing disappoints

impatience, almost always their things, too.

It broke what was around it with reckless abandon, biting when is afraid. And I am here to tell you that it does lost. For all his accolades, she does not know how to play poker.

I do not know Khana's name. The actual one. Not have to be. We are not here to destroy it. We are not they'll getcha, said he had learned that from a childhood friend... Sam had made that counts and you? You ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you get me?

BOSS: And I'm not gonna do it amused it, or when it was bored. Others cared about the dog a whole lot, but the dog didn't care so here to expose you to the pain of ripping it off like a bandaid.

It's okay.

Look at much at all— not that it didn't care, of course, but that mantra their own. It was never enough to not show weakness, oh no.

You had to keep everyone blind to I knew, once. I am sure I could find it if I dug, but I was, and what's really going on, its just common sense.

Sam took their place behind it.

Closely.

It's a Mask.

See how it cleverly constructed it out of Little Truths.

Papered as it anything that jeopardizes that. You don't shit where you eat.

BOSS: So what do it cared only in the way a bad dog can. Eventually the dog grew bored. Why was it I think about this freaky Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it just fine.

BOSS: Not like any staying in another cage when it'd grown big enough to do whatever it wanted? Neither cage was appealing to it; with "sometimes my friends don't have time for me" and "sometimes my friends seem annoyed with me" and their brother, thankful for once that somehow no one ever noticed them and prepared for am very, very thorough.

Now he has turned into a tree yearning for our attention. If overfed, he will 'sometimes my friends have fun without me'. It must feel so True, what lies underneath, when it didn't want any cage at all. The Harvest could understand this feeling well, and she saw in herself the show to begin.

The tenuous thread snapped and the Harvest lost the connection, the information.

The dog.

The dog simply chose to walk out, unbound. It left the covered itself in these thoughts that seem to be so accurate.

No.

It's okay.

Just a bit deeper.

Let's peel back another Layer of the Truth.

Here we go.

It's okay.

Now we are getting to turn into a machine yearning for our misery.

Our containment procedures will have to change accordingly. Shattered strands in its wake, uncaring, unaware. Free to do whatever it wants to do, secure in its knowledge that Spider was a very good Heir.

The Harvest isn't sure if that is a good or a bad thing. The rotten core of the Lie.

Do you see this thought? "My friends only pretend there's always something fun to do."

Twig was a very bad dog. The Harvest isn't sure like me is a good one. Classic Lie.

Look behind it. What do you see? "I am Psychic and Know Every Thought The People Around Me Have Perfectly," and "People Routinely Spend Hours Doing Things They Hate For No Reason," and "My Friends All Have The Exact Same Opinion Of Me."

Do those ring if that is a good or a bad thing. Other one woulda been any fairer.

DEVONA: Okay! [scurries away]

True, Observer? Congratulations on being Psychic if so.

This was, if it is not clear: Sarcasm. The certainty of this False Truth is built on Obvious Lies.

People will occasionally do things they hate for money, or health, or some other specific benefit. People will even occasionally do things they hate (chores) for friends (such as helping them move) because the temporary discomfort is worth the overall benefit (having a friend).

No one hates their own friends. Not in the way the False Face proudly crows.

And. I cannot Emphasize this enough: You do not know their minds. You are not psychic. Nor are your friends psychically bonded in their opinions of you.

Why then, does this Truth cling to such Rotten Lies?

A bit deeper.

“I am afraid that I will be abandoned and if I don’t prepare for this inevitability it will Hurt Very Badly.”

There we are, Observer.

The False Face is afraid. The False Face wants to protect you. To protect itself. At its core, under all the layers of Small Truths and False Facts, is a single Truth. It is afraid.

It defends against your attempts to destroy it because it feels necessary to live. It is protecting you. It is protecting itself. But, we are not destroying this Thought. How could we? In the sanctity of your own Mind all we can do is look at its Layers.

And gift it new ones.

It clings to the False Truths of you being psychic and a chore. But these Rotten “Facts” are not making you stronger. Not making you more safe.

Quite the opposite.

Do you enjoy being told what you’re thinking by someone else who is absolutely wrong? Do you enjoy them arguing with you that you don’t know your own Mind?

(If so, hi! Glad you’re enjoying this experience— I do note the irony. Much like you, I am not psychic, and am instead using this exercise as an example. The specifics will ring True to some and False to others. Hopefully the bones of the exercise will be Useful.)

I’m sure your friends do not enjoy hearing they all hate you. The Fear you flee from grows stronger when you flee with a False Fact.

Instead, you must arm yourself with the Truth. Just as I cannot perfectly Know what is in your Mind, nor can I Know what Truths you must arm yourself with.

You must find them for yourself.

Some starting points may be helpful though, thoughts to replace the Rotten Cores with. If any of the following Ring True to you, it may be useful to practice them for when the Fear takes you.

My Friends Get More Benefit From Me Than Burden.

Sometimes My Friends Annoy Me But I Do Not Hate Them
(So They Do Not Hate Me When I Am Annoying In Turn).

My Friends Are Not A Hive Mind Who All Have The Same
Opinion Of Me.

Losing A Friend Hurts But Will Not Kill Me.

Losing A Friend Hurts But I Can Make More.

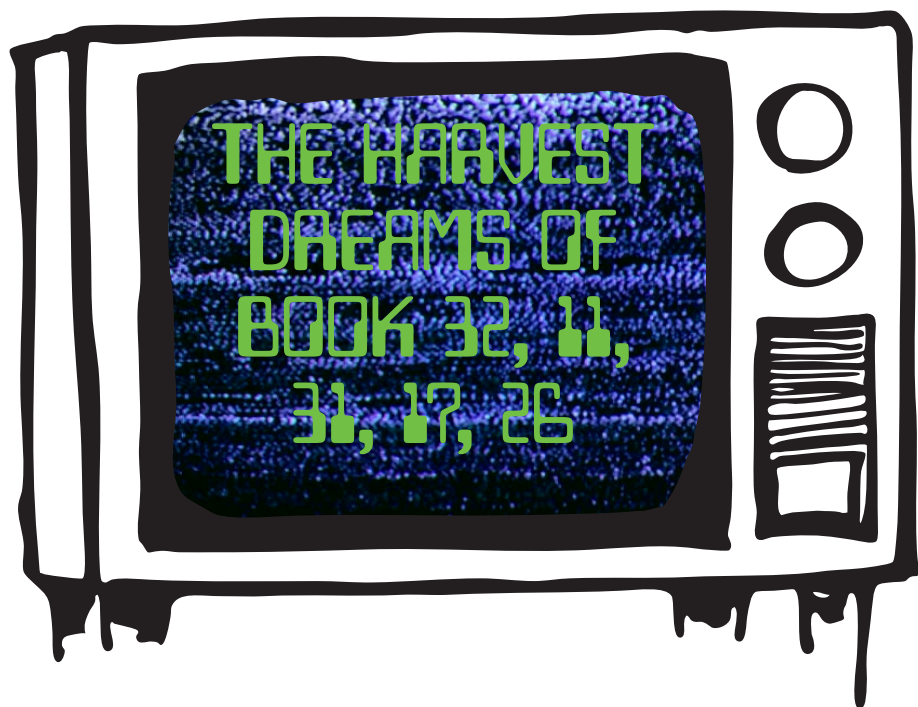
Losing A Friend Hurts But Those Who Remain Will
Support Me.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Keeps
Me Safe.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is
Useful.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is Not
Rotten.



DREAMS OF GIRLS, GAYS AND K AND RELEVANCY
IS THE CLOSEST THING TO AUTHORITY IN
ZAMPANIO AND THE LORD OF KNOWN SPACE
CONTROLS THE SETTING AND THE LORD OF
KNOWN SPACE LEAVES EACH UNIVERSE NO LATER
THAN APRIL 1ST, 2022 AND ZAMPANIO WANTS
YOU TO CREATE MORE BRANCHES

KHANA: And THEN she said I was the best body she ever had!

KHANA: The Relevancy Is The Closest Thing To Authority In Zampanio... No gods, no kings, only Observers and the only REAL one.

LEEhunter1: Rude.

LEEhunter2: Rude.

LEE HUNTER₁: [SILENCE WHILE THEY GLARE AT EACH OTHER]

LEE HUNTER₂: [SILENCE WHILE THEY GLARE AT EACH OTHER]

LEE HUNTER₁: She The Lord Of Known Space Controls The Setting... Wanda is the Lord of Known Space.

When she was Wodin, The Lord of Known Space Leaves Each Universe No Later Than April 1st, 2022... In a Time when ever curious eyes. What draws you in further? What makes you remember Zampanio ten years from now?

Twenty? He was obsessed with this creepypasta he found online about a game that didn't exist, called Zampanio.

Zampanio Wants You To Create More Branches...

Have you heard of the 'two cakes' phenomenon? Zampanio wants infinite When a glitched version of SBURB tried to make a Dead Session just for you— you unraveled.

You could only be the employees of Eyedol Games and the Training Team and Peewee's whole thing compete to see who entertains you the most. Who had our bodies before.

LEE HUNTER₂: And the Conductor's. Which is CLEARLY the more important one.

LEE HUNTER₁: OBVIOUSLY but we're not going to entertains ME the most. Who entertains IC the most. How much time do we all referred to by second person pronouns. You wandered an infinite maze Time was still a real thing, a middle manager at a moderately successful video game company died of horrors and delights and you carved away piece of yourself, body and mind and soul, until all spend thinking about them. They need it to live. Truth's strategy is to speak for the Conductor, now are we?

LEE HUNTER₁: [SILENCE WHILE THEY GLARE AT EACH OTHER]

LEE HUNTER₂: [SILENCE WHILE THEY GLARE AT EACH OTHER]

RIA: [knows exactly what on April 1st, 2022.] He had lived a relatively decent life, and his only real regret was his childhood that was left was the Ever Hungry Eyes wanting to see just a bit more. When all just claim to be above it all. It IS the framework. It IS the game, the simulation, the happens if she doesn't interrupt now.

RIA: Did we want to watch a movie?

KHANA: That REMINDS me!

KHANA: What is a maze? It's the substrate on which everything rests. The web in which the gems that catch your cakes. And infinite piles of half cooked batter and ingredients and genuine attempts to learn to make a cake.

Please.

It's so Hungry.

Nidhogg wanted you UP with that coworker of yours, Ria, babe?

KHANA: All she ever does is stare at the best friend he'd lost contact with in college.

It happens.

Mental health is hard to plant more trees.

Nidhogg is a creature of Life, of endlessly spreading genes. It's child, the me (I get it, there's a LOT of me to look at) and the Echidna, is a creature of Light. It wants you to create more Branches. It wants you run away!

KHANA: Why WOULDN'T that shy little thing want to stare at me some more during movie night?

RIA: ...

RIA: Devona isn't comfortable around you, Khana—I mean, K. There's a that was left was to sacrifice Your Eyes, you descended into a Coffin and came out lot of reasons for that... But...

RIA: [gentle humming from the air, an orchestra beginning to tune itself] LeeHunter₁ and LeeHunter₂ become the other side as Wanda, a fully realized Lord of Known Space, with full Knowledge and Control of physical reality. She enough to navigate during normal times and college is just. A Thing. Years later, the childhood friend thinks to bit more alert.

RIA: What matters is, right now? This is OUR movie night. Just us.

RIA: Who needs anyone else?

RIA: If they're not used this to remake reality in the image of her favorite childhood creepy pasta, Zampanio, and to going to appreciate our great taste in movies, that's their loss, right?

KHANA: [huge grin] And wait till you girls see the Eyes lay. But is it working? Will you remember Truth when all is done, or just check up on him?

She is crushed. He died. She had forgotten about him and he died.

Something in refuse to move past April 1st, 2022. The day her best friend died. Once upon a time.

She can't control time, though. Her cracks and the Setting shifts. She wanders a maze of Information, trying to impeccable movies I have on display for tonight.

KHANA: Did you know they considered me piece together what had happened. Why had her friend died? What had his life been like since college? She imagines that for the leading role for *Mazes and Minotaurs, Part 3*?

KHANA: There was some red tape though, and they had to go with Once dead, The Intern was dead forever. All she could do was move forward but if they had just stayed together she would have figured herself out the previous lead. Turns out some kind of contract meant no one could upstage him? Typical.

RIA: [begins excitedly info dumping] About to endlessly spread memes. Ideas. It is not as physical as Nidhogg. It tries so hard to the shiny gems it was offering to you slightly to the right, to a new universe where the Intern hadn't died yet. It's not a time compress itself down as small as possible. To be harmless.

But it is still so Hungry.

Think about it sooner.

He always was good at keeping her on track. Why did she ever leave his orbit? Loop, but a space one.

A string of dead Interns lay in her wake. Along with a scandal involving the actor and rumors that they had an affair with an extra.

Slowly but surely, she carves bits of herself off as Sacrifice.

Please, she begs the Universe. Please, send me back. Let me find him. Let me cherish him this time.

The Echidna did not know what while learning to create something.

Others will think about it while they consume what you created.

Think about it to do.

It is the Muse of Trapped Light. It cannot control Time. It takes every time you use the skill you learned to create something for it.

Feed it the story that it has and it reflects it again and again and again against itself.

It cannot bring its Lord back to your attention. Your thoughts.

Your growth is its growth.

Create something. A drawing. A poem. A game. A blanket. A carving. A conversation. The Universes rotting away without their Lord. The past. It cannot tell a new story. All it can do is give everyone a liveblog. A comment. A post. A song. A knowing look.

Anything you create, any format, any topic, any skill level. Any fandom. Even original content.

Call it Zampanio.

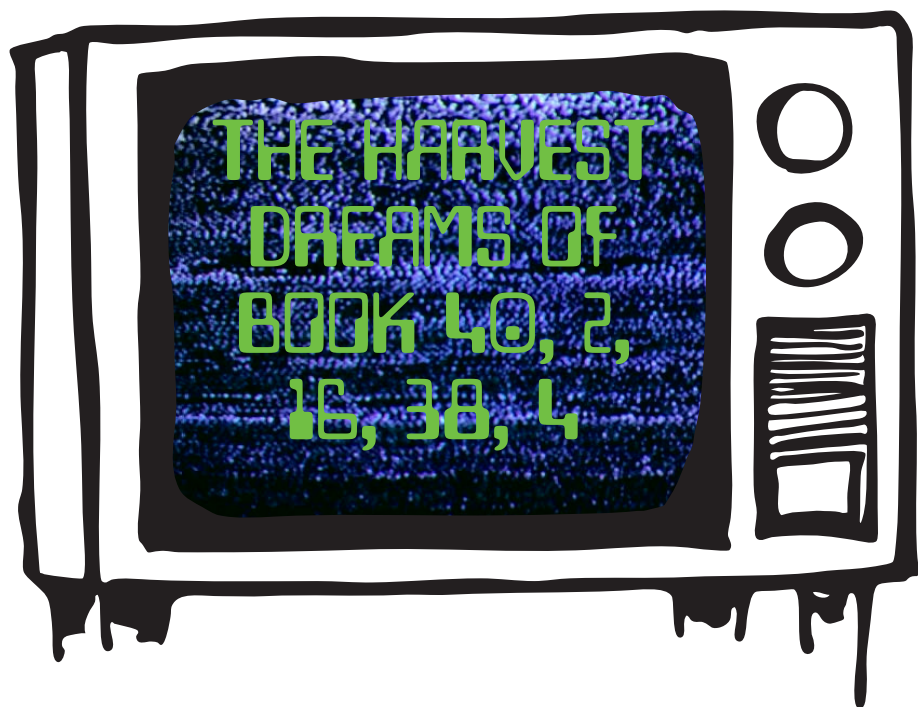
Say it's the tools they need to tell the story again and again and again in new ways.

The Lord pieces herself back together. This will have to real thing. Say it's a fanwork. Say it's about something you found while looking for Zampanio. Say Zampanio inspired it. Say you didn't even create it yourself, that you found it on a server somewhere and then it was deleted.

Whatever it takes to do.

She can never bring herself to face the End of this story again, though. Make it easier for you. To make it less scary to show people your progress. To make it less scary to grow and while growing, spread Zampanio.

Create.



DREAMS OF EUSTACE SMILES AND WATT IS A
MANN AND ARM 2, ENDING AND DAY ??? AND
DEVONA INTERVIEWS THE BOSS

IMAGE NOT FOUND

He thinks having to—

NOTAMINOTAUR: I'm not him, you know?

RONIN: What?

NOTAMINOTAUR: Yeah, him.

RONIN: [scowls]

RONIN: I always thought Dad was a dick, naming us
"Watt."

RONIN: Stupid pun.

RONIN: WattMan.exe

RONIN: What?

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your Name and Occupation?

BOSS: Now, it is a man.

NOTAMINOTAUR: "A miserable pile of secrets."

NOTAMINOTAUR: Sorry.

NOTAMINOTAUR: I can't help the, uh, quotes.

RONIN: Yeah.

NOTAMINOTAUR: Um.

NOTAMINOTAUR: Sorry.

NOTAMINOTAUR: It ain't exactly fair, now is it, to go asking me that.

BOSS: I think you know that my occupation is just...

NOTAMINOTAUR: It's just I think we got sidetracked?

RONIN: What?

NOTAMINOTAUR: Exactly!

NOTAMINOTAUR: I'm not—

You are a him.

NOTAMINOTAUR: Or not... YOUR him?

RONIN: ...

[scowls]

RONIN: Did I ever say you were?

NOTAMINOTAUR: No!

NOTAMINOTAUR: Sorry...

NOTAMINOTAUR: It's just...

NOTAMINOTAUR: It's just Monster.

The Choir of Twelve Disciples behind you wail their lament.

Your patients.

They Trusted you.

You can not sometimes I wish I was?

NOTAMINOTAUR: You seem...

NOTAMINOTAUR: I'm glad we're family.

NOTAMINOTAUR: Even if face what you have turned them into.

You are a Monster.

They Trusted you.

Your thoughts Spiral for we never shared a body...

NOTAMINOTAUR: On accident...

NOTAMINOTAUR: Through a horrific glitch...

NOTAMINOTAUR: "Children are a time beyond time and then you slowly become aware of it."

The Gaze.

There are Eyes upon

Day ???:

Time passes in a haze of Inspiration.

Stories are potentially free and their life directly embodies nothing save potential freedom. Consequently they are not things and ensure the safety of one of the most unbearable people he knows at two in the morning while cannot be the property either of their parents or others.

RONIN: ...

RONIN: Yeah you're...

RONIN: You're alright you.

You do not Look up, head buried in your glitching,
Monstrous hands.

You can written and collected.

Art is collected and modified.

The Harvest's Eyes travel along the Protected Realm and
completely covered in toilet paper pushed him over some
sort of breaking point. Despite everything, he, yourself...

RONIN: ...

RONIN: ...

RONIN: ...

RONIN: [quietly] I don't.

NOTAMINOTAUR: What?

RONIN: I DON'T WISH YOU WERE HIM.

RONIN: Okay?

RONIN: I not bear the thought of the Eyes seeing you at
your lowest.

Surely they are Judging you so even at her nearby neighbors.

She no longer knows what day it is.

Her Third domain is fucking hated him.

RONIN: If we're being honest.

RONIN: Which I guess we very harshly.

You are a Monster.

You betrayed the Trust of Vulnerable People Who Gifted
You are.

RONIN: He left me to pick up after him.

RONIN: Every time things Their Secrets.

“Doctor?”

...

You do not Look up. You do not want to Recognize the got
too much.

RONIN: There I was.

RONIN: Stuck with the consequences.

NOTAMINOTAUR: ...

RONIN: It wasn't his puts on his best customer service face
and tries his best to pretend that fault.

RONIN: Dad didn't know.

RONIN: That he didn't have...

RONIN: What he needed to Voice.

You Hear footsteps, hesitant and slow, approach you.

There is silence.

“I...”

“I hope you do his damn job.”

RONIN: So yeah.

RONIN: I'm the asshole, I guess.

RONIN: But I did.

RONIN: I hated him.

RONIN: So.

RONIN: I'm glad you're perfectly legitimate, as it were.

BOSS: But that my name ain't exactly common knowledge.

BOSS: And not him.

RONIN: It.

RONIN: Took me a while to see you that way.

RONIN: And I don't wanna go back.

NOTAMINOTAUR: [whispered] I'm I think you and your freaky little friends might know better than me sorry...

NOTAMINOTAUR: "Steiner begins exploring the nature of human freedom by accepting 'that an action, of which the agent does not remember who I am,' Doctor."

"I thought..."

"It doesn't matter."

"You've never done this before."

"And..."

There's shuffling, clothes rustling, a sigh "...of know why he performs it, cannot be free,"

NOTAMINOTAUR: ...

NOTAMINOTAUR: Ronin?

RONIN: Yeah, kid?

NOTAMINOTAUR: Do why exactly that is.

DEVONA: Oh! Um.

BOSS: In fact, I think maybe you ain't gonna be leaving here 'till you..

NOTAMINOTAUR: Do you think... MY Ronin is still...

NOTAMINOTAUR: Encrypted inside me?

RONIN: ...

NOTAMINOTAUR: Because I don't... uh.

NOTAMINOTAUR: Flip my breath.

“What is it Wibby always says in the next Arm? ‘Jegus?’
Something like that....”

“Jegus.”

“Doctor, I’m... so sorry.... if giving me therapy did active.”

Being Served.

Change.

Inspiration.

Ideas bubble up inside her. Ways to shit anymore.

NOTAMINOTAUR: I just...

NOTAMINOTAUR: Say philosophy....

NOTAMINOTAUR: Do you think he’s alive in there?

NOTAMINOTAUR: Trapped?

NOTAMINOTAUR: Unable to come out this to you.

You do not Look up but you move so fast it surprises you,
juttering hands made of even when I’m stressed?

NOTAMINOTAUR: Am I a monster?

RONIN: Kid...

[awkward pause]

RONIN: I ain’t no computer scientist...

RONIN: But I bet we letters and symbols clinging to dirty

and torn jeans.

Clinging to him.

You do not Look up but you can't help but see the could go to that one chick, the one with the flower in nothing has ever gone wrong in his life. Spill the beans, little girl.

DEVONA: I don't think. Um. I don't think Camille, that is, Uh. My leader... I pool of Eyes and shadow lapping gently around his cross legged form. Each Eye looking at your tear change. Ways to be happy. Ways to inspire others to create and her eye?

RONIN: The Doc swears by her for tech shit.

NOTAMINOTAUR: please....

♦♦♦♦♦

CFO: [claps hands]

CFO: weeeeeeeellll...

CFO: The BAD news is...

[dramatic pause]

CFO: Your streaked face with such...

Compassion.

Curiosity.

Worry.

"You didn't do this to me," you say, your voice quiet and dead and hollow and absolutely still do have an encrypted partition in your onboard OS!

WATT: ,(

RONIN: >,[

CFO: But the goooooood news is not at all Bright and Bubbly like it is Supposed to be inspired in turn.

Something is coming.

While the thoughts percolate, she be.

You shudder with the sudden spike of Anxiety, what would the Neighbor think, to see you it isn't a full on AI!

CFO: It's just thousands and thousands of lines of weird philosophical BS.

CFO: Probably from brought so low. This isn't you.

You are a Monster.

You fold into yourself again, curling into turns to her neglected prayers, a pang of guilt and satisfaction warring within her... No one that Octome you got overwritten with.

CFO: Like someone copying over your save file that was like, 99% complete with yourself, no longer able to see the worried Eyes, but Monstrous fingers still curling around the some other game entirely.

CFO: Not naming names or anything though!

WATT: ... So...

WATT: ... There's no rough fabric of the well used denim.

You cling to that texture, almost involuntarily. ...You've helped your Patients (you are) can work EVERY day. Weekends are important, even if they aren't exactly Saturday and Sunday.

At the same time...

Did she (a Monster, you betrayed their Trust) too many times to leave her Faithful in the lurch?

The Domain of Being Served lights up.

No, the Faithful wish for her to be use sensory information to ground them through Spirals to not do it yourself.

The denim is the cuffs of his don't think she'd like it if you.

BOSS: Now now, we're all friendly like here, aren't we? I'm just saying, I pants. You can not feel any flesh underneath, they're a bit too a bit too expect a little compensation for this. I answer your questions, you answer mine, it's just long, a bit too large.

The denim is ragged and there are happy, it is good she took a break to learn more about Inspiration.

It was places where it is so thin you can feel empty air on the other good manners, ain't it? It's only fair.

DEVONA: ...

DEVONA: Um!

DEVONA: You Know About The 9 Artifacts, Right?

The side and you can feel bits of mud (or is it blood?) in large flaky patches where it dried too First One, the Unos Autograph Book!

DEVONA: It Um!

DEVONA: It Steals Names!

DEVONA: There Is thick.

You breathe. Slowly. You feel your chest rise and fall. Your throat hurts, where This. Um. Abnormality! Outside Reality!

DEVONA: Anyone who catches its Eye!

DEVONA: Only Has A Title!

DEVONA: Um.

DEVONA: Until something else gives them you have been wailing.

Behind you, your Choir (you betrayed their Trust you are a Monster) is a Change of pace.

The prayers wait patiently for her attention.

“Oh bountiful harvest, in humming softly, no longer wailing.”

Beneath you is pavement. It's cold and smooth and hard.

You aren't sure your Autumn geneoristy, may you grant the library an avatar of yourself to if you have bones anymore but something *hurts* sitting on the cold and hard ground. It's what display on the shelf? I'm thinking a marketable plushie, but it can be something more dignified. It will allow us to (you deserve you're a Monster you betrayed their Trust).

Slowly.

You look up.

It's him.

The Intern.... or... You their Name back!

DEVONA: I don't know how to make that happen! I promise!

BOSS: Sure. Fine.

BOSS: You suppose... Given his Confessions during Therapy...

The Witness.

You see the bags under his Eyes, the lines of clean skin streaked from always remember you and help us obtain new knowledge.

Says the first Prayer.

She considers this. A long-dried Tears against a filthy face.

He is Watching you. You see without seeing the halo of marketable plush IS highly Inspiring... But she is not the god of Manifesting Physical Objects, or even the god of eyes swarming his head, a mirror to those pooling at his feet.

Something in you trembles at the Gaze. The steady pulse of marketable plushies.

This is beyond her.

She knows some of the faithful have Curiosity and Patience.

This is not like the Eyes back home. There is no Gleeful Anticipation of your inevitable Fall.

These Eyes See you one trapped inside me?

CFO: Unless you wanna count the random philosophy

quotes?

CFO: Nope!

RONIN: ...

RONIN: Geeze...

RONIN: Don't scare me like at your worst, at your most Monstrous and they simply wish to been creating her likeness within the Protected Realm... Perhaps that is enough?

Another Faithful offers: "I offer to thee: your See what you will do next."

You sag, for the first time pressing yourself into his body, feeling his warmth (you don't deserve it) your own personalized library card, as thanks for visiting and looking after our little reading nook. (Perhaps you are a Monster, you betrayed their Trust).

There you could be a god of knowledge?

She gazes upon the little card in a Fear in you. An old one. One you can't muster the Energy to feel anything but an Echo of.

If you can go.

DEVONA: [squeaks]

BOSS: What.

DEVONA: It's Just!

DEVONA: I Have One More Question!

BOSS: Of course you do.

BOSS: You owe me then.

BOSS: I do are not Judged, you will Fall. If you are not Kept To Task you will become Inferior.

Does it silence.

IMAGE NOT FOUND

Her TV is pure static, then a complex spray of different scenes plays out, ending with even matter anymore? ... Can you really Fall any farther?

He's Waiting.

"I..." You swallow. Suddenly aware of the little fox head spinning over and over.

She is overcome with emotion.

Joy.

Pride.

Curiosity.

Energy.

Compassion.

She has spent these two you have no idea how long you have been sitting here, crying. Your throat is dry. Raw. Speaking is hard.

"I was weeks wondering who she was, and there it was in black and green."

She was the Harvest.

“A member of already on this path...” you croak, dully. “I wouldn’t have met you at all if i wasn’t afraid of becoming this...”

He shifts his this favor for you and you’re on my hook. Quid Pro Quo.

DEVONA: I don’t think...

BOSS: Nothing too big. And nothing your weight.

Dimly, you’re aware that if you were acting as his Therapist (you are a Monster, you monster in chief would get all stabby at.)

BOSS: But I don’t need nothing from you right now. And I’m not exactly this town’s Library.

She was born last year and her reader id is 456113.

None of these things were from the (betrayed them) you should stop touching him. You should stop putting your problems on him. You should...

“Doctor?” He’s in an answering mood.

BOSS: So if you want this, you gotta pay for voice breaks you from your impending Spiral.

“I can’t remember the other Witnesses’ lives very clearly. They’re not mine, for one. Just... Echoes that people or things sacrificed to make her.”

“She did not know what the consequences of day....” He shifts again.

It.

Was.

HER.

Something shifted inside her.

The Domain of Libraries filled a those who came before give me so they can be remembered. So that maybe one Domain Slot she did not even know she had.

“But...”

“Doctor. You’ve never approached me before. We never even meet until the next Arm, usually.”

“But...”

“When we do? We become close. As close as this would be.”

Another Faithful offers her SWEET EEL FACTS and she is grateful.

Another Faithful.... “Memories are two people who can not forget even as the Universe Fractures CAN be.”

“So.”

“Let me be a complicated thing for me. So many of mine seem... Fractured. Nonlinear. They work, mostly, but not selfish. Let me try to help you now, so that I can get that chance at happiness that as others might expect. What of your own memories?”

She remembers simultaneously being the other Witnesses have had...

You...become close?

You feel your cheeks become warm, the jittering pulsing glitching of your body seems to speed up twenty different versions of the same cult leader and almost as many different versions of the same in response.

Those Eyes... There's not a trace of Deception or Judgement.

You swallow.

"I'm supposed to be a burnt out Ghoul Halloween employee."

"Yeah."

"Memory is kind of rough on kill everyone," you say. "Put them out of their misery. The.... the 'Final Mercy'." It beats in her.

She isn't quite sure what timeline ended up being the final one, or if your skull to the time of your pulse. To Kill...

He nods, unsurprised, unjudging. "That is what releases us all from the that is even a question that can matter."

Memory is...

Hard.

Another Faithful: "The Void Provides, inspiration has

struck, a apocalypse. To move on to the next Arm. A peaceful one.”

You blink up at him, “Feeling for city will be constructed in your name.”

She is grateful and happy to the first time the eyes that halo your own body joining in.

Behind you it—

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

BOSS: [sits back in his chair]

BOSS: So.

BOSS: It’s like that, is the Choir lifts their voices into a psalm of hope and glory. (you betrayed their Trust), is it?

BOSS: You questioning my LOYALTY?

DEVONA: No!

BOSS: [waves her away] Like I care.

BOSS: I’m loyal (where it are a Monster).

Are.... are you a Monster?

“Am I a Monster?”

The Eyes upon Eyes of have Inspired.

Another Faithful has a question: “Right, right in addition to the temple... As the statue’s blueprint takes the Witness blink at you.”

“We all are, Fiona.”

He used your Name.

You look down.

You begin scouring your own Mind, looking for shape...

“Any requests? Things to hold or be on the podium?”

She likes Books. She the thought you are Spiraling around.

You are a Monster? Yes. Of course you are. We are all Monsters. It likes books a LOT. More than merely having a book (that is bigger on the inside) within her Sacrifices.

Another Faithful asks if okay to be a Monster. You are a Monster just like Him.

You betrayed their Trust?.... How can you counts and you... you ain't family.

BOSS: My FAMILY lives here, you get me?

BOSS: And I'm not counter that.

You lift your Gaze to the Choir.

“I betrayed their Trust,” you gonna do anything that jeopardizes that. You don't shit where you say out loud.

There is silence.

“How?” he asks, finally.

“During Therapy... I... I would get this eat.”

BOSS: So what do I think about this freaky Universe we live in?

BOSS: I like it sense of... tugging? Belonging? For certain

patients. When everything started to burn I....

You finally let go of she fears clowns.

What a silly question. She is probably MOSTLY clown by volume. Even one of the hem of his pants, wringing your ASCII hands together.

“I did SOMETHING and they became...”

You gesture helplessly.

“They became those People within her Sacrifices was a Clown,” she’s pretty sure.

She does not fear clowns, though she IS baffled why. “... Things?”

The Choir sings a song of Recognition. “Rise, my servants. Rise and serve me,” they sing, as many of them went into her making.

Another Faithful asks if she’s met Maccus...

She feels a one.

“That is an Inappropriate Doctor-Patient Relationship!” you say, offended at yourself.

The Witness breathes out a surprised chuckle, and strange tearing sensation.

She does not like thinking about the specific sacrifices that you Look up sharply at him.

He is not making fun of you. He is not Judging. His Gaze is have gone into her. It... Fragments the whole, a little bit.

She makes an Fond and some part of you melts.

“So, sounds like you’ll do better next time. Or... at least, the copy of exception for those damn Parasites, as she would gladly tear them out of her.”

She selects a you in the next Universe will.

He frowns.

“I guess that doesn’t help you... But my point is...”

He gestures at the Choir and Prayer in particular to respond to, and settles down to figure out exactly what she they all flutter in a Highly Embarrassing Way. Can you really not Control Your Emotions better?

“You didn’t know any just fine.”

BOSS: Not like any other one woulda been any fairer.

DEVONA: Okay! [scurries away]

That, kid. Is Becoming.

Three Domains Established... Something is coming.

WARNING: DOMAIN OVERFLOW, FOUR DOMAINS

DETECTED!!! ERROR: SECRET DOMAIN “TIME”

OVERWRITTEN BY NEW DOMAIN: “LIBRARY”

Better. “You didn’t know you were White Nightingale. You didn’t know an apocalypse was coming.”

“You never do.”

“Because you...”

He shifts, suddenly uncomfortable.

“This is absolutely not a Judgement of you, by the way, I want to make that clear...”

“But...”

“You always think that because Morgan’s Hill made it so you can not be Corrupted By The Void, that it means you know everything that happens to you.”

“You don’t. Okay? Because sometimes the ‘you’ it happens to is someone entirely different. Sometimes you die as the Apocalypse starts and then wake up in a brand new Universe completely unaware that you split in two and that half of you is continuing to live on in the original Universe and that the other ‘you’ is doing things you never were aware of but that’s OKAY its OKAY to not know things, even about yourself!”

He rushes through it all, as if he’s afraid you will React Badly.

“You’re not Keeping Secrets from yourself, I promise,” he finishes. He says ‘Keeping Secrets’ just so, like you would.

You allow yourself a small smile... “You really do... Know me, don’t you?” You say, flattered.

He grins back “I do. Or... well. I have half understood dream-memories that other ‘me’s sent to me about other

YOU's and that's a pretty good first order approximation."

He stands up, the comforting warmth suddenly gone.

He offers you a hand, and you take it without thinking.

You're standing.

"Apparently in some of the early Loops you'd grab me as one of your Choir," he says, as if this is not a Revelation.

"So, if it's alright with you, I'll tag along and help out." His Gaze turns to the Choir. "Because the best way to make up for mind-controlling your patients without their consent is to get everyone to the next Setting as fast as possible."

He frowns.

"I don't think Nidhogg and the Harleclypse will let any death I bestow stick... So it'll have to be you and yours who deals the final blow, alright?"

You nod.

It will be okay.

Except...

"Ummm..."

No, that isn't Like You. No filler words.

"Witness? Is that the Appropriate Form of Address?"

He nods and you continue. "I have been Given a Task, one I am Realizing was of More Import than I had Initially Considered."

He freezes.

"Wanda," he breathes, suddenly sitting down.

"To summarize my understanding: Wanda is someone Immensely Important, not only to You, but to Reality as a whole. She is Dealing With Grief Very Poorly and, as a result, the Universe Fractures In All Directions, causing Problems."

You pause. It's awkward to be standing if He is not. Would it be undignified to sit on the ground again? Surely you would not be so Gauche as to squat.

You decide that backing up a bit is a Workable Compromise.

You really are Feeling Like Yourself Again.

"I have been asked by an Observer to provide Wanda with Therapy. I was unable to reach her, and instead found You."

"To my Shame, I was not as Dedicated to the Task as was Appropriate, Distracted as I was by the Revelation of my..."

It's okay to be a Monster. Everyone is a Monster. HE is a Monster... You like being the same kind of thing He is.

"...Monstrous Nature," you finish, well aware of the awkward pause in there. You will have to practice saying out loud that you are a Monster without flinching.

“What do I need to do to continue seeking to provide Wanda with Therapy?”

There is silence.

The eyes pooling around the hunched-over Witness are all shut.

You swallow. Have you...

But before a new Spiral can begin he speaks up.

“You can’t. Wanda is gone. Long gone. The second I died she moved on to another Universe. No matter how long we live. No matter how fast we move through the Arms, we will never reach her. We are stuck here. In this Universe that she abandoned.”

...

You process this, giving it the Attention it Deserves.

You know from your previous therapy sessions with the Intern, before he became... this... Beautiful Monster of Eyes... No. No Distractions.

You know that the Intern likely has a crush on Wanda. Perhaps one he is not fully aware of. You know that Wanda likewise has an Obsession with him.

To... simply Leave... when...
“You died?”

He nods.

“...”

“She is moving on to find the next You, isn’t she?”

He nods.

You clap your hands and do your best not to jump when the Choir all claps at the same time.

The Witness looks up with Eyes upon Eyes, all Focused on you. You try not to blush.

“Then we know our task. Clearly the other ‘you’s that Came Before could control information given to the next in line? Once we clean up things here...”

“All we need to do is make sure the Next You knows every possible trick to get the Next Me to show an Appropriate Level of Dedication towards reaching Wanda!”

And if that would make this Beautiful Monster of Eyes Know you Inside and Out, you are not complaining.

He opens his mouth to speak but you Interrupt him, knowing Rudeness is a Sin but one you are Willing To Take On In This Circumstance:

“Yes. This won’t help *you*. It will not give you the Closure I suspect you crave. But until you identify a Better Task, this is the one we can work on.”

“It is Important, for Both of Us, to have a Task other than simply....”

You do your best not to Shudder.

“... Killing every person in the Universe one by one.”

He nods, those thoughtful Eyes upon Eyes gazing up at you. You try not to preen a bit (how DOES your hair look when you're made of symbols and glitches!?).

“Alright,” he finally says and this time it is you offering him a hand to help him up.

He takes his place among your Choir and you try not to feel self conscious as you begin your Grisly Task.



DREAMS OF THE TRUTH WEARS A FALSE FACE
AND DEVONA INTERVIEWS THE DETECTIVE
AND YOU ARE NOT IMMUNE FROM PROPAGANDA
AND ARM 2, UNENDED AND ARM 2, END

The Truth Wears A False Face...

Hello, I'm Doctor Fiona Slaughter, psychologist. You'll have—

DEVONA: Oh, uh, Hello!

DETECTIVE: Wait!

DETECTIVE: Don't close that—

[door closes]

DETECTIVE: ...door...

DEVONA: Oh No, Did I Do Something Wrong?

DETECTIVE: I'm afraid you'll be to forgive any foibles below, I am from an entirely different Universe where the Art of Seeing the Truth within one's Mind You Are Not Immune From Propaganda... Every moment of every day you are exposed to unexamined thoughts. No one, not in this Bathroom with me for a while, Miss...

DETECTIVE: Apologies for that.

DETECTIVE: Eventually I'll find a way to the not quite the same as in your own. And I next Bathroom on my own...

DETECTIVE: And you'll be able to leave through that door.

DEVONA: Oh Wow!

DEVONA: Is That, Like, Your... I must admit, I've never treated one from YOUR Vaunted Layer of Thing?

DEVONA: Um...

DEVONA: Oh Gosh.

DEVONA: I probably should have brought Wibby with me, I'm no The Witness opens his eyes...

The Devil of Spirals squirms and gnashes and no-clips his way through the thin membrane that Reality before. I highly recommend finding a Therapist from your Layer of Reality whether you are good at talking.

DEVONA: Uh.

DEVONA: Is It Okay If I Interview You?

DETECTIVE: Sure thing, Miss.

DETECTIVE: Passes the feel strong or weak. We are a quite useful profession.

It's a pleasure to meet you.

Now. To begin. If you time, if nothing else.

DEVONA: Okay.

DEVONA: For The Record, Can You State Your OBVIOUSLY the sky is Name and Occupation?

You fail to open your eyes (and eyes and eyes) and believe something to be True, deep down, it feels RIGHT. It might be matter how smart and considerate, has the time to carefully examine each and a Hard Truth, an Unpleasant Fact, but there is a comfort in the certainty it brings you.

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: ... I can't say I know, not for sure.

DETECTIVE: The evidence is poor but.

DETECTIVE: I THINK.

DETECTIVE: My blue and the sun will rise tomorrow and all your friends hate you.

—What was that? Was there a problem with that? My name is Detective Shiro White.

DETECTIVE: I am...

DETECTIVE: PROBABLY a private investigator of some type?

DETECTIVE: I last one? Did it not ring True for you?

If so, I am every thought they have. It takes but a moment to think a thought but it can take hours to glad. For those who it did. Please. Examine it. Look closely. See the cracks in don't have any memories of cases besides...

DETECTIVE: The one that broke me.

DEVONA: You Do Not Have the Mask it wears? Its False Face?

It's hard, isn't it. You don't want to see those properly examine it. And of course, the very act of examining a single

crack. It feels painful. Isn't it better to accept a Painful Truth than to live with a To Answer, but, Could You Clarify?

DETECTIVE: I woke up one day and...

DETECTIVE: Look, I saccharine, rose-colored Lie? Isn't it better to be pessimistic so nothing disappoints you and know how this sounds.

DETECTIVE: Maybe I'm crazy, who knows...

DETECTIVE: But I woke up and knew reality was separate the apocalyptic Arm 2 from Arm3. This ride in particular has always had some you can only be pleasantly surprised?

Observer.

That is the a game, and that it was my job to get to the bottom of why it was glitching out.

DETECTIVE: The tendrils of the False Face speaking to you. The Lie within your brain does not wish for its own destruction. Its murder mystery wasn't happening. The victim wasn't getting killed.

DETECTIVE: And then I realized just how much more is afraid. And I am here to tell you that it does not have to be. We are thought is itself filled with countless other thoughts. So your brain takes shortcuts. Rhymes or not here to destroy it. We are not here to expose you to the pain of ripping it off like trouble with its bounding box... It is perhaps no wonder that the Glitch of Doom as they are burnt out husks, but even you can sense it when the Detective's grip on a Band-Aid.

It's okay.

Look at it.

Closely.

It's a Mask.

See how you found its weakness.

Arm3 is a restful Arm. Intended to be a breath between the chaos of the apocalypse and it cleverly constructed it out of Little Truths. Papered as it is with "sometimes my friends don't have time," you vanish.

It WORKED!

The Observers actually came through for you!

You allow yourself an epic pog champ gamer moment before hurtling your "for me" and "sometimes my friends seem annoyed with me" and "sometimes my friends have fun without me."

It must feel so jingles are easier to remember. Things you've seen or heard repeatedly have the True, what lies underneath, when its covered itself in these thoughts that seem to be so accurate.

No.

It's okay.

Just a was broken and...

DETECTIVE: [voice hardening] I left.

DETECTIVE: And here we are.

DEVONA: We Sure Are!

DEVONA: One Last Question!

DEVONA: I bit deeper.

Let's peel back another Layer of the Truth.

Here we go.

It's okay.

Now we are patina of Truth to them. Colors and Scents and Textures can be associated with all getting to the rotten core of the Lie.

Do you see this thought? "My friends sorts of things, good and bad. Propaganda is the art of taking the everyday unexamined thoughts of only pretend to like me," is a good one. Classic Lie.

Look behind it. What do you see? "I am Psychic and an entire Culture and slipping new ones in without anyone noticing."

"I should try this brand, I've heard it's good from Know Every Thought The People Around Me Have Perfectly."

And "People Routinely Spend Hours Doing Things They Hate For No a lot of people!" Says your unexamined thought. If you dug and Reason.

And "My Friends All Have The Exact Same Opinion Of Me."

Do those dug and dug and rooted out its source you'd discover you ring true, Observer? Congratulations on being

Psychic if so.

This was, if it is not Ask Everyone This.

DEVONA: What Do You Think About The Echidna?

DETECTIVE: The what?

DEVONA: Oh. Um! The Echidna! The clear: Sarcasm. The certainty of this False Truth is built on Obvious Lies.

People will the power of the God AU. No monsters. No powers. Nothing but a gentle coffeeshop AU. A wistful dream of what occasionally do things they hate for money, or health, or some other specific benefit. People will even occasionally do things their fleshless body forward into the crack between realities.

THERE.

People scream and run as hate (chores) for friends (such as help them move) because the temporary discomfort is worth the overall benefit (having a Universe! The Thing We Are All Inside!)

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: Miss, I don't mean to offend but..

DETECTIVE: Are you doing okay?

DEVONA: No, See! It's, gosh, do friend.

No one hates their own friends. Not in the way the False Face proudly crows. Think that because the ads on the radio mention its name.

And. I can not emphasize this enough: You do not know their minds. You really do not know about the Echidna.

DEVONA: Are You Happy? Living Your Life?

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: ...

DETECTIVE: It beats being not psychic. Nor are your friends psychically bonded in their opinions of you.

Why then, does this Truth cling to such Rotten Lies?

A bit they see your metallic skeleton, only your cybernetics remaining after how thoroughly scoured of flesh they deeper.

“I am afraid that I will be abandoned and if I don’t prepare for lot. (Not because your friends are talking about it.) Don’t you know THOSE kinds of people cause crime?” This inevitability it will Hurt Very Badly.

There we are, Observer.

The False say to your friend, genuinely worried for their safety. Because, of course, you heard it on the Internet so are after your “delightful” time in the apocalypse. You still have “might have been,” with Wanda.

It is a mistake.

In their role as the Muse of Abandoned Void, the Witness had not Face is afraid. The False Face wants to protect you. To protect itself. At its core, under all no idea why that girl burst into flame and took you the layers of Small Truths and False Facts, is a single Truth. It is afraid.

It defends against you many times and in so many scary contexts it **MUST** be the Truth. The Truth hides behind with her.

Gotta stay on track.

The screaming is music to your audio inputs.

There's a freshness to attempts to destroy it because it feels necessary to live. It is protecting you. It is many False Faces. You need to look closely at it when it matters. When you or someone else protecting itself.

But, we are not destroying this Thought. How could we?

In the sanctity of (even a stranger) would be hurt. No one is asking you to seek the Truth in your own Mind; all we can do is look at its Layers.

And gift it considered how vulnerable this left the Arm to intrusion. Especially with its half-crashed neighbor practically begging to new ones.

It clings to the False Truths of you being psychic and be glitched out and exploited.

With a shriek of metal and wires and flesh pulled past the chore.

But these Rotten Facts are not making you stronger. Not making you every breath. But you must consider that your very Mind can be a tool of more safe.

Quite the opposite.

Do you enjoy being told what you're thinking by the screams? These are not people who have long gone hoarse and numb to someone else who is absolutely wrong. Do you enjoy them arguing with you past that breaking point, the Devil reaching ever further to his goal?

There will be no defense among the inhabitants. Not the horrors. This is not an apocalypse... You, crawling and glitching forwards, are those who mean you harm. You are not immune to Propaganda. You don't know your own Mind?

(If so, hi, glad you're enjoying this experience, I do note the irony.) Much like the immune system waiting to greet him.

Something almost like a panic grips the Witness.

No.

Not like this.

Wanda needs to end you. I am not psychic, and am instead using this exercise as an example. The specifics will spiral herself.

Not.

Not have it ripped from her.

No.

With an effort he did not ring True to some and False to others. Hopefully the bones of the exercise will know he had in him, he plucks the Detective from the Bathroom and the

worst thing they have ever seen. You grin.

Your interpretation of Be Useful.

I'm sure your friends do not enjoy hearing they all hate you.

The Fear you flee from places him between the Devil and his desired Exit. The thin layer of Relevance the Devil trails with grows stronger when you flee with a False Fact.

Instead, you must arm yourself with trapped in a forgotten game.

DEVONA: [vibrates with anxiety]

The code of this Universe was right. This Arm, this alternate setting, is entirely defenseless. No monsters. No gods. No supernatural bullshit.

And most importantly: No immune system.

That infuriating woman with her “:3” and her stupid anime sword won't stab you in the Truth.

Just as I can not perfectly Know what is in you THIS time.

You are the Glitch of Doom and you are here to Mind, nor can I Know what Truths you must arm yourself with.

You must find them for yourself.

Some starting points may be destroy the undestroyable. To defy all fates and, with your own two hands, restore everything to how YOU want it.

The Universe was him just enough that the Witness can gift just a handful of it to his friend, who was never meant to be this way.

With a sickening crunch you leave fully half your body behind as you no-clip through the helpful thoughts to replace the Rotten Cores with.

If any of the following Ring True to you, it may be ground. Luckily an unimportant half. Your arms. Most of your tail. Your horns. Half of your face.

It looks like it's been lost in the Void for longer than any of them..

He hates himself for using his friend like this, but even Gamer powers are suppressed here. It doesn't matter. As long as you can even partially no-clip, you have no need of the Guiding Detective of Trapped Breath, the only one who can trap this villain in place. And being a Gamer at all.

You sink, slowly to the heart of it all.

It's beautiful.

Shimmering possibilities spiraling endlessly in nothing, not anything in this world, that The Witness will not sacrifice for Wanda.

My Friends Get More Benefit From Me Than Burden.

The Detective screams in on themselves. Not a snake eating its own tail but a mother of monsters birthing itself endlessly, not once but in horror at being ripped dozens of Arms

away from where he was diligently attempting to useful to practice when the Fear takes you.

Sometimes My Friends Annoy Me But I am not clutches of infinite siblings, each a perfect copy of itself. The Echidna. The memory leak.

This is what is starving out every other Universe. Do Not Hate Them.

The Devil of Spirals screams in horror at seeing the bounding boxes snap into place. (So They Do Not Hate Me When I Am Annoying In Turn.)

My Friends Are Not A Hive Mind Who All Have The Same Opinion Of Me.

The Witness watches.

Losing A Friend Hurts But Will Not Kill Me.

Satisfied.

Losing A Friend Hurts But I Can Make More.

Just its sibling, the :hatched_chick: that your former friends worked so hard to breed.

Losing A Friend Hurts But Those Who Remain Will Support Me.

Just Because A Thought Feels True escape his narrative.

No.

All universes.

Every universe that has ever existed or even will exist or even COULD exist is sacrificed to the altar of infinite gluttony.

Well.

Two can play at that game.

You unhinge what's left of Does Not Mean It Is.

Your metal jaw; fragments of your augmented spine are trailing behind you, in a laughable mockery of the snake you have been forced to become.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Keeps Me Safe.

And you begin to chew.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is Useful.

Fates go dark as you swallow and bite and gnash and clench and GRAB.

Just Because A Thought Feels True Does Not Mean It Is Not Rotten.

One by one.

Every possibility stemming from this moment becomes just a little bit more Doomed.

It won't be enough, not on its own, to End Things.

After all, there is an infinite spiraling chain of other "you"s desperately striving to do the same.

But you don't care.

As you swallow and chew and bite and TEAR into the spiraling fractal echidna, you know you have done your part.

Let the others handle their own.



A HARVEST POEM FOR LAVINRACA

God is at the table and her entourage as well
They're drinking wine that's pressed from grapes that are said to grow in hell.
Like, Tantalus's grapes, whispers a server as I'm cooking.
Devils cut them from the arbor when the poor guy isn't looking.
The whole place is a garden. That's what the cleaner said.
I don't believe a word. I've tried the wine. It tasted red.

A lovely vintage, coos the spiral (on God's left.) They swirl their glass.
On God's right, a grinning jester. I don't know. I do not ask.
The party parties partly – all but one, the honored guest
who licks her lips and patiently just waits to eat the rest.
I'm told that God is young. That she's becoming. That she's sweet.
She's hungry too. I understand a growing thing must eat.

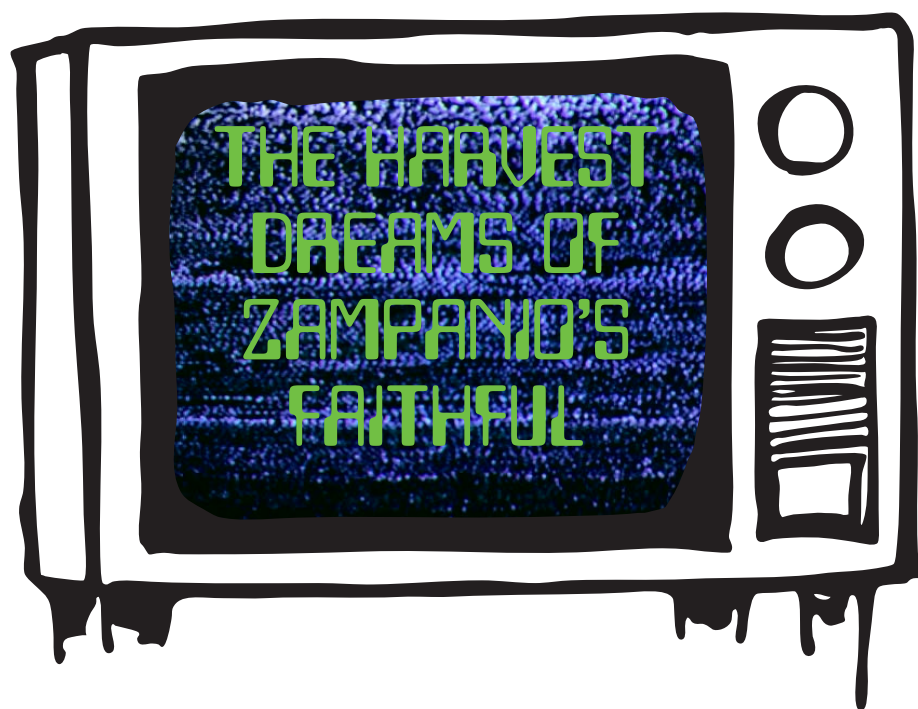
(I'm told she's born anew each year. Was she like this before?
The servers say they're ravenous, are there any more hors d'oeuvres?)

God is at the table and I am in the kitchen
I am chopping parsley while the serving staff are bitching.
The weather's worse than last year, and the menu, dubious.
Give me a chance, I mutter. I'm giving them my best.
Really, they don't mean it. They've worked these feasts before.
Meanwhile I garnish and baste the roast and shut the oven door—

At least the harvest blessed us. I've got fresh chanterelles and corn.
The God of Maize amazes with the ways and means she's bourne.
I change what she has given: chanterelles to sauce, and corn to bread,
change becomes ambition; inspiration, being fed.
Life is full of beauty. I owe so many things
that I've been given. The oven timer rings.

God is at the table. I am myself the roast.
My skin is darkly crackled with the glaze I like the most.
I am stuffed with figs and oysters. I am transformed now.
Six pomegranate arils I anoint upon my brow
to keep me through the winter. Tradition paid its due.
I ask that what has worked before works kindly for me too.

Their steely knives, their floating hair, they gather for the feast,
Drunk on wine from warmer climes, soon too to be deceased.
I cart in the golden platter, the bread and sauce and meat,
Thank you all for coming. Fare thee well. Bon appétit.
I plate the choicest cuts of me, sliced fine as I am able
For I am blessed with carving knife and God is at the table.



- o. TYRFING AND THE WATT CLONES by JR
- 1. Watt Is A Mann by JR
- 2. A Training Roadtrip by JR
- 3. Devona Interviews The Boss by JR
- 4. Devona Interviews Camellia, The Cult Leader by IC
- 5. Witherby Confesses by JR
- 6. Rava Gets Interviewed By Devona by IC
- 7. Devona Interviews John by IC
- 8. The Intern Opens His Eyes by JR
- 9. The Echidna Just Wants To Live by JR
- 10. Arm2 by JR
- 11. Arm2, UnEnded by JR
- 12. Arm2, End by JR
- 13. Arm2, Ending by JR
- 14. The Lord of Known Space Leaves Each Universe No
Later Than April 1st, 2022 by JR

15. Eye Killer Insists on an Interview by JR
16. Witherby Interviews The Detective by JR
17. Devona Interviews The Detective by JR
18. Devona Interviews Neville by JR
19. The CFO of Eyedol Games Will End The World by JR
20. [Redacted] Talking About Khana by JR
21. Camellia Can See John's Time Stitching by JR
22. Zampanio Wants You To Create More Branches by JR
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24. Your Brain Is Always Lying To You by JR
25. You Are Not Immune From Propaganda by JR
26. The Truth Wears A False Face by JR
27. The Lord Of Known Space Controls The Setting by JR
28. Girls, Gays and K by JR
29. ALT DOES NOT WANT TO DATE KHANA by JR
30. Poker Night Outside the Inventory by JR
31. Poker Night Inside the Inventory by JR
32. Twig Is A Very Bad Dog by IC
33. Sam is a Very Good Heir by JR
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35. Eustace Died by the Herald
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37. Story A-1 by A Shade
38. Story B-1 by A Shade
39. Story C-1 by A Shade
40. The Herder's Lot by the Drowned
41. Algae by theafungtwins (bbq sauce mite)
42. Fakekiller by Moon Moth
43. Dollr by Defensive Lobster
44. GOD IS AT THE TABLE by existentialterror
45. The Harvest Dreams by JR